

MSc in Cybersecurity Engineering

Embedded Operating Systems and Architecture

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1 What Is an Embedded System

The word *system* comes from physics: a system is a set of elements inside a boundary. Everything inside the boundary is the system; everything outside is its *environment*. To describe an embedded system, the first step is therefore to decide what is inside the boundary (components, functions) and what is outside (the physical world it observes and controls).

There is no single official definition of an embedded system. Three common definitions stress different aspects, and together they give a complete picture.

View	Definition	Key idea
Hardware and software	Hardware plus software (*firmware*) built into it	The software cannot be written without knowing the hardware
Dedicated computer	A system based on a microcontroller or microprocessor that performs one specific task	Hardware and software are designed together for one job
Cyber-physical system	Computer hardware, software, and physical parts that perform a dedicated function	The computer interacts with the physical world

The third view explains what an embedded system usually does. *Sensors* measure physical quantities such as temperature, speed, or pressure. The processor runs the firmware and computes a response. *Actuators* turn that response into a physical action, such as moving a motor, opening a valve, or changing a display. Many embedded systems are also connected to other systems through a network.

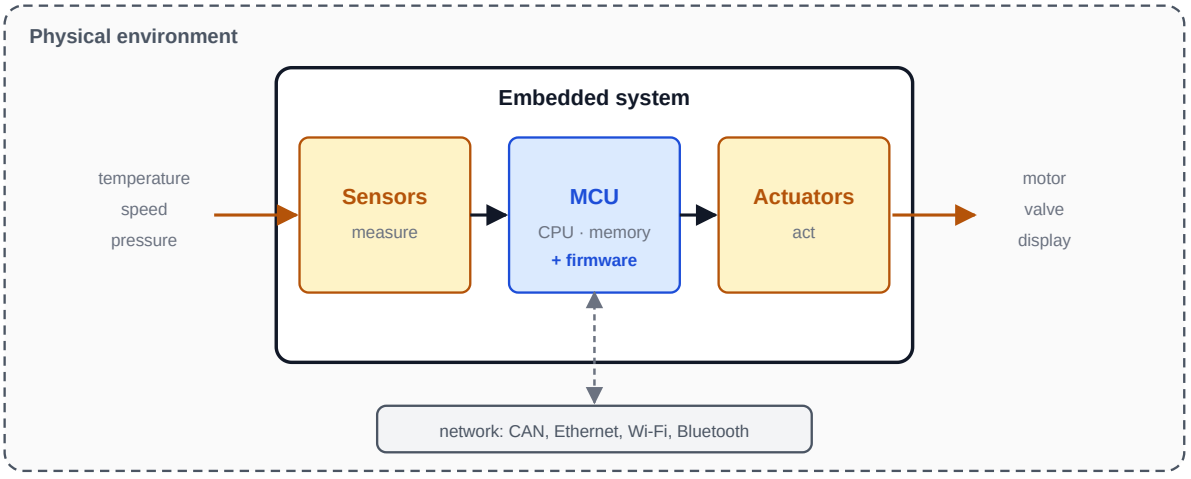


Figure 0.1: *An embedded system inside its environment. Sensors bring physical quantities in, the microcontroller runs the firmware, and actuators act on the world. A network may connect it to other systems.*

1.1 Classes of Embedded Systems

Embedded systems are used in very different fields, so they are classified in several ways. The three most useful classes are based on autonomy, timing, and connectivity. They are not exclusive: a car's brake controller is both real-time and networked.

Class	Main property	Example
Standalone	Works alone, without a network	Early washing machines, microwave ovens, thermostats
Real-time	Must complete each task before a deadline	Electronic brake control, drone stabilisation
Networked	Exchanges data with other nodes over a network or field bus	Engine, brake, and lighting controllers on a car's CAN bus

1.2 Embedded Versus General-Purpose Computers

A general-purpose computer, such as a laptop, runs any program the user installs, supports many users and tasks, and has plenty of memory and power. An embedded system runs one fixed job and works under strict limits.

Aspect	Embedded system	General-purpose computer
Workload	One fixed task	Anything the user installs
Resources	KB to a few MB of RAM and Flash	GB of RAM, TB of disk
Timing	Often hard deadlines	Best effort
User model	No interactive user, no shell	Multi-user, multi-tasking
Power and cost	Milliwatts, cents to a few euros	Tens to hundreds of watts, hundreds of euros

These limits change how software is written. Embedded software cannot rely on an operating system to create a process, assign an address space, discover devices, or provide standard input and output. It is built for one known processor and one known memory map. The hardware details are visible and cannot be ignored, but this does not make the software simple: the developer must handle many tasks that a desktop OS normally hides.

The border between the two worlds is becoming less sharp. The same processor families, especially ARM, now range from tiny sensor nodes to smartphones, laptops, and cloud servers.

1.3 A Short History

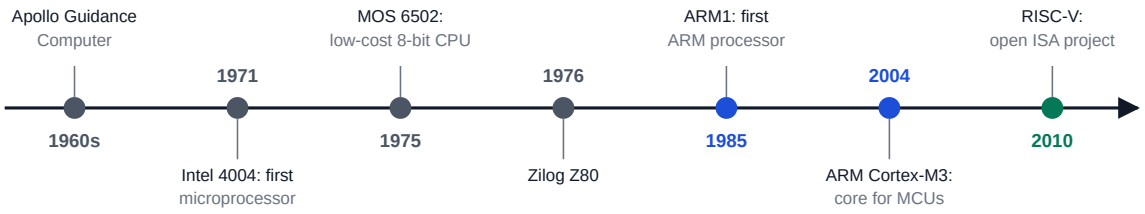


Figure 0.2: *Milestones of embedded computing, from the Apollo Guidance Computer to the open RISC-V instruction set (not to scale).*

The Apollo Guidance Computer, built in the 1960s for NASA's Moon missions, is often cited as one of the first true

embedded systems: a computer designed for one task and built into a vehicle. The first single-chip microprocessor, the Intel 4004 (1971), was designed by the Italian engineer Federico Faggin. Low-cost 8-bit processors such as the MOS 6502 and the Zilog Z80 followed in the 1970s and brought programmable control into consumer products.

Today the embedded market is dominated by ARM, whose low-power cores range from microcontrollers to servers. The Cortex-M3, introduced in 2004, is one of ARM's first cores designed specifically for microcontrollers. RISC-V is a newer alternative: its instruction set architecture (ISA) is open, so anyone can build compatible processors without paying licence fees.

Embedded technologies also have a long lifecycle. A satellite or an industrial machine may use the same processor for ten or twenty years, because replacing it is impossible or too expensive. Reliability and long-term support often matter more than performance.

2 Design Constraints of Embedded Systems

Embedded systems are designed under constraints that rarely matter on a desktop. Each one shapes both the hardware and the software.

Constraint	Why it matters	Example
Real-time	Results must arrive before a deadline	A brake controller must react within a few milliseconds
Size and weight	Extra mass costs energy and space	A heavier controller shortens a drone's flight time
Cost	Small extra costs multiply over millions of units	A 50-cent security chip rejected for a car because of the total cost
Energy	Many devices run on batteries	A wearable or remote sensor must last months on one battery
Reliability and safety	Failures can damage machines or hurt people	Medical devices and robots must *fail safe*
Development time	Low-level code is slow to write and test	Hardware debugging and testing in all operating conditions

Fail safe means that when a fault is detected, the system moves to a controlled and predictable state instead of acting in an uncontrolled way. In a safety-critical system, every failure scenario must be considered at design time.

2.1 Real-Time Means Bounded Response

Real-time does not mean fast. A real-time system guarantees a *bounded and predictable* response time: every reaction to an event must complete before its deadline. A correct embedded system must therefore meet three kinds of requirements.

Requirement	Example
Functional	Sample a sensor correctly
Temporal	Sample it every 1 ms, before the deadline
Robustness	Continue safely when one input is missing

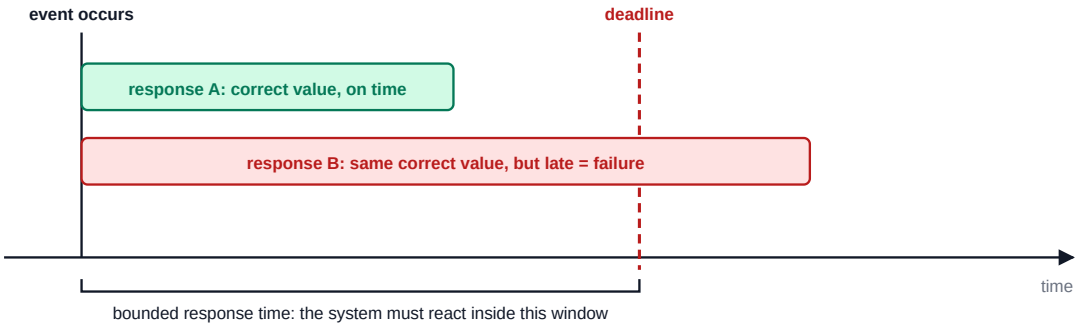


Figure 0.3: *Two responses to the same event. Both compute the correct value, but only the first arrives before the deadline; the second is a failure.*

In a *hard* real-time system, missing a deadline is a failure of the system, as in a braking controller. In a *soft* real-time system, a late result is still useful but lowers the quality of service, as in video playback.

> ⚠ **CORRECT VALUE, WRONG TIME**
>
> A result computed after its deadline can be a failure even if its value is correct. A fast system is not necessarily a real-time system, because average speed says nothing about the worst case.

3 Inside the Hardware: Processor, Memory, and Buses

A computer has four basic parts: the central processing unit (CPU), memory, input units, and output units. An embedded developer works much closer to these parts than an application developer does, so a basic model of each is needed.

3.1 The CPU and the Pipeline

A CPU repeats the same cycle forever: it *fetches* an instruction from memory, *decodes* it to find out what to do, and *executes* it. Inside the CPU, the *control unit* drives this cycle, the *arithmetic logic unit* (ALU) performs arithmetic and logic operations, and *registers* hold the values being processed. Registers are the fastest storage in the system, and a few of them have special roles: the program counter, the stack pointer, and the status register.

Modern CPUs overlap these steps with a *pipeline*. Each step is handled by a different part of the hardware, so while one instruction executes, the next one is decoded and a third one is fetched, like cars in a car wash with one worker per station.

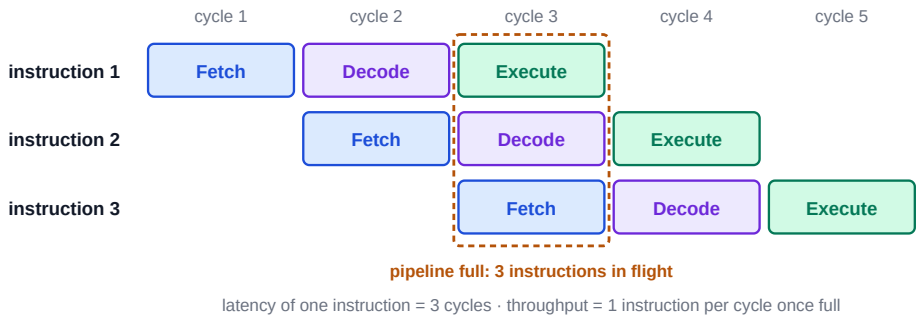


Figure 0.4: *A three-stage pipeline. From cycle 3 on, three instructions are in flight and one instruction completes every cycle.*

With n stages of duration t, a single instruction still needs $n \cdot t$ (its *latency* does not change), but once the pipeline is full one instruction completes every t. A sequence of m instructions takes

$$T_{total} = (n + m - 1) \cdot t$$

so pipelining increases *throughput*, not the speed of each instruction. The Cortex-M3 uses a three-stage pipeline of this kind.

3.2 Von Neumann and Harvard Architectures

CPU architectures differ in how they reach instructions and data. In the *von Neumann* architecture, instructions and data share one memory and one bus. It is simple and flexible, but the shared bus limits how fast data can move (the *von Neumann bottleneck*). In the *Harvard* architecture, instructions and data use separate memories and buses, so the CPU can fetch an instruction and access data at the same time.

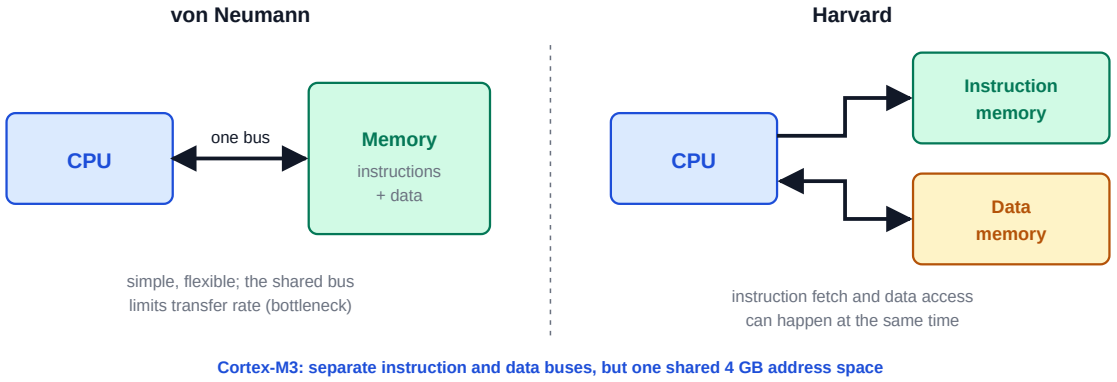


Figure 0.5: *von Neumann (one memory, one bus) and Harvard (separate instruction and data paths). The Cortex-M3 mixes the two: separate buses, one address space.*

Real processors often mix the two models. The Cortex-M3 has separate buses for instruction fetches and data accesses, which gives Harvard-like performance, but code and data share one 4 GB address space, as in von Neumann.

3.3 RISC and the Load/Store Model

ARM processors follow the RISC (Reduced Instruction Set Computer) philosophy: a small set of simple instructions, each executed quickly, combined with good compilers. A key RISC rule is the *load/store* model: arithmetic and logic work only on registers, so a value must be loaded from memory into a register, processed, and stored back. CISC (Complex Instruction Set Computer) processors, such as Intel x86, can instead operate directly on memory. Compilers hide this difference in C, but it becomes visible in assembly and in operating-system code.

3.4 Memory Hierarchy and Memory Technologies

Memories differ in speed, size, and cost, so every computer arranges them in a hierarchy. Small and fast memories sit close to the CPU; large and slow memories sit further away.

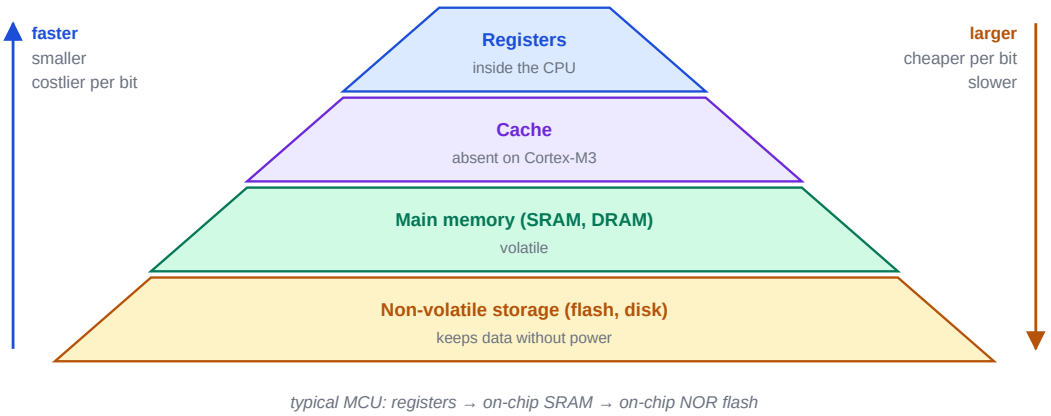


Figure 0.6: *The memory hierarchy. Going down, memories become larger and cheaper per bit but slower.*

Technology	Properties	Typical use
SRAM (static RAM)	Fast, no refresh needed, expensive, low density	On-chip RAM of a microcontroller, caches
DRAM (dynamic RAM)	Needs periodic refresh, cheap, high density	Main memory of PCs and large boards
NOR flash	Non-volatile, fast random reads, slow writes; code can run from it	Firmware and boot code
NAND flash	Non-volatile, accessed in blocks, dense and cheap	SD cards, USB drives, SSDs; not for direct execution

A *cache* is a small, fast memory that automatically keeps recently used data close to the CPU. It improves average speed, but its access time depends on what happened before, so the same code can take different times on different runs. This makes timing hard to predict, which is why many real-time systems disable caches or configure them carefully. The Cortex-M3 core has no cache at all.

3.5 Buses and Peripherals

Textbooks show a computer as a CPU and memories joined by a single address, data, and control bus. Real embedded boards have several buses: internal buses between the CPU and on-chip memory, buses to off-chip memory, and serial buses such as SPI, I²C, UART, or CAN to talk to sensors and other chips. Each peripheral is programmed by reading and writing its control registers, following the timing rules in its datasheet. On a desktop the operating system hides all of this; in an embedded system the firmware handles it directly.

3.6 Microprocessors and Microcontrollers

The core of a microprocessor and the core of a microcontroller execute instructions in the same way. The difference is what surrounds the core.

A *microprocessor* is mainly the CPU. It needs external RAM, external storage, and external peripheral chips to form a working computer. At power-on it runs a small firmware stored in a boot memory. This firmware starts a *boot loader*, which copies the operating system from storage (a disk or an SD card) into RAM and jumps to it.

A *microcontroller* (MCU) puts the CPU core, RAM, Flash, and peripherals (timers, converters, serial interfaces) on a single chip. Its internal Flash is mapped at the address the CPU reads after reset, so the firmware starts running directly from Flash, without a boot loader.

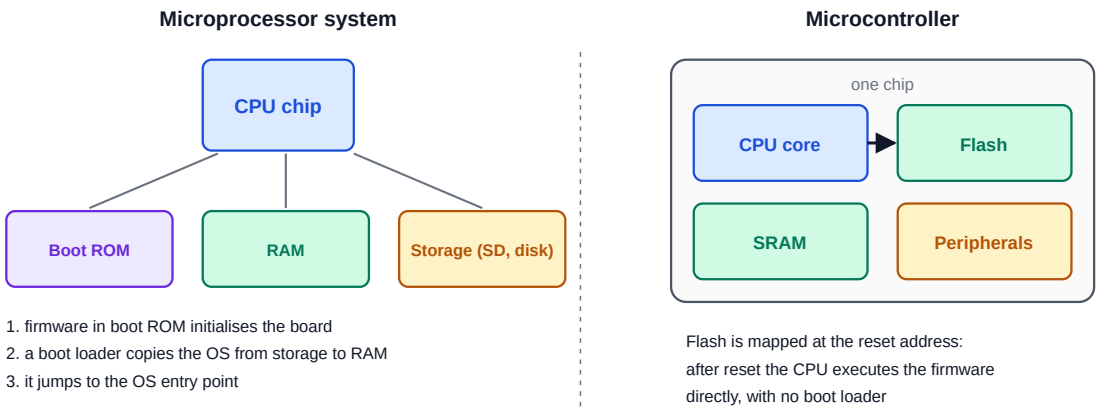


Figure 0.7: *A microprocessor needs external memories and a boot loader; a microcontroller integrates everything and executes its firmware straight from Flash after reset.*

4 Operating Systems

An operating system (OS) has several classic definitions, each stressing a different role.

Definition	Emphasis
Intermediary	A middle layer between hardware and applications that hides hardware details
Resource manager	Software that shares CPU, memory, I/O devices, and storage among applications
Master control program	The first software loaded at power-on; its core, the *kernel*, stays in memory

ROLE OF AN OPERATING SYSTEM

An OS mediates between application software and hardware. It gives controlled access to processors, memory, devices, and time, and it decides how competing work is scheduled.

The OS has two main purposes. First, it makes the hardware usable: without an OS, every application would have to initialise the CPU, program timers, share communication links, and handle interrupts on its own. Second, it manages resources that are limited and shared, even on a small board: CPU time (which task runs now), memory (which code and data occupy RAM), devices (who may use a timer or read a received byte), and events (how an interrupt becomes work for the right task).

Internally, an OS can be seen as a set of *managers*, one per resource, placed above a layer of hardware-specific services. Applications never call the managers directly: they go through a single *system-call interface*.

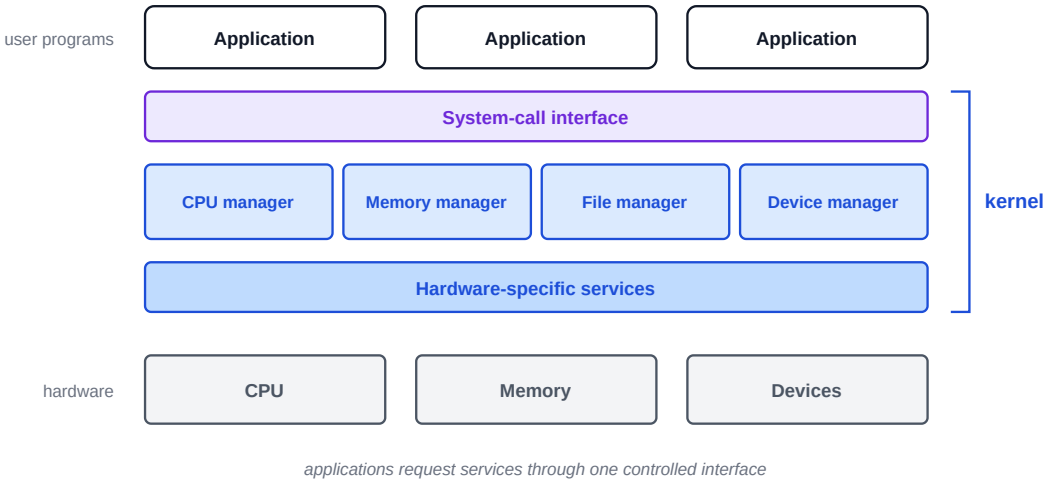


Figure 0.8: *The structure of an operating system. Applications use the system-call interface; the kernel's managers coordinate the hardware through hardware-specific services.*

4.1 Operating System Services

The services of a general-purpose OS fall into three groups.

Group	Services
For users	User interface (command line, graphical, touch, batch); program execution and termination

Group	Services
For programs	Uniform I/O operations through device drivers; file-system operations; communication between processes
For safe sharing	Resource allocation; logging and accounting; protection and security; error detection and handling

An embedded OS usually offers only a small part of this list. A microcontroller OS may provide only task scheduling, synchronisation, and time services, while the application keeps its own device drivers.

> **THE OS BOUNDARY IS A DESIGN CHOICE**
>
> What belongs to the OS is not a fixed feature list. It depends on what the product needs.

4.2 Privilege Levels, Traps, and System Calls

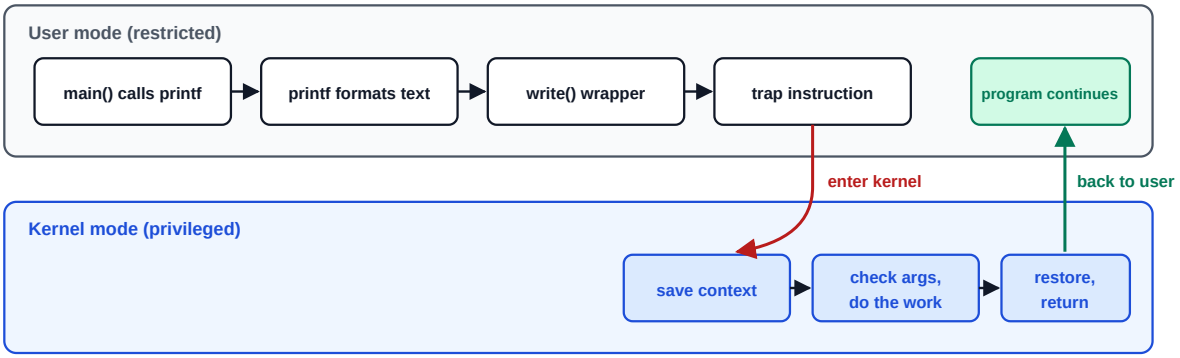
To protect itself and the hardware, an OS relies on CPU *execution modes*. Application code runs in *user mode* (restricted): it cannot program I/O controllers, change memory-protection settings, or disable interrupts. The kernel runs in *kernel mode* (privileged), where everything is allowed.

When an application needs a privileged operation, it makes a *system call*. A system call is implemented with a *trap*, a special instruction that moves execution from user mode to kernel mode in a controlled way. The CPU switches mode, saves the context of the program (for example the program counter and some registers), and jumps to a fixed kernel entry point. The kernel checks the arguments, performs the service, prepares a return value, restores the context, and returns to user mode.

```
#include <unistd.h>
#include <string.h>

int main( void )
{
    const char *msg = "Greetings\n";
    ssize_t n = write( 1, msg, strlen( msg ) );  /* 1 = standard output */
    return ( n < 0 ) ? 1 : 0;
}
```

Programs rarely execute the trap instruction themselves. They call library functions such as `printf`, which formats the text in user mode and then calls `write`, a thin *wrapper* that places the arguments where the kernel expects them and executes the trap. The return value tells the program whether the operation succeeded.



the same shape on Cortex-M: svc enters a privileged handler, exception return goes back

Figure 0.9: *A system call. The program reaches the trap through the C library, the kernel does the work in privileged mode, and control returns to the program in user mode.*

The Cortex-M3 implements the same mechanism with the `svc` instruction and the privileged Handler mode, as described in the chapter on the ARM Cortex-M3 architecture.

4.3 From Source Code to a Running OS

A program becomes executable in three steps. The *compiler* turns each source file into a *relocatable object file*, whose final addresses are not fixed yet. The *linker* combines the object files and libraries into one executable image (an ELF file), resolves the references between them, and assigns final addresses. Finally, the image must be placed in memory and started: on a PC this is the job of a *loader*, which can also relocate the program to a different address.

On a microcontroller the OS image is written into Flash with an external programmer during development, and the CPU runs it from its reset address. Applications can be added to such a system in two ways. With *fixed tasks*, the tasks are compiled and linked together with the OS into one image, and no loader is needed. With *programmable tasks*, applications are separate images loaded after the OS starts; this allows updates without rebuilding the OS, at the cost of a loader, memory management, and security checks. Most small embedded systems use fixed tasks.

5 Kernel Architectures

Operating systems differ in *where* their services run and *how strongly* they are isolated from each other and from applications.

Architecture	Where services run	Advantage	Cost	Examples
Flat	Everything in one image and one address space	Small and fast	Little or no isolation	FreeRTOS, MS-DOS
Monolithic	All services in one privileged kernel	Fast direct calls between services	Large trusted core; a bad driver can crash the kernel	Linux, UNIX
Microkernel	Minimal kernel; services as user-mode servers	Small trusted base, faults contained	IPC overhead, more interfaces	seL4, QNX
Hybrid	Mix of the above	Balance of speed and structure	Complexity	macOS (Mach + BSD), Linux modules

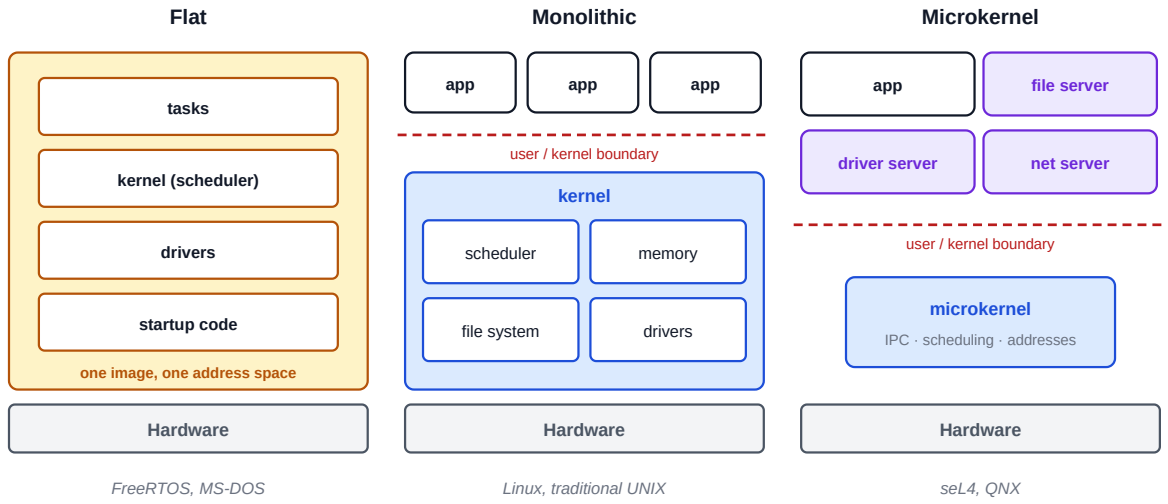


Figure 0.10: *Three kernel architectures. The red line is the hardware-enforced boundary between user and kernel mode; a flat system has none.*

In a *flat* design, startup code, kernel, drivers, and tasks are linked into one image and share one physical address space. OS services are ordinary functions that tasks call directly. No memory management unit and no privilege levels are needed, but any bug can corrupt any data.

A *monolithic* kernel separates user space from kernel space with hardware support (privilege levels and an MMU or MPU), so a faulty application cannot corrupt the kernel. Inside the kernel, however, scheduler, memory manager, file systems, and drivers share the same privileged space. Drivers are a large and error-prone part of the code, and a single faulty driver can crash the whole system.

A *microkernel* keeps only the basic mechanisms in kernel mode, typically scheduling, address-space management, and inter-process communication (IPC). File systems, drivers, and network stacks run as user-mode servers that exchange messages. A failed server can be restarted, and the small kernel is easier to verify.

The price is performance: a system call in a monolithic kernel needs two mode switches (user to kernel and back), while the same request in a microkernel typically needs four (client to kernel, kernel to server, server to kernel, kernel to client).

Most real systems are *hybrids*. Linux is monolithic but loads drivers as modules at run time; macOS combines the Mach microkernel with BSD components.

CHOOSING A KERNEL ARCHITECTURE

Each architecture is a trade-off between isolation, fault containment, overhead, and complexity. The useful question is not "which one is best?" but "what must this system guarantee?".

6 Embedded and Real-Time Operating Systems

Embedded OSes differ from desktop OSes for three reasons. They are *resource-constrained*: a few KB of RAM leave no room for a large kernel. They are *real-time*: correctness depends on when things happen. They usually have *no untrusted users*: one vendor ships one firmware image with a known set of tasks. For these reasons an embedded OS is selected and configured for one product, not for an unknown future workload.

General-purpose mechanism	Embedded replacement
Dynamic allocation	Static number of tasks and fixed-size buffers
General fairness policy	Simple priority-based scheduler
Layered device stack	Direct register access
Maximum throughput	Predictable execution time

SMALL IS NOT INCOMPLETE

A small OS is complete when it matches the responsibilities of the system.

A *real-time operating system* (RTOS) such as FreeRTOS provides ready-made versions of the mechanisms an embedded application needs: tasks with priorities, delays and timer-driven scheduling, queues, semaphores and mutexes, and communication from interrupts to tasks. By default FreeRTOS has no memory protection between tasks: like flat firmware, all tasks share one address space. Knowing the mechanisms underneath an RTOS makes its API much easier to use correctly.

6.1 Single Image, Single Failure Domain

Many microcontroller products ship one firmware image that contains startup code, drivers, OS, and application. Updating the image changes the whole system. This makes deployment simple, but it requires discipline: a bad pointer can damage any writable data, a blocked high-priority task can stop an important service, and recovery and diagnostics must be designed into the firmware from the start. Scheduling, synchronisation, and memory protection are the mechanisms that reduce these risks.

6.2 From Bare Metal to a Minimal OS

A minimal flat OS is built as a chain of mechanisms, where each one depends on the previous one. This chain is also the path followed by the rest of these notes, on an ARM Cortex-M3 microcontroller emulated by QEMU.

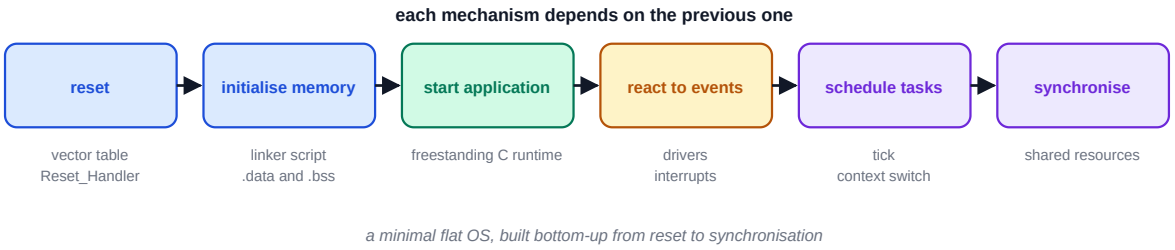


Figure 0.11: *The mechanisms of a minimal OS, from reset to synchronisation, with the main topics involved in each step.*

First the processor must start correctly after reset, which requires a vector table and a reset handler. Then memory must be prepared, as described by the linker script, so that C code can run. Once the application runs, it must react to events through device drivers and interrupts. With a periodic timer tick and context switching, the kernel can schedule several tasks, and finally it must synchronise their access to shared resources. Memory protection and system calls, built on the privilege levels of the Cortex-M3, add isolation on top of this chain.

1 Microcontrollers and the Cortex-M3 Core

A microcontroller (MCU) integrates on one chip what a desktop computer spreads across a motherboard: a CPU core, volatile working memory (SRAM, typically tens or hundreds of KB), non-volatile program storage (Flash, from which code executes directly), and on-chip peripherals such as timers, UARTs, and GPIO. One chip, one clock, and one address space replace the external memory bus, the BIOS, and the disk of a general-purpose machine.

Aspect	Desktop CPU	Microcontroller
Integration	Core only; RAM, storage, I/O on separate chips	Core, memory, and peripherals on one chip
Address space	Per-process virtual address space via an MMU	One flat physical map for code, data, and registers
Memory protection	MMU with page tables	No MMU; at most an optional MPU
Device access	Through a driver layer in the kernel	Device registers are addresses written directly

1.1 Architecture, Core, and Chip

Three layers must be kept apart when reading documentation. The **architecture** (ARMv7-M for the Cortex-M3) defines the programmer's model, the instruction set, the exception model, and the purpose of each region of the address space. The **core** (Cortex-M3) is ARM's implementation of that architecture, including a fixed set of *core peripherals*: the NVIC, the SysTick timer, the System Control Block, and an optional MPU. The **chip** or **board** is built by a silicon vendor around the licensed core and decides how much Flash and SRAM exist and which device peripherals (UARTs, timers) are connected.

Layer	Defined by	Examples of what it fixes
Architecture (ARMv7-M)	ARM	Registers, Thumb-2 instructions, exception numbers, address regions
Core (Cortex-M3)	ARM	NVIC, SysTick, SCB, MPU, 3-stage pipeline
Chip / board	Vendor	Memory sizes, device peripherals, IRQ assignment, clock

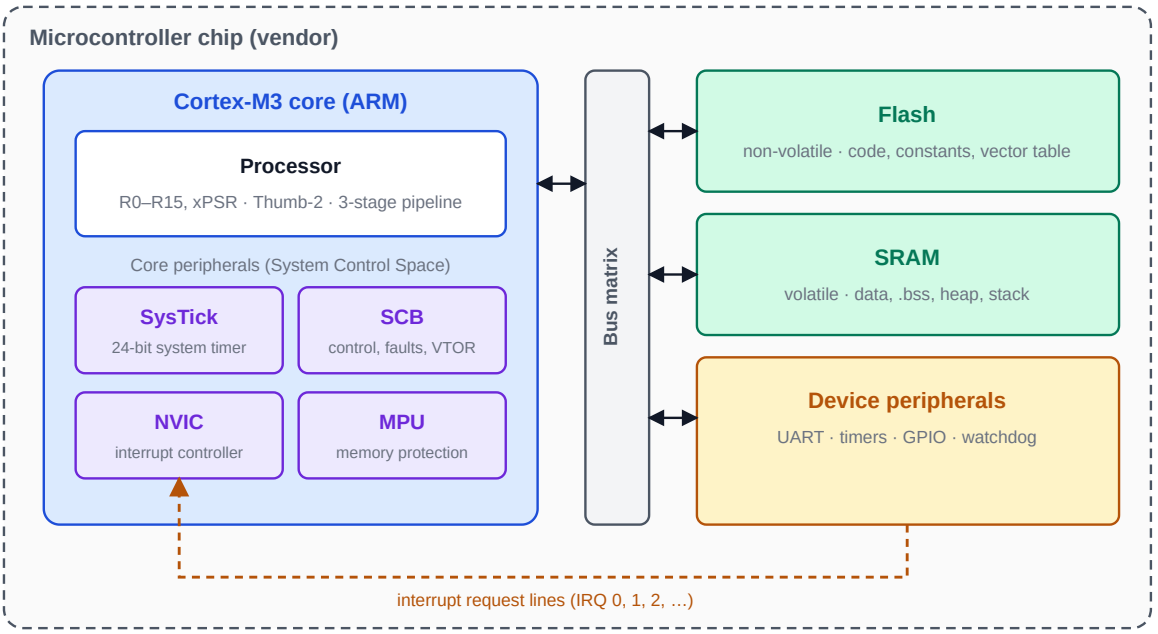


Figure 1.1: *Block diagram of a Cortex-M3 microcontroller: the ARM core with processor and core peripherals, the bus matrix, and the vendor's Flash, SRAM, and device peripherals.*

Everything in this chapter belongs to the first two layers and is therefore identical on every Cortex-M3. Board-specific values are taken from the `mps2-an385` platform (an FPGA image of a Cortex-M3 system, emulated by QEMU, clocked at 25 MHz) and are marked as such.

2 Programmer's Model and Thumb Instruction Set

The programmer's model is the set of registers visible to software and to the debugger. At this level there are no variables, only registers and memory: a C statement such as `x = x + 1` becomes "load `x` into a register, add 1, store it back".

2.1 Core Registers

All core registers are 32 bits wide.

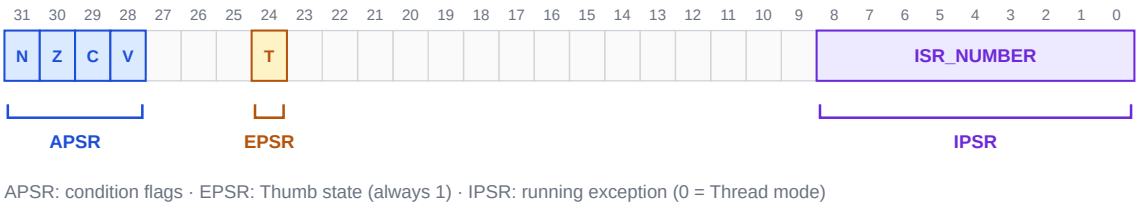
Register	Name	Role
`R0` – `R12`	General purpose	Operands and addresses; `R0` – `R3` carry function arguments
`R13`	`SP`	Stack pointer: address of the top of the stack
`R14`	`LR`	Link register: return address after a function call
`R15`	`PC`	Program counter: address of the next instruction
—	`xPSR`	Program status: flags, Thumb bit, current exception number

The stack is *full descending*: it grows towards lower addresses, and `SP` points to the last occupied word. A push first decrements `SP` by 4 and then writes at the new `SP`. `R13` is a banked name: two physical stack pointers exist (`MSP` and `PSP`), and `SP` always refers to the one currently selected (see the section on execution modes).

2.2 The Program Status Register xPSR

`xPSR` holds neither data nor addresses: it describes the current state of the processor. The name reflects that it is the union of three sub-registers occupying disjoint bits of the same 32-bit word.

Sub-register	Bits	Content
`APSR` (Application)	31–28	Flags `N` (negative), `Z` (zero), `C` (carry), `V` (overflow)
`EPSR` (Execution)	24	`T` : Thumb state, always 1 on Cortex-M
`IPSR` (Interrupt)	8–0	Number of the exception being handled, 0 if none



APSR: condition flags · EPSR: Thumb state (always 1) · IPSR: running exception (0 = Thread mode)

Figure 1.2: *Bit layout of xPSR: N, Z, C, V flags in APSR, Thumb bit in EPSR, exception number in IPSR.*

The flags are written by comparison and arithmetic instructions and read by conditional branches; this is how every `if` and loop condition is implemented at machine level.

FLAGS IN ACTION

`cmp r1, r2` computes `r1 - r2`, discards the result, and updates only the flags: `Z = 1` if the operands are equal, `C = 1` if `r1 >= r2` as unsigned values. The following `bhs done` reads `C` and branches if it is 1.

`IPSR` identifies the execution mode: 0 means Thread mode (ordinary code), any other value is the number of the exception whose handler is running.

2.3 Load/Store Architecture

The Cortex-M3 has a load/store instruction set: arithmetic and logic operate only on registers, and memory is accessed exclusively through load (`ldr`, memory to register) and store (`str`, register to memory) instructions. Every operation on a variable therefore passes through a register.

Assembly	C equivalent
`ldr r3, [r0]`	`r3 = *r0;`
`str r3, [r1]`	`*r1 = r3;`
`ldr r3, [r0], #4`	`r3 = *r0; r0 += 4;` (post-increment)
`strb r1, [r0, #7]`	`((uint8_t *)r0)[7] = r1;`
`ldr r0, =_estack`	`r0 = (uint32_t)&_estack;` (any 32-bit value)
`mov sp, r0`	`sp = r0;`
`movs r3, #0`	`r3 = 0;` (small constants only)
`orr r1, r1, #0x10`	`r1 |= 0x10;`
`b label`	`goto label;`
`bl main`	`main();` (return address saved in `LR`)
`bhs done`	`if (r1 >= r2) goto done;` after `cmp r1, r2`

Square brackets denote "the memory at this address". In `[r0], #4` the address in `r0` is used first and then incremented, so a loop walks through memory one word at a time.

An instruction is 16 or 32 bits long and cannot embed an arbitrary 32-bit constant. For the pseudo-instruction `ldr rX, =value` the assembler stores the constant in a nearby table, the *literal pool*, and emits a PC-relative load, which a disassembler shows as `ldr r0, [pc, #92]`. The `.ltorg` directive places the pool where the CPU never executes it.

```
loop:   cmp   r1, r2        @ while (r1 < r2) {
        bhs   done          @
        ...                 @     body
        b     loop          @ }
done:
```

A C `while` loop compiles to a test at the top and an unconditional branch back at the bottom: `cmp` sets the flags, `bhs` leaves the loop when the condition fails, and `b` closes the cycle.

2.4 Thumb State and the Thumb Bit

The Cortex-M executes only the Thumb-2 instruction set, a mix of 16-bit and 32-bit encodings. Because instructions are always at least 2-byte aligned, bit 0 of a code address carries no information, so ARM reuses it as the *Thumb bit*: every code pointer used in a branch-and-exchange or loaded into `PC` must have bit 0 set. The CPU checks the bit, copies it into `xPSR.T`, clears it, and jumps to the even address. A handler located at `0x40` is therefore referenced as `0x41`.

> **THUMB BIT EQUAL TO 0**
>
> Branching to an address with bit 0 clear requests ARM state, which the Cortex-M does not implement. The result is a UsageFault (`INVSTATE`), not an ordinary crash at the target address.

2.5 Calling Convention (AAPCS)

The AAPCS (Procedure Call Standard for the Arm Architecture) defines how functions exchange arguments and which registers they must preserve. Compiled C and hand-written assembly interoperate only if both follow it, and the exception model is designed around it.

Register	Role in a call	Preserved across the call
`r0` – `r3`	First four arguments; `r0` also returns the result	No (caller-saved)
`r4` – `r11`	Long-lived local values	Yes (callee-saved)
`r12`	Scratch	No (caller-saved)
`lr`	Return address written by `bl`	No; a non-leaf function saves it
`sp`	Multiple of 8 at every public call	Yes

A caller that still needs `r0` – `r3` or `r12` after a call saves them itself; a function that uses `r4` must restore it before returning, typically with `push {r4, lr}` at entry and `pop {r4, pc}` at exit. A leaf function using only caller-saved registers saves nothing.

AAPCS: A CALL, STEP BY STEP

Calling `add3` and the code of `add3` itself:

```
int add3(int a, int b, int c);          add3:
r = add3(1, 2, 3);                          adds r0, r0, r1   /* r0 = a + b */
                                            adds r0, r0, r2   /* r0 = r0 + c */
movs r0, #1    /* a = 1 */                  bx   lr           /* return r0 to the caller */
movs r1, #2    /* b = 2 */
movs r2, #3    /* c = 3 */
bl   add3      /* lr = next instruction; pc = add3 */
               /* r = r0 */
```

- `add3` uses only r0–r2 and calls nothing, so it saves nothing: no stack at all
- A function that calls another must first save `lr` (`push {r4, lr}`), or `bl` would overwrite its own return address

`add3` is a leaf function using only caller-saved registers: it saves nothing.

3 Memory Map and Memory-Mapped Registers

The Cortex-M3 sees a single 4 GB physical address space (32-bit addresses). The architecture fixes the purpose of each region; the vendor decides how much memory or which devices populate it. There is no translation: the address issued by an instruction is the address seen by memory and peripherals, and no run-time loader chooses where a program is placed. All placement decisions are made at link time and recorded in the image.

Address range	Region	Populated on `mps2-an385`
`0x0000_0000` – `0x1FFF_FFFF`	Code	4 MB program memory at `0x0` ("FLASH")
`0x2000_0000` – `0x3FFF_FFFF`	SRAM	4 MB at `0x2000_0000` ("RAM")
`0x4000_0000` – `0x5FFF_FFFF`	Peripherals	UARTs, timers, watchdog
`0x6000_0000` – `0xDFFF_FFFF`	External RAM / devices	Not used
`0xE000_0000` – `0xE00F_FFFF`	Private Peripheral Bus	Core registers (System Control Space)

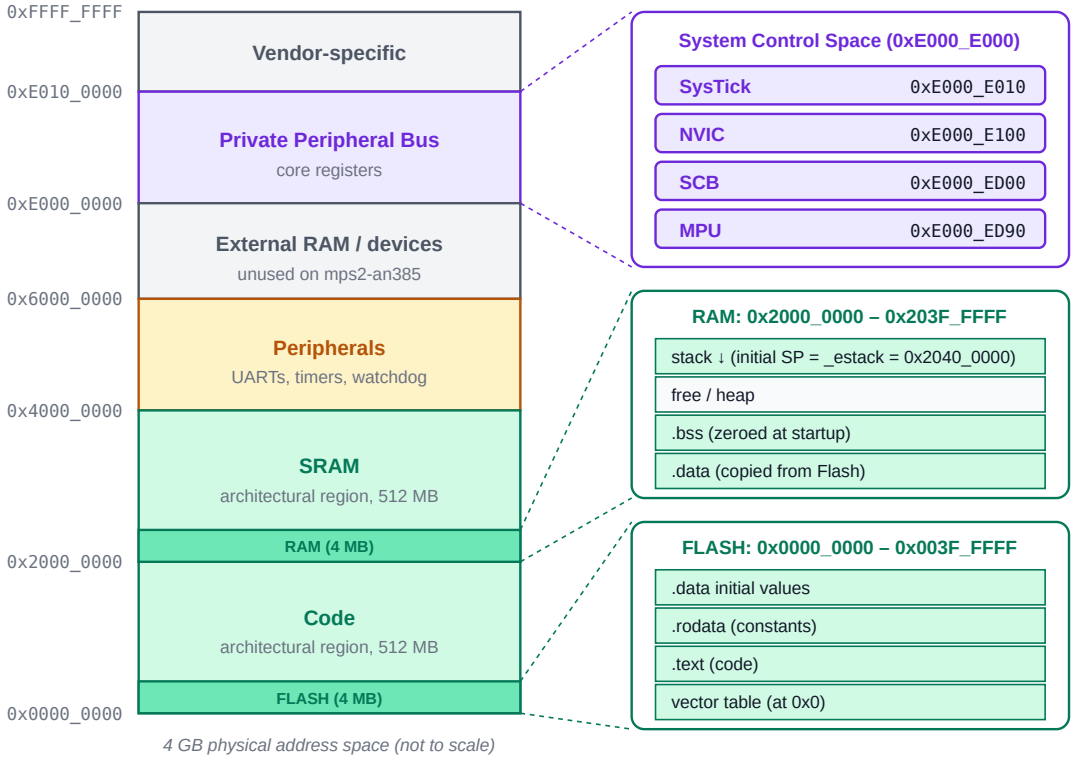


Figure 1.3: *Cortex-M3 address space with the regions populated on mps2-an385 and the System Control Space in detail.*

Flash keeps its contents without power and holds the vector table, code, constants, and the initial values of initialized variables. SRAM is fast writable memory whose contents are undefined at power-on; it holds initialized and zeroed variables, the heap, and the stack. This split is the reason startup code must copy some bytes from Flash to SRAM and zero others before C code can run safely.

EMULATED FLASH

On `mps2-an385`, and in QEMU, the 4 MB at address `0x0` are fast RAM preloaded with the program image. They play the role of Flash and are treated as read-only, exactly like real Flash on a microcontroller.

3.1 System Control Space and Core Peripherals

The last region holds the registers of the core itself. Inside it, the System Control Space (SCS, `0xE000_E000` – `0xE000_EFFF`) groups the core peripherals, which are identical on every Cortex-M3 regardless of the vendor.

Core peripheral	Base address	Purpose
SysTick	`0xE000_E010`	24-bit periodic timer
NVIC	`0xE000_E100`	Enabling, pending state, and priority of device interrupts
SCB (System Control Block)	`0xE000_ED00`	Vector table location, fault configuration and status, system priorities
MPU	`0xE000_ED90`	Memory protection regions

Only privileged code may access the SCS. An unprivileged access raises a BusFault, which is what prevents application code from reconfiguring the machine.

3.2 Accessing Memory-Mapped Registers

```
#define SCB_SHCSR (*(volatile uint32_t *)0xE000ED24)

SCB_SHCSR |= (1u << 16);
```

```
        ldr r0, =0xE000ED24     @ address
        ldr r1, [r0]            @ read
        orr r1, r1, #0x10000    @ modify
        str r1, [r0]            @ write
```

A peripheral register is accessed with ordinary load and store instructions through a pointer to its documented address. The macro casts the address to a pointer to `volatile uint32_t` and dereferences it, so `SCB_SHCSR` behaves like a variable located at `0xE000ED24`. The compound assignment compiles to the four instructions shown: read the current value, set only the required bit, write the word back. This *read-modify-write* pattern preserves every other bit of the register and is mandatory whenever a register mixes configuration bits with status bits.

The `volatile` qualifier forces the compiler to perform every access, in program order. Without it, the compiler may assume that a value read twice cannot have changed, or that a value written and never read back is useless, and remove the access; both assumptions are false for hardware, where a read may observe a changing state and a write may trigger an external effect.

Not every register needs read-modify-write. Registers with *write-1-to-set* or *write-1-to-clear* semantics (such as the NVIC enable registers) ignore 0 bits, so a plain assignment affects only the selected bit. Registers organized

as independent bytes (such as the priority registers) are written with a byte store (`strb`).

> ⚠ **WHAT `VOLATILE` DOES NOT DO**
>
> `volatile` guarantees that accesses happen and in which order. It does not make a read-modify-write sequence indivisible: an interrupt arriving between the load and the store can still cause a lost update.

4 Execution Modes, Privilege, and Stacks

The Cortex-M3 implements in hardware the separation between kernel mode and user mode found in operating systems. Two independent properties describe the current state: the *mode* (what kind of code runs) and the *privilege level* (what that code may do).

4.1 Thread Mode and Handler Mode

Thread mode runs ordinary code: `Reset_Handler`, `main()`, and the functions they call; `IPSR` is 0. Handler mode runs exception handlers; `IPSR` holds the exception number. The CPU enters Handler mode automatically when it takes an exception and returns to the previous mode when the handler finishes.

Mode	Privilege	Typical code
Thread	Privileged	`Reset_Handler`, kernel code after reset
Thread	Unprivileged	Application tasks after the kernel drops privilege
Handler	Always privileged	Every exception handler

ONLY THREE COMBINATIONS

Privilege can be lowered only in Thread mode. Handler mode is always privileged, so an exception always runs privileged and returns to Thread mode with the privilege level it had before.

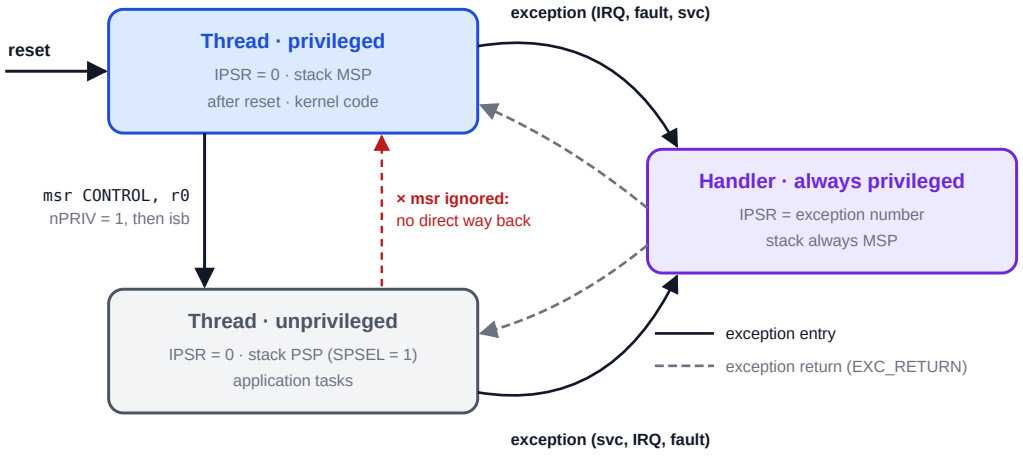


Figure 1.4: *Transitions between privileged Thread mode, unprivileged Thread mode, and Handler mode.*

After reset the CPU is in privileged Thread mode, which is why the boot code can configure the vector table, fault handling, and priorities.

4.2 Special Registers and the CONTROL Register

Some core registers are not memory-mapped and cannot be reached with `ldr` or `str`. They are read with `mrs` (move register from special) and written with `msr` (move special from register).

Special register	Content
`CONTROL`	Thread-mode privilege and stack selection
`PRIMASK`	1 bit: masks every exception with configurable priority
`FAULTMASK`	1 bit: also masks HardFault; only NMI is taken
`BASEPRI`	Masks exceptions whose priority value is greater than or equal to it

`CONTROL` holds two bits relevant here:

Bit	Name	Meaning
0	`nPRIV`	0 = privileged, 1 = unprivileged (Thread mode only)
1	`SPSEL`	Thread-mode stack pointer: 0 = `MSP`, 1 = `PSP`

4.3 Dropping Privilege

```
        mrs r0, control     @ r0 = CONTROL
        orr r0, r0, #1      @ set nPRIV
        msr control, r0     @ Thread mode is now unprivileged
        isb                 @ discard instructions fetched under the old rules
```

The sequence is a read-modify-write on a special register, equivalent to `CONTROL = CONTROL | 1`. The final `isb` (instruction synchronization barrier) is required because the CPU prefetches instructions: some may already have been fetched and decoded under the privileged rules, and `isb` flushes the pipeline so that the following instructions execute under the new ones.

Writing `CONTROL` is itself a privileged operation: an unprivileged `msr control, r0` that tries to clear `nPRIV` is silently ignored. The only ways back to privileged execution are a reset or an exception, whose handler runs in Handler mode. Unprivileged code keeps access to ordinary RAM, Flash, and its own code, but loses the ability to reconfigure or silence the machine:

Attempt by unprivileged code	Result
Access to the SCS (SysTick, NVIC, SCB, MPU)	BusFault
`msr control, r0` to regain privilege	Ignored
`cpsid i` / `cpsie i`	Ignored
Access to a region denied by the MPU	MemManage fault
Semihosting `bkpt 0xab`	Refused by QEMU by default: the fault escalates to HardFault

4.4 Main and Process Stack Pointers

The Cortex-M3 has two physical stack pointers. The **main stack pointer** (`MSP`) is used after reset and always in Handler mode; it is the kernel's stack. The **process stack pointer** (`PSP`) is used in Thread mode when `CONTROL.SPSEL` is 1; an operating system gives each task its own `PSP` stack. A task therefore typically runs with

`CONTROL = 3`: unprivileged and on `PSP`.

The register name `sp` always refers to the stack pointer currently selected, while `mrs r0, msp` and `mrs r0, psp` name each one explicitly. Because Handler mode always switches to `MSP`, interrupt handlers and system calls never execute on a task's stack: a task that corrupts or overflows its own stack cannot corrupt the stack the kernel runs on.

4.5 Interrupt Masking with PRIMASK

`cpsid i` sets `PRIMASK` to 1: every exception with configurable priority is held back, and only NMI and HardFault are taken. `cpsie i` clears it. Exceptions that arrive while masked are not lost: they remain pending and are taken as soon as `PRIMASK` returns to 0. `PRIMASK` is 0 at reset; boot code usually sets it first and clears it only once the vector table, handlers, and priorities are in place.

Instruction	`PRIMASK`	CMSIS function
`cpsid i`	1: masked	`__disable_irq()`
`cpsie i`	0: accepted	`__enable_irq()`

Critical sections that may nest must save the previous value with `mrs r0, primask` and restore it with `msr primask, r0`, rather than unconditionally executing `cpsie i`, which would unmask interrupts too early when the outer section is still active.

5 Exception Model

An *exception* is any event that makes the CPU suspend the current code and run a specific handler in Handler mode. An *interrupt* is an exception raised by a hardware device. Faults, system calls, the system timer, and device interrupts all go through the same mechanism.

5.1 Exception Types and Numbers

Number	Exception	Raised by
1	Reset	Power-on, reset pin
2	NMI	Non-maskable interrupt (e.g. watchdog expiry)
3	HardFault	Any fault with nowhere else to go
4	MemManage	Violation of MPU rules
5	BusFault	Access to an address that does not answer or refuses the access
6	UsageFault	Undefined opcode, Thumb bit 0, division by zero (if trapped)
7–10, 13	Reserved	—
11	SVCall	The `svc` instruction
12	DebugMonitor	Debug events in monitor mode
14	PendSV	A software request (`ICSR.PENDSVSET`)
15	SysTick	The core timer
16 + n	IRQ n	Device interrupt line n, through the NVIC

Numbers 0–15 belong to the core and are identical on every Cortex-M3; device interrupts follow. Number 0 is not an exception: its vector table slot holds the initial stack pointer.

At reset only HardFault is active among the faults: MemManage, BusFault, and UsageFault are disabled, so every fault *escalates* to HardFault until the boot code enables the dedicated handlers.

PendSV deserves a note because of its role in operating systems. It is raised only by software, by writing a bit in a system register, and it is normally given the lowest priority. An OS uses it to request work, typically a context switch, that must run only after every more urgent handler has finished.

5.2 Priorities, Preemption, and Lockup

When several exceptions compete, the more urgent one runs first. On Cortex-M a **lower number means more urgent**. Reset (−3), NMI (−2), and HardFault (−1) have fixed priorities above anything configurable; every other exception has a one-byte configurable priority. A pending exception preempts the running code only if its priority is *strictly* more urgent; otherwise it stays pending until the current handler returns. Preemption of one handler by another is called *nesting*, which gives the NVIC (Nested Vectored Interrupt Controller) its name.

Implementations do not use all eight bits of a priority byte. Real chips implement only the upper 3 or 4 bits, and the lower bits read as 0, so distinct priorities must differ in their top bits (`0x00` , `0x20` , ..., `0xE0` for 3 bits).

> **LOCKUP**
>
> If a fault occurs while the CPU already runs at HardFault priority, or the fault cannot be reported because exception entry itself fails (for example, the stack pointer points outside RAM), there is nowhere to escalate. The CPU enters *lockup* and stops executing. QEMU reports it as `Lockup: can't escalate 3 to HardFault (current priority -1)`.

5.3 Vector Table and Reset Sequence

The vector table is an array of 32-bit words where slot N holds the address of the handler of exception N. When exception N occurs, the CPU reads the slot and branches there. Slot 0 is special: it holds the initial value of `MSP`, not a code address. The table is located through the `VTOR` register, which resets to `0x0000_0000`; at reset it must therefore be at the start of the Code region, which is why the linker places it first in Flash.

When the Cortex-M3 leaves reset, before any software runs, the hardware performs exactly two reads:

1. the word at address `0x0` is loaded into `MSP`;
2. the word at address `0x4` is loaded into `PC`, and execution starts there in privileged Thread mode.

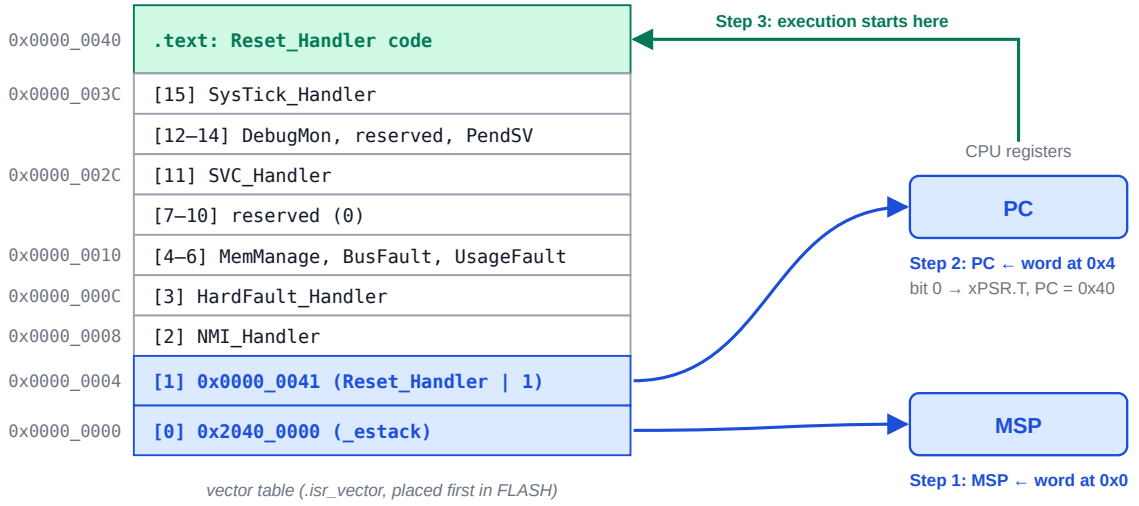


Figure 1.5: *Reset sequence: the CPU loads MSP from address 0x0 and PC from address 0x4, then executes Reset_Handler.*

There is no BIOS, no loader, and no C runtime. Initializing memory, configuring the core, and calling `main()` are the job of the code whose address is stored in slot 1, `Reset_Handler`.

Offset	Slot	Content
`0x00`	0	Initial `MSP` (e.g. `0x2040_0000`, one byte past the end of RAM)
`0x04`	1	`Reset_Handler` address, with bit 0 set
`0x08`	2	`NMI_Handler`
`0x0C` – `0x18`	3–6	HardFault, MemManage, BusFault, UsageFault handlers

Offset	Slot	Content
`0x2C`	11	`SVC_Handler`
`0x38`, `0x3C`	14, 15	`PendSV_Handler`, `SysTick_Handler`
`0x40` + 4n	16 + n	Handler of IRQ n

Every handler address is stored with the Thumb bit set. Reserved slots hold 0, and every other slot must point to valid code even if the exception is never expected; startup code usually fills unused slots with a default handler that loops forever, so that an unexpected exception stops at a recognizable address.

> **FROM IRQ NUMBER TO VECTOR SLOT**
>
> IRQ n is exception 16 + n, and its handler address is at offset 4 × (16 + n). IRQ 1 is exception 17, at offset `0x44`.

5.4 Exception Entry and the Stacked Frame

Before the first instruction of a handler, the hardware:

1. pushes 8 words, the *stacked frame*, onto the stack in use when the exception occurred (`MSP` or `PSP`);
2. writes a special `EXC_RETURN` value into `lr`;
3. reads the handler address from the vector table and branches to it in Handler mode, on `MSP`.

Offset from new `sp`	Stacked register
`+0x00`	`r0`
`+0x04`	`r1`
`+0x08`	`r2`
`+0x0C`	`r3`
`+0x10`	`r12`
`+0x14`	`lr` of the interrupted code
`+0x18`	`PC`: where the interrupted code resumes
`+0x1C`	`xPSR`

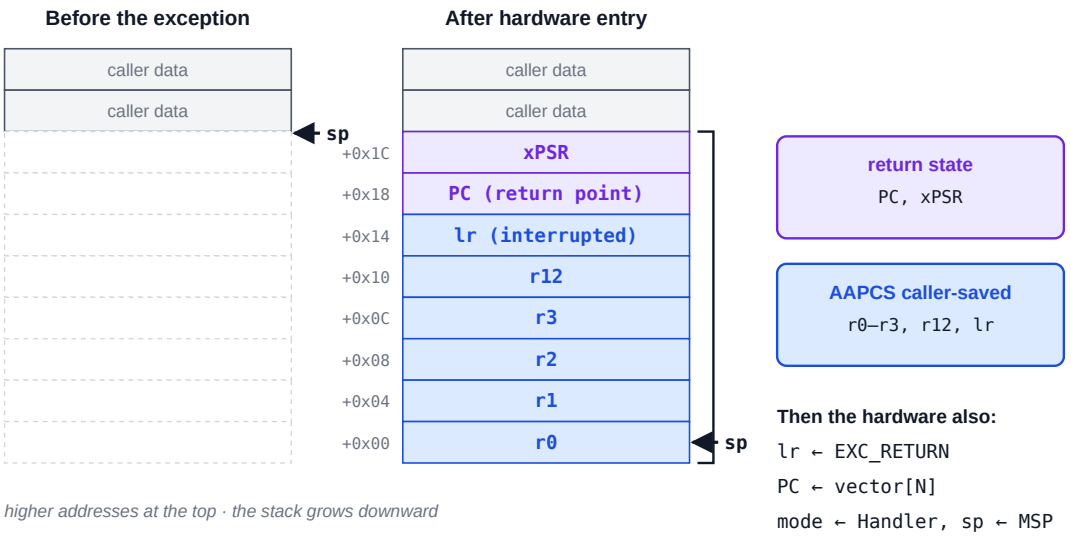


Figure 1.6: *Stack before and after exception entry, with the 8-word stacked frame pushed by hardware.*

The hardware saves exactly the AAPCS caller-saved registers plus `PC` and `xPSR`, and any compiled C function already preserves the callee-saved `r4`–`r11`. Together, these two facts mean that an exception handler can be an ordinary C function, with no special prologue or epilogue. When `CCR.STKALIGN` is set (its reset value on the Cortex-M3), the hardware also aligns `sp` to 8 bytes on entry, as the AAPCS requires, and records the adjustment in bit 9 of the stacked `xPSR`. Entry takes about 12 cycles.

5.5 Exception Return through EXC_RETURN

A handler ends with an ordinary return instruction (`bx lr` or `pop {..., pc}`), yet the CPU must restore the saved state rather than jump to a return address. While a handler runs, `lr` holds a value of the form `0xFFFFFFxx`, where no code can exist. Loading such a value into `PC` is recognized as an *exception return*: the CPU pops the 8-word frame from the indicated stack, restores the mode, and resumes at the stacked `PC`.

`EXC_RETURN`	Return to	Frame popped from
`0xFFFFFFF1`	Handler mode (a preempted handler)	`MSP`
`0xFFFFFFF9`	Thread mode	`MSP`
`0xFFFFFFFD`	Thread mode	`PSP`

Bits 31–4 are all ones and mark the value as `EXC_RETURN`. Bit 3 selects the return mode (1 = Thread, 0 = Handler) and bit 2 the stack (1 = `PSP`, 0 = `MSP`). On entry, bit 2 therefore tells the handler which stack holds the frame just pushed, which a system-call handler needs in order to read the caller's arguments.

When you return from an exception, the Link Register is not containing the return address but also a special code 0xF

In which execution mode the CPU should go back

EXCEPTION RETURN: `EXC_RETURN`

In a handler, `lr` does not hold a code address: it holds a value starting with `0xFFFFFF..`, where there is no code. When the handler returns with `bx lr` (or `pop {..., pc}`), the CPU sees this value and does an **exception return**: it pops the 8 words, goes back to the old mode, and resumes at the stacked PC.

`EXC_RETURN`	Return to	Stack used
`0xFFFFFFF9`	thread mode (normal code, e.g. `main`)	main stack
`0xFFFFFFF1`	handler mode (a less urgent handler that was interrupted)	main stack
`0xFFFFFFFD`	thread mode	process stack

- Cortex-M has a **second stack pointer** (the process stack). This kernel never uses it, so a return to thread mode here is always `0xFFFFFFF9`
- The compiled C handler ends with an ordinary `bx lr` or `pop {..., pc}`: the value in `lr` is what makes it an exception return

5.6 Tail-Chaining and Late Arrival

When exceptions occur close together, the core avoids saving and restoring the same state repeatedly.

Optimization	Situation	Behaviour
Tail-chaining	A handler ends while another exception is pending	No pop and re-push of the frame: direct jump to the next handler (about 6 cycles instead of about 24)
Late arrival	A more urgent exception arrives while the frame of a less urgent one is being pushed	The frame is reused; the more urgent handler runs first, then tail-chains to the other

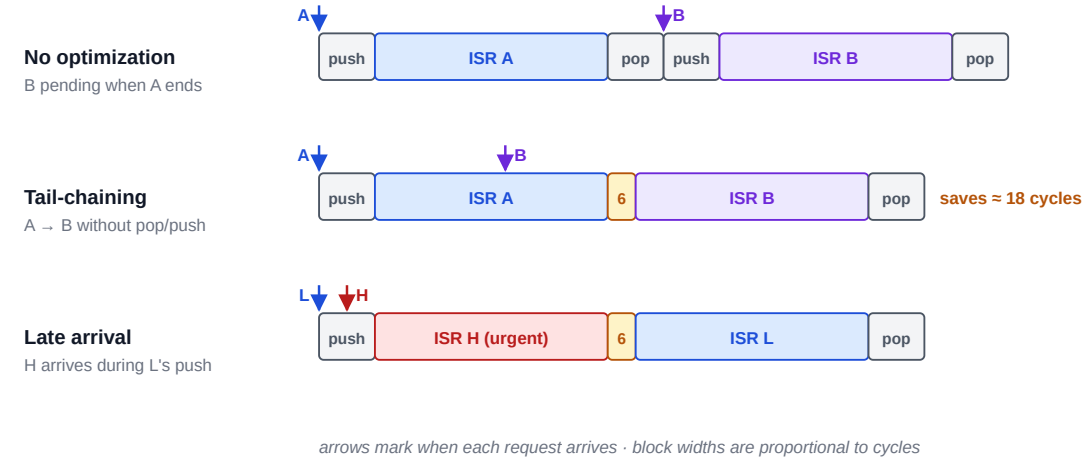


Figure 1.7: *Timelines of two exceptions without optimization, with tail-chaining, and with late arrival.*

5.7 SVC: A Controlled Entry into Privileged Code

```c
void SVC_Handler( void )
{
    /* privileged service code */
}

/* in unprivileged Thread mode */
__asm__ volatile ( "svc #0" : : : "memory" );
```

`svc #n` (supervisor call) is one of the few things unprivileged code can always do. It raises SVCall (exception 11) synchronously, so the handler in slot 11 runs in Handler mode and therefore privileged. When the handler returns, execution resumes at the instruction after `svc`, in Thread mode and still unprivileged. Inside the handler `CONTROL.nPRIV` still reads 1: the handler is privileged because of the mode, not because the bit changed.

Privilege is borrowed only for the duration of the handler, and only code placed in the handler runs with it: the caller can request a service but cannot choose what executes. The immediate `#n` is encoded in the instruction and, together with arguments in `r0` – `r3`, can select the requested service. This is the hardware foundation of every system call: restricted code cannot touch the machine directly and must go through a single, controlled entry point.

> ⚠ **MISSING HANDLER**
>
> If `SVC_Handler` is not defined, `svc` reaches the default handler and the program hangs silently. Unlike a fault handler, `SVC_Handler` returns normally, because `svc` is a deliberate request, not an error.

6 Configuring the Core: SCB, NVIC, and SysTick

The behaviour of the exception model is configured through memory-mapped registers in the System Control Space. All of them are accessible only from privileged code.

6.1 System Control Block Registers

Register	Address	Role
`CPUID`	`0xE000_ED00`	Core identification (`0x410FC231` : ARM, Cortex-M3)
`ICSR`	`0xE000_ED04`	Pending state of system exceptions; `PENDSVSET` (bit 28) raises PendSV
`VTOR`	`0xE000_ED08`	Address of the vector table
`CCR`	`0xE000_ED14`	Which conditions are treated as faults
`SHPR1` – `SHPR3`	`0xE000_ED18` – `0xE000_ED20`	Priorities of system exceptions
`SHCSR`	`0xE000_ED24`	Enable and status of system handlers
`CFSR`	`0xE000_ED28`	Cause of MemManage, BusFault, UsageFault
`HFSR`	`0xE000_ED2C`	Cause of HardFault
`MMFAR`	`0xE000_ED34`	Address that caused a MemManage fault
`BFAR`	`0xE000_ED38`	Address that caused a BusFault

`VTOR`. On an exception the CPU reads the handler address from `VTOR + 4 × N`. Bits 31–7 hold the table address, which must be aligned to at least 128 bytes (more when many IRQs exist). Writing `VTOR` is redundant when the table is already at 0, but it makes the boot code correct wherever the image is placed: a bootloader at address 0 can start an application stored higher in Flash, which then points `VTOR` at its own table, or a program can copy its table into RAM to replace handlers at run time.

`SHCSR`. Bits 16 (`MEMFAULTENA`), 17 (`BUSFAULTENA`), and 18 (`USGFAULTENA`) enable the dedicated fault handlers. At reset they are 0, so every fault escalates to HardFault and a single handler cannot tell what went wrong. The other bits report whether handlers are active or pending, so the register is updated with read-modify-write (`|= 0x00070000`), never overwritten.

`CCR`. The configuration bits relevant here are listed below.

Bit	Name	Effect when set
3	`UNALIGN_TRP`	Unaligned word and halfword accesses raise a UsageFault
4	`DIV_0_TRP`	Integer division by zero raises a UsageFault
9	`STKALIGN`	8-byte stack alignment on exception entry (1 at reset)

Without `DIV_0_TRP` , `sdiv` and `udiv` silently return 0 when the divisor is 0 and the program continues with a wrong value; setting the bit turns this silent bug into a fault. Unaligned accesses are legal on the Cortex-M3, only

slower, and trapping them can break correct compiler-generated code, so `UNALIGN_TRP` is usually left off. Since `STKALIGN` is already 1, enabling the division trap requires read-modify-write, giving `0x210`.

`SHPR1` – `SHPR3`. Each system exception has one priority byte, so the three registers can be viewed as a 12-byte array starting at `0xE000_ED18`, indexed by exception number minus 4. Each byte is written with a byte store and needs no read-modify-write.

Register	Byte 0	Byte 1	Byte 2	Byte 3
`SHPR1`	MemManage	BusFault	UsageFault	—
`SHPR2`	—	—	—	SVCall
`SHPR3`	—	—	PendSV	SysTick

A typical policy makes faults most urgent (`0x00`), system calls intermediate (`0x80`), and PendSV and SysTick least urgent (`0xE0`). Reading the words as little-endian, this gives `SHPR2 = 0x80000000` and `SHPR3 = 0xE0E00000`.

6.2 Fault Status Registers

```
void UsageFault_Handler( void )
{
    kprintf( "UsageFault: CFSR=0x%x\n", SCB_CFSR );
    for ( ;; ) { }
}

int main( void )
{
    volatile uint32_t numerator = 42;
    volatile uint32_t zero = 0;
    volatile uint32_t result = numerator / zero;
    (void)result;
    for ( ;; ) { }
}
```

The divisor is `volatile`, so the compiler cannot evaluate the division at build time and must emit a real `udiv` instruction. With `CCR.DIV_0_TRP` and `SHCSR.USGFAULTENA` set, the instruction raises a UsageFault, the dedicated handler runs, and it prints `CFSR=0x2000000`: bit 25, `DIVBYZERO`. The handler then loops forever, because a fault is a bug with no sensible way to continue. Removing each configuration step isolates its role:

Configuration	Observed behaviour
`SHCSR` bits and `DIV_0_TRP` set	`UsageFault_Handler` runs and reports the cause
`SHCSR` bits not set	The fault escalates to HardFault; its kind is lost
`DIV_0_TRP` not set	No fault: the division returns 0 and `main` continues

`CFSR` is the concatenation of three status registers, one per configurable fault. Its most useful bits are:

Bits	Sub-register	Main flags
7–0	MMFSR (MemManage)	`IACCVIOL` (0), `DACCVIOL` (1), `MUNSTKERR` (3), `MSTKERR` (4), `MMARVALID` (7)
15–8	BFSR (BusFault)	`PRECISERR` (9), `IMPRECISERR` (10), `BFARVALID` (15)
31–16	UFSR (UsageFault)	`UNDEFINSTR` (16), `INVSTATE` (17), `UNALIGNED` (24), `DIVBYZERO` (25)

`HFSR` bit 30 (`FORCED`) indicates that the HardFault is an escalated configurable fault; the original cause is then found in `CFSR` . The bits are sticky and are cleared by writing 1 to them.

6.3 NVIC: Device Interrupts

```
NVIC->IPR[UART0TX_IRQn] = 0xC0;                              /* priority of IRQ 1 */
NVIC->ISER[UART0TX_IRQn / 32] = 1UL << ( UART0TX_IRQn % 32 ); /* enable IRQ 1 */
```

Device interrupt requests do not reach the CPU directly: they pass through the NVIC, which numbers them, enables them, and assigns their priority. The first line writes the priority byte of IRQ 1 with a byte store. The second sets bit `n % 32` of word `n / 32` in the enable register; since set and clear registers ignore 0 bits, a plain assignment enables one line without disturbing the others.

Register	Base address	Bit or byte for IRQ n	Write semantics
`ISER`	`0xE000_E100`	Bit `n % 32` of word `n / 32`	1 = enable
`ICER`	`0xE000_E180`	Same	1 = disable
`ISPR`	`0xE000_E200`	Same	1 = set pending
`ICPR`	`0xE000_E280`	Same	1 = clear pending
`IPR`	`0xE000_E400`	Byte n	Priority; lower = more urgent

A device interrupt runs its handler only if all of the following hold:

1. the device is configured to raise it (an interrupt-enable bit in the device's own control register);
2. the NVIC line is enabled in `ISER` ;
3. its priority is more urgent than that of the running code, and `PRIMASK` is 0.

NVIC lines driven by device flags are level-sensitive: as long as the device keeps its interrupt flag set, the request stays active. A handler must therefore *acknowledge* the interrupt at the device, typically by writing 1 to clear the flag, otherwise the handler is re-entered forever as soon as it returns.

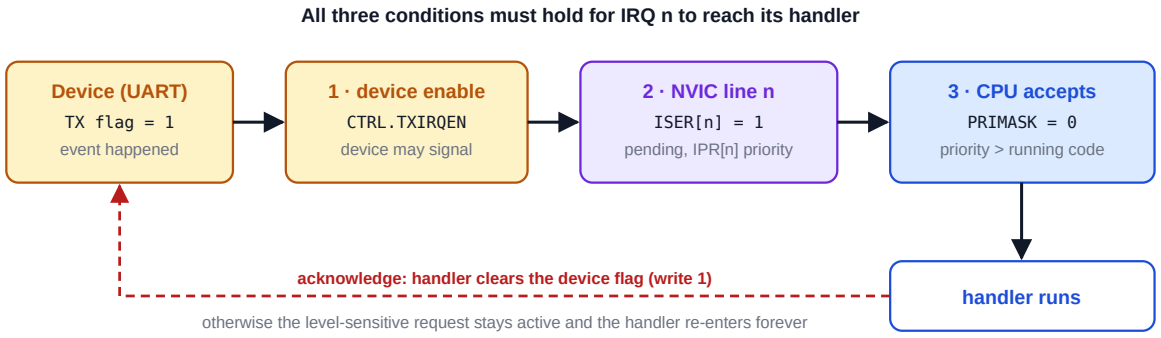


Figure 1.8: *Path of a device interrupt through the device enable, the NVIC, and the CPU masking and priority check, with acknowledgement at the device.*

6.4 SysTick: The Core Timer

SysTick is a 24-bit down-counter present in every Cortex-M core. It counts from the reload value to 0, reloads, and can raise exception 15 each time it reaches 0. An operating system uses this periodic exception, the *tick*, as its time base.

Register	Address	Content
`CTRL`	`0xE000_E010`	`ENABLE` (0), `TICKINT` (1), `CLKSOURCE` (2), `COUNTFLAG` (16, cleared on read)
`LOAD`	`0xE000_E014`	24-bit reload value (max `0xFFFFFF`)
`VAL`	`0xE000_E018`	Current count; any write clears it
`CALIB`	`0xE000_E01C`	Read-only; `TENMS` = reload value for 10 ms on the reference clock

`CLKSOURCE` selects between the processor clock (1) and an implementation-defined reference clock (0). On `mps2-an385` the reference clock runs at 1 MHz (`CALIB.TENMS = 9999`) and the processor clock at 25 MHz. `CALIB` serves portable code that does not know the processor frequency; when the frequency is known, the reload value is computed directly. Writing `CTRL = 7` starts the counter on the processor clock with the exception enabled.

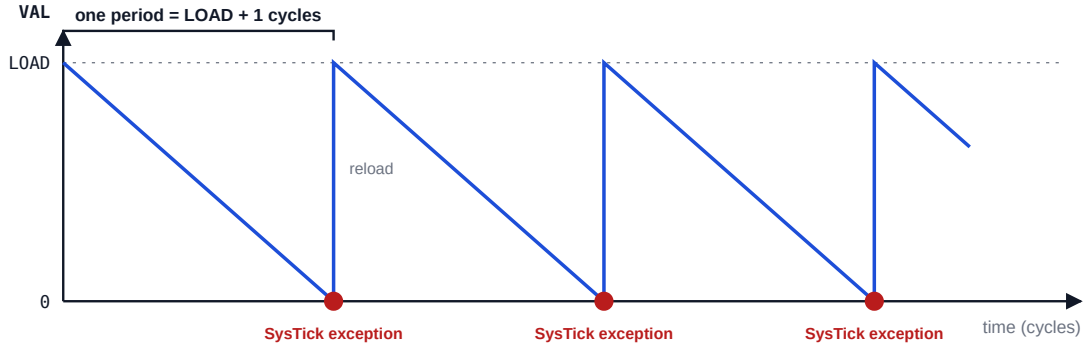


Figure 1.9: *SysTick counter value over time: a sawtooth from LOAD to 0 with an exception at every zero.*

Since one period lasts `LOAD + 1` cycles, the reload value for a tick rate r at clock frequency f is

$$\mathrm{LOAD} = \frac{f}{r} - 1$$

At 25 MHz and 100 ticks per second, `LOAD = 249 999` (`0x3D08F`), which fits in 24 bits; the longest possible period is 2^{24} cycles, about 0.67 s. A faster tick gives finer time resolution at the cost of more exceptions per second.

SysTick is a core exception, not a device interrupt, and this changes how it is configured and handled:

Aspect	SysTick	Device interrupt
Priority set in	`SHPR3`	NVIC `IPR`
Enabled by	`CTRL.TICKINT`	Device enable bit and NVIC `ISER`
Acknowledge in the handler	Not needed: pending state clears on entry	Required, otherwise the handler is re-entered

7 Memory Protection Unit

The Cortex-M3 has no MMU. What it offers instead is an optional **Memory Protection Unit** (MPU), present on `mps2-an385` and disabled after reset.

7.1 MPU Versus MMU

An MMU *translates* every virtual address into a physical one through page tables, and checks permissions as part of the translation. An MPU *only checks*: on every load, store, and instruction fetch, it compares the address with a short list of regions. If the access is allowed, it proceeds at the same physical address; if not, it does not happen at all (a store writes nothing, a load reads nothing) and the CPU raises a MemManage fault. Every task sees real physical addresses, so the linker must place each task at its own address.

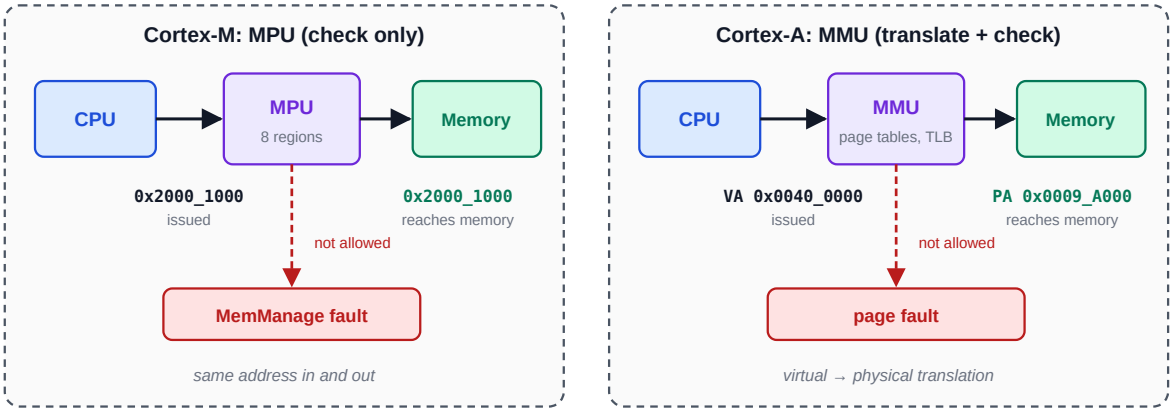


Figure 1.10: *Comparison of an MPU, which only checks addresses, and an MMU, which translates virtual to physical addresses.*

Microcontrollers adopt the MPU for reasons that follow directly from embedded constraints. An MPU is a handful of region registers, while an MMU needs page tables in RAM, a hardware table walker, and a TLB, which cost silicon area and energy. An MPU check takes the same time on every access, whereas a TLB miss makes some accesses slower by an amount that depends on the TLB contents, which harms timing predictability. Finally, with no disk and a small fixed set of tasks, virtual memory would bring no benefit.

7.2 Regions and Permissions

The Cortex-M3 MPU has 8 regions, numbered 0 to 7 (the count is read from `MPU_TYPE` bits 15–8). Each region has a base address, a size, permissions, and an enable bit, subject to two rules:

- the size is a power of two, from 32 bytes to 4 GB;
- the base address is a multiple of the size, i.e. the region is aligned to its own size.

A 4 KB region can start at `0x2000_1000` but not at `0x2000_0400`. A task that needs 5 KB receives an 8 KB region, the next power of two.

The **AP** (access permission) field encodes two rights at once, one for privileged and one for unprivileged code:

AP	Privileged	Unprivileged
`000`	No access	No access
`001`	Read/write	No access
`010`	Read/write	Read-only
`011`	Read/write	Read/write
`110`	Read-only	Read-only

The **XN** (execute never) bit forbids instruction fetches from a region while still allowing reads and writes if AP permits them. Marking data and stack regions XN prevents code injection: a task cannot execute machine code it has written into a buffer.

The **PRIVDEFENA** bit of `MPU_CTRL` decides what happens to privileged accesses that hit no region. When it is 1, they use the default memory map as if the MPU were off, so the kernel keeps access to all memory and peripherals and only unprivileged code is restricted. When it is 0, even privileged code may access only what the regions allow. An unprivileged access that hits no enabled region is always refused.

7.3 MPU Registers and Region Encoding

Register	Address	Fields
`MPU_TYPE`	`0xE000_ED90`	Bits 15–8: number of regions
`MPU_CTRL`	`0xE000_ED94`	`ENABLE` (0), `PRIVDEFENA` (2)
`MPU_RNR`	`0xE000_ED98`	Region selected by `RBAR` and `RASR`
`MPU_RBAR`	`0xE000_ED9C`	Base address (31–5), `VALID` (4), `REGION` (3–0)
`MPU_RASR`	`0xE000_EDA0`	`XN` (28), `AP` (26–24), `S` / `C` / `B` (18–16), `SIZE` (5–1), `ENABLE` (0)

A single `RBAR` / `RASR` pair serves all eight regions; `RNR` selects which one it refers to. When `RBAR` is written with its `VALID` bit set, the region number is taken from its own `REGION` field, so one write replaces the pair of writes to `RNR` and `RBAR`. The low 5 bits of a base address are always 0, because the base is aligned to at least 32 bytes, which leaves room for `VALID` and `REGION` in the same word.

The `SIZE` field holds $\log_2(\text{size}) - 1$, so a region spans $2^{\text{SIZE}+1}$ bytes; the offset of 1 lets 5 bits reach 4 GB with `SIZE = 31`. The `S`, `C`, and `B` bits describe the memory type for caches and multi-core systems and have no functional effect on a core without cache.

```
#define MPU_CTRL (*(volatile uint32_t *)0xE000ED94)
#define MPU_RBAR (*(volatile uint32_t *)0xE000ED9C)
#define MPU_RASR (*(volatile uint32_t *)0xE000EDA0)

void mpu_setup( void )
{
    MPU_RBAR = 0x00000000u | 0x10u | 0u;  /* region 0: Flash, VALID */
    MPU_RASR = 0x0602002Bu;               /* AP=110, C, 4 MB, enabled */
```

```
    MPU_RBAR = 0x20001000u | 0x10u | 1u;  /* region 1: task partition, VALID */
    MPU_RASR = 0x13060017u;               /* XN, AP=011, S, C, 4 KB, enabled */
    MPU_CTRL = ( 1u << 2 ) | 1u;          /* PRIVDEFENA | ENABLE */
    __asm volatile ( "dsb\n\tisb" : : : "memory" );
}
```

The function configures a typical two-region layout for running one unprivileged task. Region 0 covers the 4 MB of Flash as read-only and executable for everyone, so the task can run its code and read constants. Region 1 covers the 4 KB partition of the running task as read/write and non-executable. Everything else (other tasks' memory, kernel data, kernel stack, peripherals) has no region and is therefore forbidden to unprivileged code, while `PRIVDEFENA` leaves the kernel unrestricted. A kernel that switches tasks only needs to rewrite region 1. The final `dsb` waits for all register writes to complete and `isb` ensures that the following instructions are checked against the new regions.

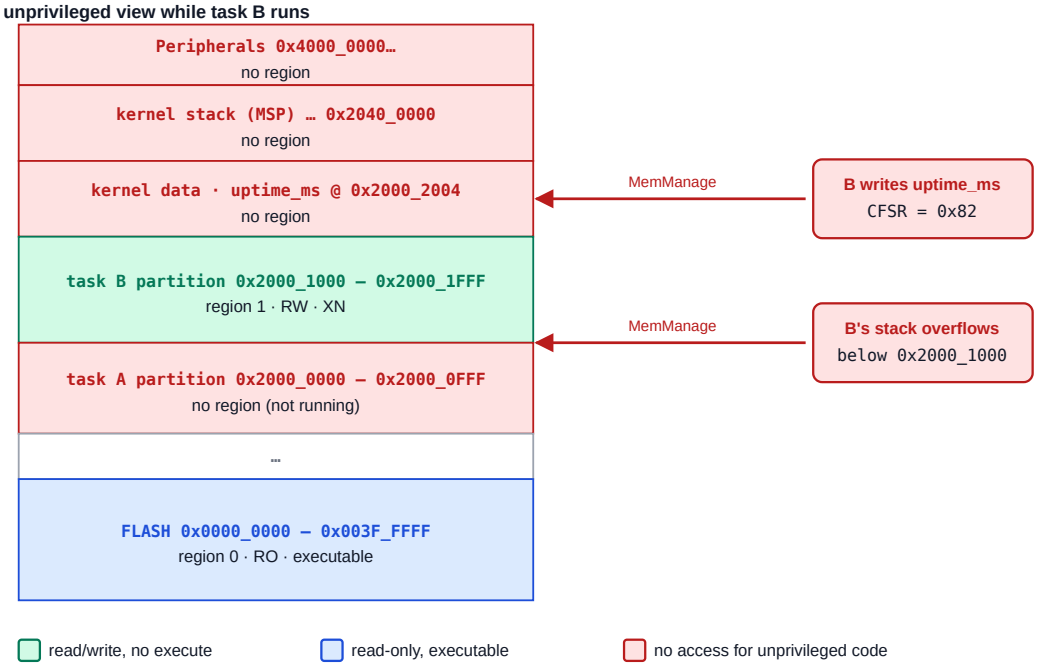
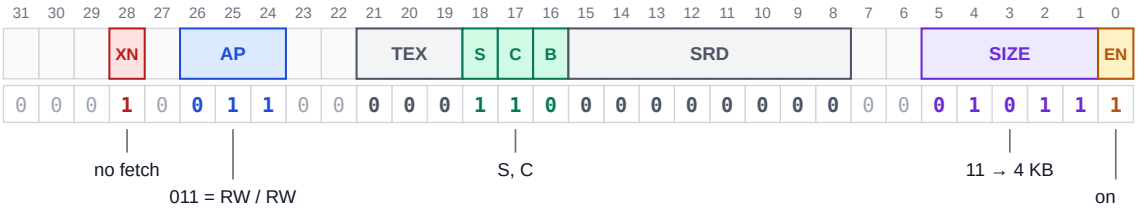


Figure 1.11: *Unprivileged view of memory with the MPU enabled while task B runs: Flash region 0, task B partition region 1, everything else forbidden.*

The two `RASR` values decompose as follows:

Field	Region 0 (Flash)	Region 1 (partition)
`XN` (bit 28)	0	1 → `0x10000000`
`AP` (bits 26–24)	`110` → `0x06000000`	`011` → `0x03000000`
`S`, `C` (bits 18, 17)	`C` → `0x00020000`	`S`, `C` → `0x00060000`
`SIZE` (bits 5–1)	21 (4 MB = 2^{22}) → `0x2A`	11 (4 KB = 2^{12}) → `0x16`
`ENABLE` (bit 0)	`0x01`	`0x01`
Total	`0x0602002B`	`0x13060017`



RASR = 0x1306_0017: region 1 (task partition) · TEX and SRD left at 0

Figure 1.12: *Field layout of MPU_RASR with the value 0x13060017 decoded bit by bit.*

7.4 MemManage Faults

A refused access raises MemManage (exception 4), which reaches its own handler only if `SHCSR.MEMFAULTENA` is set; otherwise it escalates to HardFault. The handler runs privileged and on `MSP`, and it finds the cause in the low byte of `CFSR`:

Bit	Name	Set when
0	`IACCVIOL`	An instruction fetch was refused (e.g. from an XN region)
1	`DACCVIOL`	A data load or store was refused
3	`MUNSTKERR`	Popping the frame on exception return was refused
4	`MSTKERR`	Pushing the frame on exception entry was refused
7	`MMARVALID`	`MMFAR` holds the refused address

Several bits can be set at once. A value of `0x82`, for example, means `MMARVALID` plus `DACCVIOL`: a data access was refused and its address is in `MMFAR`. Looking that address up in the symbol table of the image (with `nm`) names the variable the faulty code tried to touch. A task that overflows its stack below the start of its partition produces the same kind of fault, which makes the MPU an effective stack-overflow detector.

> **READ `MMFAR` ONLY WHEN `MMARVALID` IS SET**
>
> For instruction-fetch and stacking faults the CPU does not update `MMFAR`, which may then hold a stale, meaningless value.

1 Cross-Compilation Toolchain

1.1 Host, Target, and Emulator

Role	Meaning
Host	Computer running the editor, `make`, and the toolchain (x86-64 or Apple silicon)
Target	ARM Cortex-M3 machine for which the ELF is built
Emulator	QEMU model that executes target instructions on the host

A native `gcc` emits code for the machine it runs on; it cannot produce Cortex-M3 firmware just because the source language is C. A **cross toolchain** (`arm-none-eabi-*`) runs on the host but emits code for the target instruction set architecture (ISA).

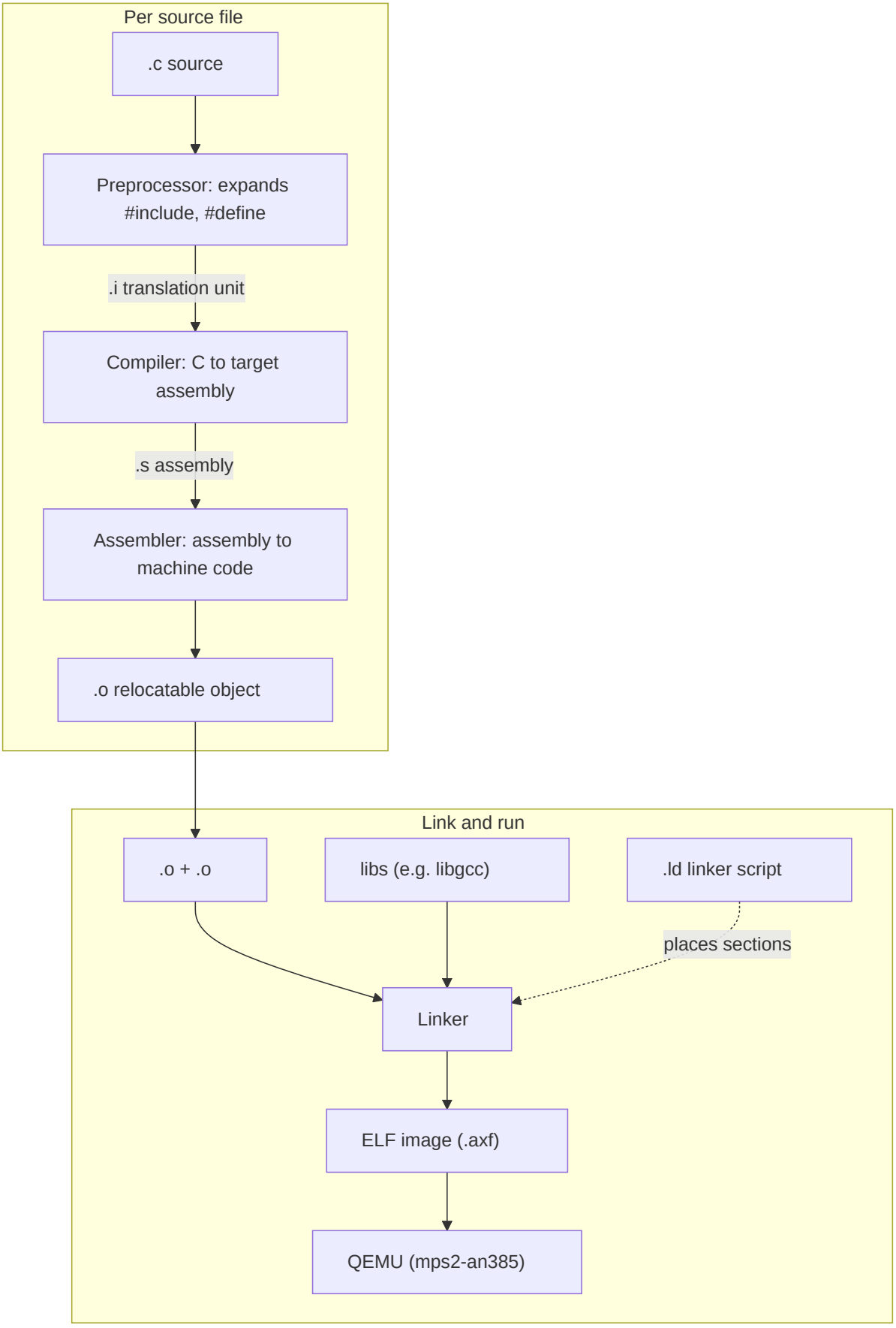
```
gcc -dumpmachine              # host triple, e.g. x86_64-linux-gnu
arm-none-eabi-gcc -dumpmachine  # target triple: arm-none-eabi
```

The triple `arm-none-eabi` means: ARM architecture, **no** operating system on the target, standard ARM **E**mbedded **ABI**.

- Consequences of "no OS":
  - No `_start` from a C library unless the application provides one.
  - No dynamic loader, and no process to return to when `main()` finishes.
  - No guaranteed `printf` console, no `malloc` backed by an OS.
- QEMU is not the target CPU, but it provides a reproducible board model before physical hardware is used.

1.2 Build Pipeline Stages

Figure 2.1 — Build pipeline from source files to the ELF image



Stage	What it does	Stop with	Output
Preprocessing	Expands `#include`, macros, conditional compilation; pure text substitution	`-E`	`.i` translation unit
Compilation	Checks syntax and types, **optimises**, emits **ARM assembly** for the selected CPU and ABI	`-S`	`.s`
Assembly	Encodes assembly into a **relocatable object file**	`-c`	`.o`
Linking	Combines objects, resolves symbols, assigns final addresses	(full run)	ELF image

- `arm-none-eabi-gcc` is a driver that invokes each stage in turn; `make` decides which files need rebuilding.
- **Preprocessing** produces one **translation unit**: a single file of plain C with every include and macro expanded.

```
arm-none-eabi-gcc -mthumb -mcpu=cortex-m3 -nostartfiles -ffreestanding \
    -E src/main.c -o build/main.i
```

In `main.i`, `#include <stdint.h>` is replaced inline by its typedefs; `main()` is unchanged text with comments stripped. `-E` only substitutes text and does not touch program logic.

```
arm-none-eabi-gcc -mthumb -mcpu=cortex-m3 -nostartfiles -ffreestanding \
    -S src/main.c -o build/main.s
```

In `main.s`, the `bkpt 0xab` instruction from the inline assembly in `main.c` passes through untouched; everything around it is Thumb-2 assembly generated from the C source.

1.3 Target Compiler and Linker Flags

```
CFLAGS := -mthumb -mcpu=cortex-m3 -nostartfiles -std=gnu17
CFLAGS += -Wall -Wextra -O0 -g3

LDFLAGS := -T scripts/mps2_m3.ld
LDFLAGS += -Xlinker -Map=build/output.map
```

Flag	Meaning
`-mthumb -mcpu=cortex-m3`	Selects the Thumb instruction subset implemented by the Cortex-M3
`-nostartfiles`	Excludes the toolchain's default C startup objects, so reset handling is done by the project's own startup code
`-ffreestanding`	Compiles for a freestanding (bare-metal) C environment, without hosted-library assumptions
`-std=gnu17`	C17 with GNU extensions

Flag	Meaning
`-Wall -Wextra`	Warning policy
`-O0 -g3`	No optimisation and full debug information: a debuggable, source-corresponding image
`-T scripts/mps2_m3.ld`	Uses the given linker script to describe memory and section placement
`-Xlinker -Map=build/output.map`	Makes the linker emit a map file of every placement and symbol address
`-nostdlib -lgcc`	Links no standard library, only `libgcc` for compiler support routines

- Target options must describe the actual machine: instruction set and Thumb execution, floating-point assumptions, freestanding environment, warning and optimisation policy. Host compiler defaults are not safe substitutes.
- Make variables keep the policy in one place:

Variable	Role
`CC`	Chooses the cross compiler (`arm-none-eabi-gcc`)
`CFLAGS`	Governs compilation of each source
`LDFLAGS`	Governs memory layout and the final link

> **DIAGNOSING A BUILD FAILURE**
>
> The full command line is the exact contract that produced the failure: copy it before changing anything.

- **Debug information** (`-g3`) is stored in the ELF for host tools: QEMU and a debugger can map an instruction address back to a C line, function, or variable. The target still executes only machine instructions; debug information does not change the boot image's behaviour.

1.4 Object Files, Symbols, and the Linker

An object file contains machine-code bytes, section names, symbol definitions, and **references whose final addresses are not yet known**. Each object is built independently, so its sections have no final position in Flash or SRAM.

```
arm-none-eabi-gcc -mthumb -mcpu=cortex-m3 -nostartfiles -ffreestanding \
    -c boot/startup.c -o build/boot/startup.o
arm-none-eabi-gcc -mthumb -mcpu=cortex-m3 -nostartfiles -ffreestanding \
    -c src/main.c -o build/src/main.o
arm-none-eabi-nm build/boot/startup.o build/src/main.o
```

`nm` output	Meaning
`U main` in `startup.o`	Undefined: referenced (by `Reset_Handler`) but not defined in this object

`nm` output	Meaning
`T main` in `main.o`	Defined, in the `.text` section

- Unresolved references are normal at this stage; neither object is a runnable program.
- The **linker**:
  - Concatenates matching sections from all objects.
  - Resolves every symbol (e.g., `main`, `_estack`) to a final address and patches all references.
  - Checks that every referenced symbol has exactly one valid definition.

```
arm-none-eabi-gcc -mthumb -mcpu=cortex-m3 -nostartfiles -ffreestanding \
    -T scripts/mps2_m3.ld -Xlinker -Map=build/output.map -nostdlib -lgcc \
    build/boot/startup.o build/src/main.o -o build/scratch-os.axf
arm-none-eabi-nm build/scratch-os.axf | grep -w main
```

- In the final image `main` is `T`: the `U` in `startup.o` has been connected to the `T` in `main.o`. The map file shows which object supplied `main` and its final address.
- The **linker script** (`.ld`) states where things go: physical addresses of `FLASH` and `RAM`, the contents of `.text`, `.data`, `.bss`, where the stack starts, and where the vector table must sit.
- On a desktop the default linker script is invisible; on bare metal it must be supplied, because only the developer knows the chip's memory map.
- Separate compilation followed by linking enables fast incremental builds.

2 ELF Image Format and Memory Layout

2.1 Sections, Segments, and the ELF Header

- ELF (Executable and Linkable Format) is the format of the final image `build/scratch-os.axf`; the `.axf` suffix conventionally denotes an **ARM executable** with debug information.
- The image is a 32-bit, little-endian ARM ELF executable with several views of the same bytes:
  - **ELF header** at offset 0: points to the section and program-header tables and names the entry point.
  - **Sections** (for the linker and debugger): `.text`, `.rodata`, `.data`, `.bss`, symbol tables, debug information.
  - **Program headers / segments** (for a loader): which chunks map to which memory at run time.
  - **Symbols**: names for final addresses.
- Inspection tools: `arm-none-eabi-readelf`, `arm-none-eabi-objdump`, `arm-none-eabi-nm`, `arm-none-eabi-size`.

Section	Contents	Placement
`.isr_vector`	Initial **stack pointer** and handler addresses	Start of Flash
`.text`	**Executable** instructions	Flash
`.rodata`	**Read-only** constants	Flash
`.data`	Writable **variables** with initial values	Runs in SRAM, initial image stored in Flash
`.bss`	Writable **zero-initialised** variables	SRAM

`arm-none-eabi-objdump -h` lists each section with two addresses:

- **VMA** (virtual memory address): the run address.
- **LMA** (load memory address): where the bytes are stored in the image.
- They differ only for `.data`: VMA in RAM, LMA in Flash. This difference is what the startup copy loop resolves.

2.2 Entry Point and the Thumb Bit

2.2.1 ARM and Thumb instruction sets

ARM cores define two instruction sets: **ARM** (32-bit instructions) and **Thumb** (16-bit instructions, extended to mixed 16/32-bit in Thumb-2). A core supporting both must know, at every branch, which set the target code uses.

> **IMPORTANT**
>
> The Cortex-M3 executes **only Thumb**.

Thumb instructions are 2 or 4 bytes long and always start at an **even** address. The linker places them in the `.text` output section, in Flash.

As a consequence, the bit 0 of the start address of an instruction is **always 0** and **carries no information**. ARM reuses it as a state flag in every **code pointer**, i.e. every stored address the CPU branches to (vector-table entry,

function pointer, ELF entry point, target of `bx` / `blx`):

- **Bit 0 = 1**: the target is **Thumb code**.
- **Bit 0 = 0**: the target is **ARM code**, which does not exist on Cortex-M and raises a **UsageFault** (invalid state).

2.2.2 How the linker produces `0x48` and `0x49`

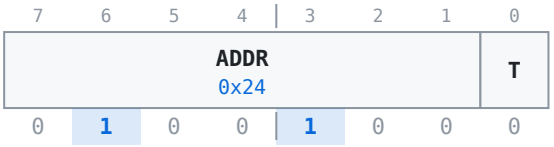
- **Placement**: the linker fills Flash in the order given by the linker script. The 64-byte vector table occupies `0x00` – `0x3F`; `.text` begins at `0x40` with the code of `startup.o`, inside which the first instruction of `Reset_Handler` lands at `0x48`. The symbol `Reset_Handler` therefore takes the value `0x48`.
- **Marking**: the compiler (or `.thumb_func` in assembly) records in the object file that `Reset_Handler` is a Thumb function.
- **Writing code pointers**: wherever the address of a Thumb function is stored as a branch target, the linker writes `address | 1` (bitwise OR: bit 0 set to 1, i.e. +1 for an even address):
  - Vector table word 1 (`.word Reset_Handler`): `0x48 | 1 = 0x49`.
  - Entry field of the ELF header (from `ENTRY(Reset_Handler)` in the linker script): `0x49`.
- **Reset**: the CPU loads `0x49` from vector word 1, checks bit 0 = 1 (Thumb, valid), sets the `T` bit of `xPSR`, clears bit 0, and starts executing with `PC = 0x48`.

```
0x48 = 0100 1000   location of the first instruction
0x49 = 0100 1001   code pointer: same location + Thumb flag in bit 0
```

The two values side by side: the address bits are identical, only bit 0 differs.

`symbol` 8-bit **= 0x48**

Low byte of Reset_Handler's address (map file, nm, objdump)



Bits	Field	Value	Description
7:1	`ADDR`	0x24 (36)	Instruction address bits
0	`T`	0 → even location	Bit 0 0 = even location, 1 = Thumb code pointer

`pointer` 8-bit **= 0x49**

Low byte of the code pointer (vector word 1, ELF entry)



Bits	Field	Value	Description
7:1	`ADDR`	0x24 (36)	Instruction address bits: the same instruction
0	`T`	1 → Thumb code pointer	Bit 0 0 = even location, 1 = Thumb code pointer

2.2.3 Inspection tools and what they report

Tool	What it is	Value for `Reset_Handler`
Map file `build/output.map`	Text report written by the linker during the link (`-Map=`): output sections, input pieces with their `.o` , address of every symbol	`0x00000048` (location)
`arm-none-eabi-nm`	Lists the symbols of an object or ELF file with address and type letter	`00000048 T Reset_Handler` (location)
`arm-none-eabi-objdump -d`	Disassembles the code: every instruction with the address where it is stored	`00000048 <Reset_Handler>:` (location)
`arm-none-eabi-readelf -h`	Prints the ELF header, including the entry point	`Entry point address: 0x49` (code pointer)

- Map file, `nm` , and `objdump` answer "where are the bytes stored?": even value.
- ELF entry point and vector table answer "how does the CPU branch there?": odd value.
- No instruction starts at `0x49` : the byte at `0x49` belongs to the instruction that starts at `0x48` . Both values identify the same instruction, once as a location and once as a branch target.
- Data pointers are unaffected: bit 0 has this meaning only for addresses used as branch targets (e.g., `&counter` is a plain address).

THUMB ADDRESS RULE

- Symbol address (where the bytes are stored): always even, e.g. `0x48` .
- Code-pointer value (how the CPU branches there): symbol address `| 1` , e.g. `0x49` .
- On Cortex-M, a code pointer with bit 0 = 0 raises a UsageFault.

2.3 Worked Layout from the Map File

2.3.1 What the map file is

The **map file** (`build/output.map` , also called *link map*) is a text report written by the linker while it builds the image, requested with `-Xlinker -Map=build/output.map` .

- It records every placement decision of the linker: where each piece of the program ended up in memory, how large it is, and which object file it came from.
- It is the reference for the question **"where did this function, variable, or constant end up?**".

```
Memory Configuration

Name             Origin             Length
FLASH            0x00000000         0x00400000
RAM              0x20000000         0x00400000

Linker script and memory map

.isr_vector     0x00000000       0x40
 .isr_vector    0x00000000       0x40 build/boot/startup.o

.text           0x00000040       0xa0
 .text          0x00000040       0x64 build/boot/startup.o
                0x00000048                Reset_Handler
 .text          0x000000a4       0x2c build/src/main.o
                0x000000bc                main
 .rodata        0x000000d0        0xe build/src/main.o
```

Line type	Example	Meaning
Memory Configuration row	`FLASH 0x00000000 0x00400000`	A `MEMORY` region of the linker script: name, start, length
Non-indented section line	`.text 0x00000040 0xa0`	An **output section** of the final image: start address and size
Indented line with a `.o`	`.text 0x00000040 0x64 build/boot/startup.o`	An **input piece** of that output section: address, size, source object file

Line type	Example	Meaning
Address followed by a name	`0x00000048 Reset_Handler`	A **symbol** (function or variable) and its final address

- The excerpt above is simplified; the real file also lists debug sections, discarded sections, and linker-script symbols.
- Static (file-local) functions and variables do not appear as symbols in the map file.

2.3.2 Placement rules that produce the layout

The linker fills each region following three ordering rules:

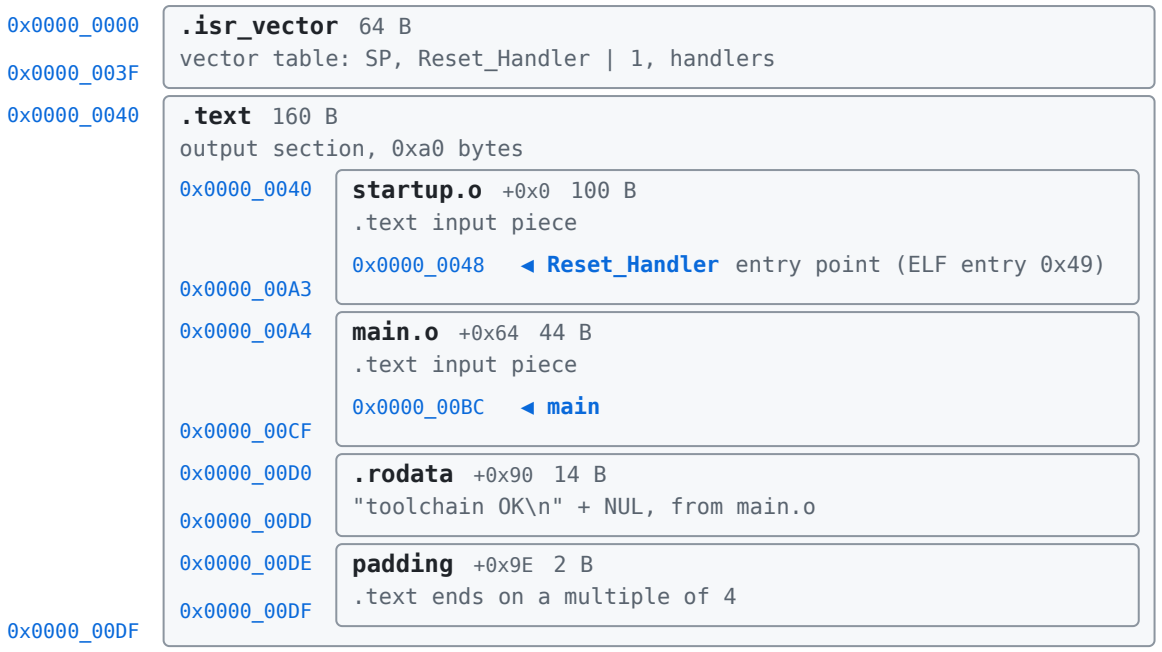
- **Order of output sections in the linker script**: `.isr_vector` first, then `.text`. The vector table (16 words × 4 bytes = 64 bytes = `0x40`) therefore starts at `0x00`, and `.text` starts right after it at `0x40`.
- **Order of object files on the link command line**: `startup.o` before `main.o`. The `0x64` bytes of `startup.o` occupy `0x40` – `0xA3`; the `0x2c` bytes of `main.o` follow at `0xA4` (`0x40 + 0x64`).
- **Order of rules inside `.text`**: `*(.text*)` (all code) before `*(.rodata*)` (all constants). The string literal therefore comes after **all** code, at `0xD0` (`0xA4 + 0x2C`), not next to `main`.

2.3.3 Flash Layout (`0x00` – `0xDF`, 224 bytes)

Address range	Size (bytes)	Content	Output section	From
`0x00` – `0x03`	4	Vector word 0: initial SP = `0x20400000`	`.isr_vector`	`startup.o`
`0x04` – `0x07`	4	Vector word 1: `Reset_Handler | 1` = `0x49`	`.isr_vector`	`startup.o`
`0x08` – `0x3F`	56	Vector words 2–15: addresses of the other exception handlers	`.isr_vector`	`startup.o`
`0x40` – `0x47`	8	Code of `startup.o` placed before `Reset_Handler`	`.text`	`startup.o`
`0x48` – `0xA3`	92	`Reset_Handler` (first instruction at `0x48`, the entry point) and the rest of the code of `startup.o`	`.text`	`startup.o`
`0xA4` – `0xBB`	24	Code of `main.o` placed before `main` (static helpers such as `semihost_write0`)	`.text`	`main.o`
`0xBC` – `0xCF`	20	`main`	`.text`	`main.o`
`0xD0` – `0xDD`	14	String literal `"toolchain OK\n"` plus terminating NUL	`.rodata`, folded into `.text`	`main.o`
`0xDE` – `0xDF`	2	Alignment padding (`.text` ends on a multiple of 4)	`.text`	linker

The same layout as a map, with the input pieces drawn inside their output section:

Figure 2.2 — Flash after linking (from build/output.map)

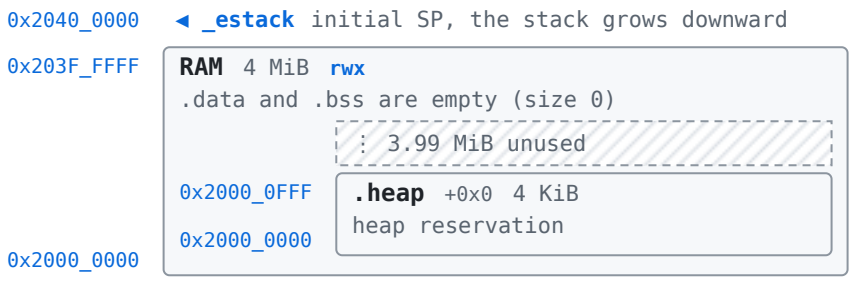


- End of `.text` : `0x40 + 0xA0 = 0xE0` , i.e. 224 bytes of Flash, the `text` value reported by `arm-none-eabi-size` .

2.3.4 RAM Layout (`0x20000000` – `0x203FFFFF` , 4 MiB)

Address range	Size (bytes)	Content	Output section
`0x20000000`	0	Initialised globals (none in this program)	`.data`
`0x20000000`	0	Zero-initialised globals (none in this program)	`.bss`
`0x20000000` – `0x20000FFF`	4096 (`0x1000`)	Heap reservation	`.heap`
`0x20001000` –...	—	Free RAM	—
...– `0x203FFFFF`	—	Stack, growing downward from `_estack` = `0x20400000`	—

Figure 2.3 — RAM after linking



- `.data` and `.bss` have size 0, so they occupy no bytes and `.heap` starts at the same address.

> **EMPTY `.DATA` AND `.BSS`**
>
> - Size 0 only means that this program has no initialised or zero-initialised global variables.
> - The startup code must still copy `.data` and zero `.bss` in general: any global or static variable makes the same loops do visible work.

2.4 Flash and RAM Budgets

- `.bss` has a size in memory but usually no bytes in the ELF file: startup code creates its zero values.
- `.data` consumes **both** Flash (initial bytes) and SRAM (run-time copy).

```
Flash usage = code + constants + .data initial image
RAM usage   = .data + .bss + stack + heap reservation
```

`arm-none-eabi-size build/scratch-os.axf` reports `text` = 224, `data` = 0, `bss` = 4096 bytes:

- `text` = `0x40 + 0xa0` = 224 bytes (vector table plus code and constants).
- `bss` includes the 4096-byte heap reservation.
- `text + data` must fit in Flash; `data + bss` must fit in RAM: the same bytes of `.data` are counted against two budgets.

> **FILE SIZE IS NOT RAM USAGE**
>
> The ELF file size includes debug information and excludes `.bss`; memory budgets are read from the `size` columns and the link map.

3 Bare-Metal Runtime: Startup Code, Semihosting, and QEMU Execution

3.1 Startup Code Responsibilities

On a desktop, the OS loader and C runtime prepare memory and invoke the program. On a bare-metal target no such service exists at boot: the application supplies its own runtime.

- With `-nostartfiles`, the toolchain's startup objects are excluded and `boot/startup.c` takes over. The startup code must:
  - Provide the vector table.
  - Initialise `.data` (copy initial values from Flash to RAM) and `.bss` (fill with zeros).
  - Call constructors if the language or runtime requires them.
  - Call `main()` and define what happens if it returns.

After these steps, every global variable has its promised value when `main()` starts.

- `Default_Handler`: an **infinite loop** installed for unimplemented exception vectors. Stopping in a known loop is safer and more diagnosable than executing arbitrary memory after an unexpected exception.
- `main()` has **no operating system to return to**: if it returns, `Reset_Handler` enters a final `for( ;; ) {}` spin loop.

> ⚠ **QEMU DOES NOT EXIT**
>
> After `main()` returns, the target keeps executing the final spin loop, so QEMU keeps running and must be interrupted manually. The printed line is evidence that execution reached the intended point, not an exit notification.

3.2 Semihosting Output via `bkpt 0xab`

3.2.1 The problem

A bare-metal program has no console and no OS: `printf` needs a C library and an OS underneath (none present), and output through a UART needs a peripheral driver (not written yet).

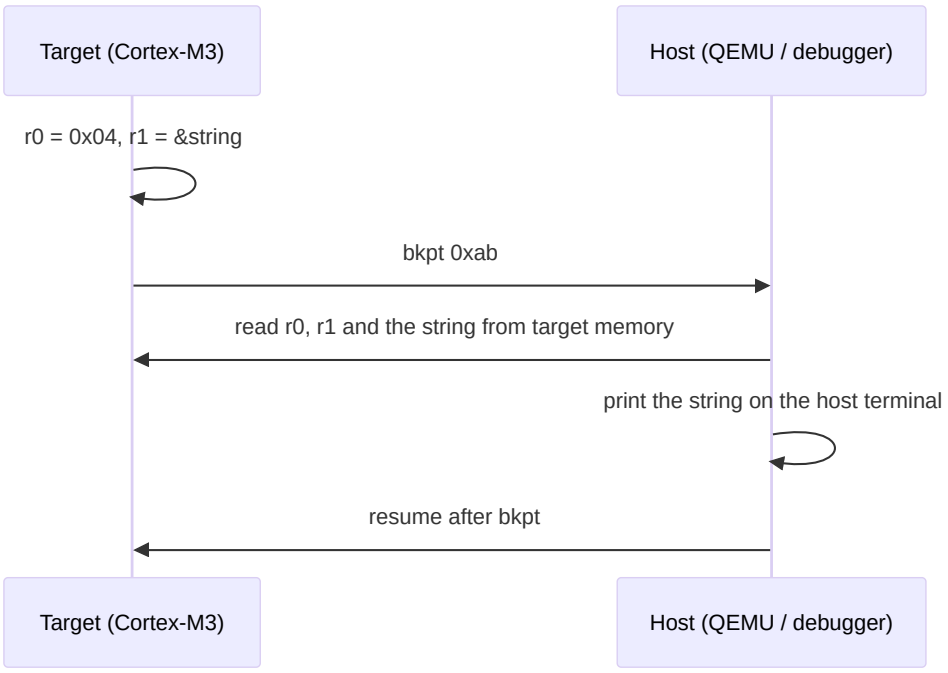
- **Semihosting** solves this during development: the program running on the target asks the **host** (the computer running QEMU or a debugger) to perform an I/O operation on its behalf. The target borrows the host's console, files, and clock.

3.2.2 How a Semihosting Request Works

A semihosting request follows a fixed convention, defined by ARM's semihosting specification and shared by the program and by every debugger or emulator that supports semihosting. The convention states where the program places its request and which instruction announces it. Because both sides follow the same rules, the host knows exactly where to look for the request and how to interpret it.

Element	Role in the request	Value for string output
`r0`	Operation number: which service is requested	`0x04` (`SYS_WRITE0` , "print a NUL-terminated string")
`r1`	Argument: the data the service needs	Address of the string in target memory
`bkpt 0xab`	Signal: the request is ready	—

Figure 2.4 — A semihosting request



On the target side, the program loads `0x04` into `r0`, loads the address of the string into `r1`, and executes `bkpt 0xab`. On the host side, QEMU notices the breakpoint and recognises the immediate value `0xab` as a semihosting request. It reads `r0` to learn which service is requested and `r1` to find the string, copies the bytes from the target's memory up to the terminating NUL, and prints them on the host terminal. The target then resumes at the instruction following `bkpt`, as if that instruction had done nothing.

The choice of a breakpoint instruction is deliberate. `bkpt` normally halts the processor and hands control to an attached debugger. The semihosting convention reuses this behaviour, and the immediate value `0xab` tells the debugger or emulator that the halt is a service request, not a breakpoint set by a developer.

This pattern is a **trap**: the program suspends its own work, control passes to a more powerful entity outside the CPU that performs the operation, and control then returns to the program. A system call in an operating system has the same shape, with the kernel playing the role of the host.

> ⚠ **DEVELOPMENT TOOL ONLY**
>
> Semihosting works only when a debugger, or an emulator started with semihosting enabled (`-semihosting` in QEMU), is attached and listening. On a real board with nothing attached, no one answers the request and `bkpt` simply halts the CPU. For this reason, production firmware produces its output through a peripheral, such as a UART driver, instead of semihosting.

3.2.3 Implementation in C

```c
#include <stdint.h>

static void semihost_write0( const char *message )
{
    register uint32_t    r0 __asm__( "r0" ) = 0x04;    /* SYS_WRITE0 */
    register const char *r1 __asm__( "r1" ) = message; /* string address */
    __asm__ volatile ( "bkpt 0xab" : : "r"( r0 ), "r"( r1 ) : "memory" );
}

int main( void )
{
    semihost_write0( "toolchain OK\n" );
    return 0;
}
```

Code	Meaning
`register uint32_t r0 __asm__( "r0" ) = 0x04;`	GCC extension: the variable is forced into register `r0` and holds the operation number `SYS_WRITE0`; standard C cannot choose registers
`register const char *r1 __asm__( "r1" ) = message;`	The string address is forced into register `r1`
`__asm__ volatile ( "bkpt 0xab" ... )`	Inline assembly (an assembly instruction embedded in C): inserts `bkpt 0xab`, which no C statement can express; `volatile` prevents the compiler from removing it
`: : "r"( r0 ), "r"( r1 )`	Input operands: guarantee that `r0` and `r1` hold their values when `bkpt` executes
`: "memory"`	Clobber: the instruction reads memory (the string), so all pending writes to memory are completed before it
`semihost_write0( "toolchain OK\n" );`	Prints the message on the host terminal: at C level the function means "the host prints `message`"

- `printf` is not used: it requires the C-library initialisation (newlib's semihosting-backed `stdio`) that the custom reset path does not perform.
- `arm-none-eabi-objdump -d build/scratch-os.axf | grep -A2 bkpt` shows the `bkpt 0xab` instruction inside the compiled image.

3.3 QEMU Board Model

```
qemu-system-arm -machine mps2-an385 -kernel build/scratch-os.axf -nographic -semihosting
```

- `qemu-system-arm` emulates an ARM system and selected board peripherals.
- `-machine mps2-an385` : the machine choice determines CPU, memory map, and available devices (here a Cortex-M3 board); it must match the memory model in the linker script.
- `-kernel` : the image to boot, which remains an ARM ELF, not a host (Linux or macOS) program.
- `-nographic` : target console routed to the host terminal.
- `-semihosting` : enables interception of `bkpt 0xab` requests.

3.4 What the Output Proves and Failure Localisation

Seeing `toolchain OK` proves that several independent contracts agree:

- The cross compiler emitted valid target instructions.
- The linker placed startup and application code at usable addresses.
- The processor found the vector table and reset reached `Reset_Handler`.
- Startup code established the runtime state and reached `main()`.
- The output mechanism (semihosting) was enabled and recognised by QEMU.

It does not prove that future drivers or timing properties are correct: it is a narrow but valuable check.

When QEMU prints nothing, work outward from the earliest guaranteed event:

- Confirm the ELF was rebuilt and passed to QEMU.
- Inspect vector-table and section addresses.
- Check that the machine name matches the linker script's memory model.
- Confirm startup reaches `main()`.
- Check the output configuration (semihosting options, call to `semihost_write0`, console routing).

Symptom	Where to look
Compiler rejects a command	Cross-toolchain installation and Makefile flags
Unresolved symbol	Object list and matching declarations
Section overflow	Linker-script memory regions and the map file
QEMU starts but prints nothing	Reset path, output call, semihosting options

- Disciplined build loop: build with `make`, read the command and the **first** diagnostic, run the ELF in QEMU, compare observed and expected output.
- Compilation failures, boot failures, and program-logic bugs must be kept separate.

> **LOCATE THE FAILING BOUNDARY**
>
> Changing random compiler flags is not a diagnosis; the first step is to identify which boundary of the pipeline failed.

4 Build Automation with Make

4.1 Rules, Prerequisites, and Timestamp-Based Rebuilds

`make` is not a compiler: it reads a `Makefile` describing a graph of **targets** and runs only the commands needed to bring the requested targets up to date. The alternative, typing every compiler command by hand, is slow and error-prone; `make` is the reproducible build.

```
target: prerequisite1 prerequisite2
         recipe line 1
         recipe line 2
```

- `target` : normally a file to produce (object file, ELF image).
- `prerequisites` : files that must be current before the recipe runs.
- `recipe` : shell commands that produce the target; **every recipe line starts with a literal Tab**, not spaces.
- A target is **out of date** and its recipe runs if the target does not exist, or if any prerequisite is newer (by modification time) than the target.
- Targets may depend on other targets, forming a **dependency graph** walked bottom-up:

```
main.c changed      --> main.o rebuilt --> scratch-os.axf relinked
startup.c unchanged --> startup.o reused
```

- The rebuild logic is correct only if the graph is complete:
  - Header dependencies must be tracked so that an interface change recompiles the affected sources.
  - A linker script that is not listed as a prerequisite does not trigger a relink when it changes; `make clean && make` forces a full rebuild.

4.2 Diagnosing the Missing Separator Error

```
CC := arm-none-eabi-gcc
BUILD_DIR := build

$(BUILD_DIR)/%.o: %.c
    @mkdir -p $(dir $@)
         $(CC) $(CFLAGS) -c $< -o $@
```

```
$ make
Makefile:5: *** missing separator.  Stop.
```

- `Makefile:5` is exact: line 5 is indented with four spaces instead of a Tab.
- `missing separator` describes what the parser expected (the Tab that marks a recipe line), not what is written: without it, `make` tried to parse the line as an assignment or a rule and failed.
- Spaces and a Tab look identical in an editor; the defect is visible only by rendering the bytes:

```
$ cat -et Makefile
CC := arm-none-eabi-gcc$
BUILD_DIR := build$
$
$(BUILD_DIR)/%.o: %.c$
    @mkdir -p $(dir $@)$
^I$(CC) $(CFLAGS) -c $< -o $@$
```

- `cat -et` marks each line end with `$` and each Tab with `^I`; line 5 lacks the `^I`.
- Portability:
  - `cat -A` exists only in GNU `cat`; BSD `cat` rejects it. `cat -et` works on both.
  - `sed -n l` is a portable alternative (Tab shown as `\t`), but BSD `sed` wraps long lines at about 70 columns.
- General technique: when a tool rejects a line that looks correct, render its bytes instead of rereading its characters.
- Editors can be configured not to expand Tabs in Makefiles.

4.3 Variables and Assignment Flavours

```
CC := arm-none-eabi-gcc
CFLAGS := -mthumb -mcpu=cortex-m3
CFLAGS += -Wall -Wextra
```

Operator	Name	Behaviour
`:=`	Simply expanded	Right-hand side evaluated once, immediately (preferred default)
`=`	Recursively expanded	Re-evaluated at every use; can be slow or loop if self-referential
`+=`	Append	Adds to the current value
`?=`	Conditional	Assigns only if not already set; allows overrides such as `make CC=clang` or the environment

- Variables are expanded with `$(NAME)`.
- Convention: uppercase names (`CC`, `CFLAGS`, `LDFLAGS`) are the tool and flags used by recipes; `make`'s built-in rules look for these exact names. Other names (`SOURCES`, `OBJECTS`, `BUILD_DIR`) hold the Makefile's own bookkeeping.

4.4 Automatic Variables, Pattern Rules, and Wildcards

Variable	Meaning
`$@`	Target of the rule

Variable	Meaning
`$<`	First prerequisite
`$^`	All prerequisites, space-separated, duplicates removed
`$*`	Stem matched by `%` in a pattern rule
`$(dir $@)`	Directory part of `$@` (a built-in function, not an automatic variable)

```
$(BUILD_DIR)/%.o: %.c
        @mkdir -p $(dir $@)
        $(CC) $(CFLAGS) -c $< -o $@
```

- `%.o: %.c` is a **pattern rule**: `%` is a stem that must match on both sides. For `build/src/main.o`, the stem is `src/main` and the prerequisite is `src/main.c`. One rule covers every object file.
- `$(dir $@)` (e.g., `build/boot/`) lets `mkdir -p` create the output directory before the compiler writes into it; `$<` is the `.c` file; `$@` is the `.o` being produced.
- `%` is a `make` mechanism, distinct from shell globbing. The glob equivalent is the `$(wildcard ...)` function, evaluated when the Makefile is read:

```
SOURCES := $(wildcard boot/*.c src/*.c)
```

Source list style	Advantage	Risk
Explicit (`SOURCES := boot/startup.c src/main.c`)	Easy to audit; a renamed file fails loudly	Must be maintained by hand
`$(wildcard ...)`	New files picked up automatically	Silently includes or excludes files

- An explicit list suits small trees; `$(wildcard ...)` suits large trees where manual maintenance is the bigger risk.
- `$(SOURCES:%.c=$(BUILD_DIR)/%.o)` is a **substitution reference**, shorthand for `$(patsubst %.c,$(BUILD_DIR)/%.o,$(SOURCES))`. It maps the source list to `build/boot/startup.o build/src/main.o`, connecting it to the pattern rule.

4.5 Phony Targets and the Default Goal

```
.PHONY: all clean run

all: $(BIN)

run: $(BIN)
        qemu-system-arm -machine mps2-an385 ...

clean:
```

```
	rm -rf $(BUILD_DIR)
```

- `run` and `clean` name actions, not files. If a file named `clean` existed, `make` would consider the target up to date and skip the recipe. `.PHONY` declares that a target is not a file, so its recipe always runs.
- `all` is the conventional **default goal**: the first target in the file, built when `make` is invoked without arguments. With `$(BIN)` as its only prerequisite it is an alias for the real image.

4.6 Inspecting Makefile State

A Makefile can be wrong without failing (e.g., a wrong substitution silently builds the wrong list). The useful information is what variables *expanded to*, not what the text says.

```
SOURCES := boot/startup.c src/main.c
BUILD_DIR := build
OBJECTS := $(SOURCES:%.c=$(BUILD_DIR)/%.o)
CFLAGS := -mthumb -mcpu=cortex-m3
CFLAGS += -Wall -Wextra

$(info OBJECTS = $(OBJECTS))
$(warning CFLAGS is $(CFLAGS))

print-%:
	@echo "$* = $($*)"

all:
	@echo linking
```

```
$ make all
OBJECTS = build/boot/startup.o build/src/main.o
Makefile:8: CFLAGS is -mthumb -mcpu=cortex-m3 -Wall -Wextra
linking
```

- `$(info ...)` and `$(warning ...)` are expanded while the Makefile is **read**, before any recipe runs: they show the value at that point in the file (after the `+=` here).
- `$(warning ...)` adds the `file:line:` prefix, useful when several are present.
- Both fire on every invocation, including `make clean`: they are temporary debugging aids.
- `print-%` uses the pattern mechanism and `$*` to query any variable: `make print-CFLAGS` prints `CFLAGS = -mthumb -mcpu=cortex-m3 -Wall -Wextra`.
- `make -n` prints the commands a goal would run without executing them, to verify that `$<` and `$@` expand as intended.
- `make -p` dumps the whole database (over 1300 lines for a 14-line Makefile, mostly built-in defaults); useful only when the cause lies in something not written in the Makefile.

4.7 The Complete Build Graph

```
SOURCES := boot/startup.c src/main.c
OBJECTS := $(SOURCES:%.c=$(BUILD_DIR)/%.o)

.PHONY: all clean run
all: $(BIN)

$(BUILD_DIR)/%.o: %.c
        @mkdir -p $(dir $@)
        $(CC) $(CFLAGS) -c $< -o $@

$(BIN): $(OBJECTS)
        $(CC) $(CFLAGS) $(LDFLAGS) $(OBJECTS) -o $(BIN)

run: $(BIN)
        qemu-system-arm ...

clean:
        rm -rf $(BUILD_DIR)
```

- Three-level graph: `run` depends on `$(BIN)`, `$(BIN)` on `$(OBJECTS)`, each object on its `.c` file.
- `make` (equivalent to `make all`): builds missing or stale objects through the pattern rule, then runs the link recipe. Running it again with no changes does nothing.
- `make run`: rebuilds anything stale, then boots the image in QEMU.
- The graph is the record of what the image is made of; re-running it is correct whether nothing changed, one file changed, or `build/` does not exist.
- A separate **build directory** holds generated objects, dependency files, maps, and ELF images:
  - Source directories stay readable.
  - `clean` can remove all generated files safely.
  - Different configurations can coexist.
  - A fresh build tests whether the dependency graph is complete.
- Generated objects and ELF bytes are never edited by hand to change program behaviour.

1 Memory Technologies on a Microcontroller

A microcontroller contains two fundamentally different kinds of on-chip memory, and every part of a C program can live in only one of them. The choice is dictated by three properties:

1. Whether the memory sits on the CPU's memory bus (so every byte or word has an address),
2. whether it can be written with an ordinary store instruction
3. whether it keeps its content at power-off.

1.1 SRAM, NOR Flash, and Block Devices

SRAM (static RAM) is **connected directly to the memory bus**:

1. every byte has an address and is read or written with a normal load or store
2. **Fast**: one access takes about one clock cycle
3. **Byte-writable** at any time,
4. **volatile**: at power-off its content is lost, and at power-on it is **undefined** (random bits, not zeros). SRAM is therefore the only place where anything that changes at run time can live: variables and the stack.

NOR flash is also on the memory bus, like a ROM:

1. Every word has an address and random-access reads are fast.
2. The CPU can therefore fetch instructions directly from it, which is called **execute-in-place (XIP)**: no copy is needed before running.
3. **Non-volatile**.
4. **Writing is not a store instruction**: a whole sector (a few KB) must first be **erased**, setting all its bits to 1, and then individual words are **programmed**, which can only turn bits from 1 to 0. Both operations take microseconds to milliseconds and go through a command sequence sent to the flash controller, so at run time NOR flash is effectively **read-only**.

NAND flash (SD cards, SSDs) and hard disks are **not** on the memory bus:

1. Accessed through a controller one block (page) at a time, typically 512 B to 4 KB, and a block has no CPU address.
2. The CPU can neither fetch instructions from it nor read a single variable: content must first be copied into RAM. This is why a desktop OS needs a **loader** that copies the executable from the SSD into RAM. A microcontroller has no loader: its program already sits in NOR flash, at the address it runs from.

Technology	On the bus?	Execute from it?	Write at run time?	Keeps data at power-off?
SRAM	yes	yes	yes, bytes	no (volatile)
NOR flash	yes	yes (XIP)	no (erase/program)	yes
NAND / disk	no (blocks)	no	through a driver	yes

1.2 Placement Rules for a C Program

These properties fix where each part of a C program goes:

Program element	Memory	Reason
Code	Flash	executed in place (XIP)
Constants (`const`, string literals)	Flash	never modified: read in place
Variables	RAM	modified at run time
Initialized variables (`int x = 5;`)	RAM at run time + Flash in the image	RAM is random at power-on: the initial value is stored in flash and copied into RAM by the startup code before `main()`

The Cortex-M3 address space, and the two memories populated on `mps2-an385` (FLASH at `0x0000_0000` and RAM at `0x2000_0000`, 4 MB each), are described in the chapter on the ARM Cortex-M3 architecture. The linker script refers only to these two memories.

2 Linker Script and Image Layout

A **linker script** is a text file, passed to the linker with `-T`, that describes the memory layout of the target chip and how the program must be placed in it.

```
MEMORY
{
    FLASH (rx)  : ORIGIN = 0x00000000, LENGTH = 4M
    RAM   (rwx) : ORIGIN = 0x20000000, LENGTH = 4M
}

ENTRY(Reset_Handler)

_estack = ORIGIN(RAM) + LENGTH(RAM);
_Min_Stack_Size = 0x1000;
_Min_Heap_Size = 0x1000;

SECTIONS
{
    .isr_vector :
    {
        . = ALIGN(4);
        KEEP(*(.isr_vector))
        . = ALIGN(4);
    } > FLASH

    .text :
    {
        . = ALIGN(4);
        *(.text*)
        *(.rodata*)
        . = ALIGN(4);
        _etext = .;
    } > FLASH

    _sidata = LOADADDR(.data);

    .data :
    {
        . = ALIGN(4);
        _sdata = .;
        *(.data*)
        . = ALIGN(4);
```

```
        _edata = .;
    } > RAM AT > FLASH

    .bss :
    {
        . = ALIGN(4);
        _sbss = .;
        *(.bss*)
        *(COMMON)
        . = ALIGN(4);
        _ebss = .;
    } > RAM

    .heap :
    {
        . = ALIGN(8);
        PROVIDE( end = . );
        PROVIDE( _end = . );
        _heap_bottom = .;
        . = . + _Min_Heap_Size;
        _heap_top = .;
    } > RAM

    __StackLimit = _estack - _Min_Stack_Size;
    ASSERT(__StackLimit >= _heap_top, "region RAM overflowed: heap collides with the stack")
}
```

The linker alone only merges the sections of the object files and resolves symbols: it **does not know which memories the chip has** or where they are. The linker script supplies this information. Based on it, the linker:

- assigns a final address to every section and symbol;
- places each section in the right memory (code and constants in flash, variables in RAM);
- defines symbols that the startup code uses, such as section boundaries and the initial stack pointer;
- checks that everything fits in the available memory, failing the link otherwise.

On bare metal there is **no OS loader** to decide where the program goes. The image must already match the hardware: for example, the vector table must be at address `0x0`, and initialized data must be stored in flash and used in RAM. The linker script is what guarantees this.

Internally, a linker script is divided into four parts:

Part	Role
`MEMORY { ... }`	declares the available memory regions: name, start address (`ORIGIN`), size (`LENGTH`), attributes (`r` , `w` , `x`)

Part	Role
`SECTIONS { ... }`	builds the output sections from the input sections of the object files and assigns each one to a memory region
`ENTRY(...)`	names the symbol where execution starts; used by tools (debugger, QEMU), not by the CPU
Symbol assignments (`_estack = ...;`)	create named addresses that the code can use, such as the top of the stack or the bounds of `.data` and `.bss`

2.1 MEMORY: Regions and Size Checking

```
MEMORY
{
    FLASH (rx)  : ORIGIN = 0x00000000, LENGTH = 4M
    RAM   (rwx) : ORIGIN = 0x20000000, LENGTH = 4M
}

_estack = ORIGIN(RAM) + LENGTH(RAM);   /* = 0x20400000 */
```

Each line of `MEMORY` defines one memory region; the two regions correspond to the two populated memories of the Cortex-M3 memory map.

Field	Meaning	Example
Name	freely chosen identifier, not a keyword	`FLASH` , `RAM`
Attributes	allowed access: `r` read, `w` write, `x` execute	`(rx)` , `(rwx)`
`ORIGIN`	start address of the region	`0x00000000` , `0x20000000`
`LENGTH`	size of the region	`4M`

The linker uses `LENGTH` to verify that the program fits:

- if the content assigned to a region does not fit, the link fails (e.g. `region 'FLASH' overflowed by 28 bytes`) instead of producing an image that cannot work;
- flash must hold `text + data` as reported by `arm-none-eabi-size` : code and constants, plus the stored initial values of `.data` ;
- `.bss` needs no flash, since it has no stored content;
- example: with `text = 96` and `data = 32` , the minimum FLASH `LENGTH` is exactly 128.

`_estack`. Defined as `ORIGIN(RAM) + LENGTH(RAM)` = `0x20400000` , one byte past the last RAM byte. The stack starts there because on Cortex-M it grows **downwards**: starting at the top of RAM gives it the most room.

2.2 SECTIONS: Output Sections Built from Input Sections

Each object file (`.o`) produced by the compiler or assembler contains its own sections, called **input sections**: `.text` (code), `.rodata` (constants), `.data` , `.bss` . The linker merges them into the sections of the final ELF

file, called **output sections**. The `SECTIONS` block contains one definition per output section, always with the same format:

```
<output_section> :
{
    <rule>            /* which input sections to take, e.g. *(.text*) */
    <rule>            /* rules are applied in order                   */
    <symbol> = .;     /* optional: give a name to the current address */
} > <REGION>          /* memory region where the section is placed    */
```

The output sections defined in this linker script are:

Output section	Content	Region
`.isr_vector`	vector table: initial SP and handler addresses	FLASH, at `0x0`
`.text`	code and read-only data (`.rodata`: constants, string literals)	FLASH
`.data`	initialized global variables	RAM (initial values stored in FLASH)
`.bss`	global variables initialized to zero or not initialized	RAM (zeroed at boot, nothing stored)
`.heap`	space reserved for dynamic allocation (`malloc`)	RAM (only reserved, empty)

The first two, both placed in FLASH, are:

```
.isr_vector :
{
    . = ALIGN(4);
    KEEP(*(.isr_vector))
} > FLASH

.text :
{
    *(.text*)            /* code from every .o          */
    *(.rodata*)          /* constants, string literals  */
    _etext = .;
} > FLASH
```

Element	Meaning
`.text :`	name of the output section created in the final ELF
`*(.text*)`	from every input file (`*`), take every section whose name starts with `.text`
`*(.rodata*)`	same, for the read-only data of every input file
`KEEP(...)`	always keep these input sections, even with garbage collection enabled

Element	Meaning
`.`	**location counter**: the address where the linker is currently placing content
`. = ALIGN(4)`	round the location counter up to a multiple of 4
`_etext = .;`	define a symbol equal to the current address (here, the end of the code)
`> FLASH`	place the output section in the FLASH region

Three consequences follow from these rules:

- **Order of rules = order in memory**: inside `.text`, all the code comes first, then all the read-only data.
- **`.rodata` has no output section of its own**: it is folded into `.text`.
- **`.isr_vector` lands at `0x0`**: it is the first output section placed in FLASH, and `.text` follows right after it.

2.2.1 Run Address (VMA) and Load Address (LMA)

```
_sidata = LOADADDR(.data);
.data :
{
    _sdata = .;       /* start of .data in RAM */
    *(.data*)
    _edata = .;       /* end of .data in RAM   */
} > RAM AT > FLASH
```

Every output section has two addresses:

Address	Meaning	In the script
VMA (virtual memory address, *run address*)	where the program uses the section at run time	`> REGION`
LMA (load memory address)	where the section's bytes are stored in the image	`AT > REGION` (if omitted, LMA = VMA)

For most sections the two coincide; `.data` is the exception:

Section	VMA	LMA	Why
`.text`	FLASH	FLASH	code runs where it is stored (XIP)
`.data`	RAM	FLASH	variables are modified in RAM, but their initial values must survive power-off in flash

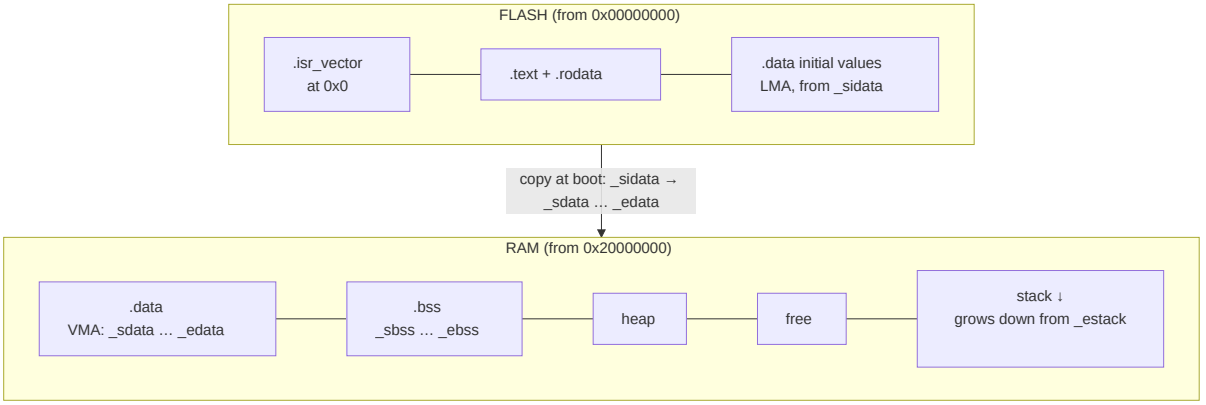
`> RAM AT > FLASH` means: VMA in RAM, LMA in FLASH. The script also records three addresses for the boot code:

Symbol	Value	Role in the copy
`_sidata`	`LOADADDR(.data)`: start of the initial values in FLASH (LMA)	source
`_sdata`	start of `.data` in RAM (VMA)	destination start
`_edata`	end of `.data` in RAM (VMA)	destination end

> **NOTHING COPIES LMA TO VMA AUTOMATICALLY**
>
> The linker only records the two addresses, and the CPU copies nothing at reset. The startup code must copy `.data` from `_sidata` to `_sdata` … `_edata` .

The resulting layout is:

Figure 3.1 — Load address (FLASH) and run address (RAM) of .data



2.2.2 .bss, Heap, and Stack Reservation

These three RAM areas occupy **no space in flash**: the image records only their size or bounds, never their bytes.

- `.bss` : storing zeros in flash would be wasteful, so only the size is recorded.
- `.heap` : it has no initial content at all; it is just space.
- **stack**: it is not even a section, only an address range below `_estack` .

```
.bss :
{
    _sbss = .;
    *(.bss*)
    *(COMMON)
    _ebss = .;
} > RAM

.heap :
{
    . = ALIGN(8);
    _heap_bottom = .;
    . = . + _Min_Heap_Size;
    _heap_top = .;
} > RAM

__StackLimit = _estack - _Min_Stack_Size;
ASSERT(__StackLimit >= _heap_top, "region RAM overflowed: heap collides with the stack")
```

Area	What it is	Bounds	Who prepares it
`.bss`	variables that start at zero	`_sbss` … `_ebss`	boot code fills it with zeros
`.heap`	space reserved for dynamic allocation (`malloc`)	`_heap_bottom` … `_heap_top` (4 KB)	nobody: it is only reserved
stack	**not a section**: the top 4 KB of RAM	`__StackLimit` … `_estack`	SP is set to `_estack` at boot

Element	Meaning
`*(COMMON)`	globals declared without a value (`int counter;`) that some compilers put in a "common" pool: they belong in `.bss` too
`. = . + _Min_Heap_Size`	advance the location counter by 4 KB, so nothing else can be placed there
`__StackLimit`	`_estack - _Min_Stack_Size` : the lowest address the stack may reach
`ASSERT(cond, msg)`	make the link fail with `msg` if `cond` is false

HEAP–STACK COLLISION CAUGHT AT LINK TIME

The `ASSERT` makes the **link fail** if the heap would run into the stack limit. A memory corruption that would appear at run time, and be very hard to debug, becomes a clear error at build time.

EXAMPLE

RAM `LENGTH = 8K` `_estack` moves to `0x20002000` and `__StackLimit` to `0x20001000` . The sections `.data` + `.bss` + `.heap` still fit inside 8 KB, so there is no region overflow. However, the 4 KB heap now crosses `__StackLimit` , and the link fails because of the `ASSERT` .

2.2.3 Linker-Defined Symbols

Symbols such as `_sdata` , `_edata` , `_sidata` , `_sbss` , `_ebss` and `_estack` have **no storage**: no memory cell holds their value. The linker only assigns each one an **address**, and the address itself is the information.

```
extern uint32_t _sdata, _edata;   /* "there is something at this address" */
uint32_t *start = &_sdata;        /* correct: the address (0x20000000)    */
uint32_t  oops  = _sdata;         /* wrong: reads RAM at that address     */
```

They are declared as `extern` objects only so that C allows taking their address with `&` . Reading `_sdata` itself would read whatever happens to be in RAM at `0x20000000` . In assembly, `ldr r0, =_sdata` means `r0 = &_sdata;` . The boot code uses these addresses as loop bounds.

2.2.4 Orphan Sections

GCC lets the programmer choose the input section of a variable or function explicitly:

```
int tagged __attribute__((section(".mysection"))) = 42;
```

If no rule in `SECTIONS` matches that section, it is an **orphan**. The linker still places it, guessing from its flags:

- writable and initialized → RAM, right after `.data`, with its own LMA in FLASH;
- read-only → FLASH.

> ⚠ **ORPHANS LINK SILENTLY BUT ESCAPE THE SCRIPT'S SYMBOLS**
>
> The link succeeds without warnings, but the orphan lies outside every range defined by the script. Here `tagged` lands exactly at `_edata`, so the copy loop over `_sdata` … `_edata` never initializes it: it reads 0 instead of 42.

2.3 Section Placement of C Declarations

Where a C declaration ends up in memory is decided in two steps:

1. the **compiler** chooses the *input section*, based on the kind of declaration;
2. the **linker script** decides which *memory region* that section goes to.

For declarations at file scope (global):

Global declaration	Section	Region
a function body	`.text`	FLASH
`const int k = 3;`	`.rodata`	FLASH
`"a string literal"`	`.rodata`	FLASH
`int x = 5;`	`.data`	RAM, initial value in FLASH
`int y;` or `int z = 0;`	`.bss`	RAM, zeroed at boot

2.3.1 Special Cases

Case	Where it goes	Why
`int z = 0;`	`.bss`	"starts at zero" is exactly what `.bss` guarantees: no reason to store the zero in flash
`const char *p = "hi";`	`"hi"` → `.rodata` (FLASH), `p` → `.data` (RAM)	two distinct objects: the characters are constant, the pointer is an initialized writable variable
local variable (`int local = 7;` inside a function)	**no section**: the stack	it exists only while the function runs and has no fixed address
`static` local (`static int s = 3;` inside a function)	`.data` (or `.bss`)	it keeps one fixed address for the whole run, like a global; only its name is private

> ⚠ **`const` POINTER VS POINTER TO `const`**
>
> In `const char *greeting = "hi";` the `const` applies to the **characters**, not to the pointer. The pointer can still be changed (`greeting = "other";`), so it is an initialized writable variable and goes to `.data` (`D`), while `"hi"` goes to `.rodata` . Only `const char * const greeting = "hi";` makes the pointer itself constant, placing it in `.rodata` (`R`) as well. Reading rule: start from the name and read leftwards: "greeting is a pointer to constant chars".

2.4 Inspecting the Linked Image

Three tools show what the linker actually produced: the map file, `nm` and `objdump` .

2.4.1 Map File

The **map file** (generated with the `-Map=` linker option) lists the *Memory Configuration* (the `MEMORY` regions) and the *Linker script and memory map*: every output section, every input section inside it with its source `.o` , every symbol's address, and the `load address` of `.data` . It also lists *Discarded input sections*.

2.4.2 nm: Listing Symbols

`arm-none-eabi-nm` is the GNU binutils tool that lists the **symbols** of an object file (`.o`) or of the final ELF image (`.axf`). A symbol is a name with an address: functions, global variables, linker-defined symbols such as `_sdata` .

For each symbol it prints:

- the **address**;
- a **letter** giving the kind of section the symbol belongs to;
- the **name**.

```
$ arm-none-eabi-nm -n build/scratch-os.axf
00000044 T limit
20000020 D counter
20000024 D greeting
20000028 B total
```

Letter	Meaning
`T` / `t`	code (`.text`)
`R`	read-only data (`.rodata`)
`D` / `d`	initialized data (`.data`)
`B`	zero-initialized data (`.bss`)
`W`	weak symbol
`A`	absolute symbol, belonging to no section

A lowercase letter means the symbol is local to its file: a `static` local `s` appears as `d s.0` , where the `.N`

`.` suffix distinguishes static locals with the same name in different functions. The `-n` option sorts the symbols by address.

2.4.3 objdump: Section Headers and Raw Bytes

`arm-none-eabi-objdump` shows the content of an ELF file. Two options are used:

Option	Output
`-h`	one line per output section with size, VMA and LMA
`-s -j <section>`	the raw bytes of one section

For an image whose startup file contains only a two-word vector table, `objdump -h` shows `.isr_vector` at `0x0` (8 bytes), `.text` from `0x8`, no `.rodata` line (it is inside `.text`), and `.data` with VMA `0x20000000` and an LMA right after the code in flash, equal to `_sidata`.

Each line of an `-s` dump contains:

- the **address** of its first byte;
- **16 bytes**, in four groups of 4, in memory order;
- the same bytes shown as **text** on the right (`.` for non-printable bytes).

2.5 Worked Example

```
const int limit = 100;
int counter = 5;
int total;
int zero = 0;
const char *greeting = "hi";
char buffer[64];
```

Object	Section	`nm` in `main.o`	`nm` in final image
`limit`	`.rodata`	`R`	`T`
`counter`	`.data`	`D`	`D`
`total`	`.bss`	`B`	`B`
`zero`	`.bss`	`B`	`B`
`greeting`	`.data`	`D`	`D`
`buffer`	`.bss`	`B`	`B`
`"hi"`	`.rodata`	not listed (no name)	not listed

WHY `LIMIT` CHANGES FROM `R` TO `T`

`nm` classifies a symbol by the output section it ends up in. The linker script merges every `.rodata` into the `.text` output section, so in the final image `limit` is reported as `T`. The bytes are the same, in the same flash; only the name of the containing section changed.

The bytes of the image confirm the layout:

```
$ arm-none-eabi-objdump -s -j .text build/scratch-os.axf
 0038 00bffde7 4c000000 00000020 64000000  ....L...... d...
 0048 68690000 6d61696e 3a206865 6c6c6f20  hi..main: hello

$ arm-none-eabi-objdump -s -j .data build/scratch-os.axf
 20000020 05000000 48000000                    ....H...
```

Address	Bytes	Meaning
`0x44` (FLASH)	`64 00 00 00`	`limit` = 100 (`0x64`)
`0x48` (FLASH)	`68 69 00`	`"hi"` : `'h'` , `'i'` , terminating `'\0'`
`0x20000020` (RAM)	`05 00 00 00`	`counter` = 5
`0x20000024` (RAM)	`48 00 00 00`	`greeting` = `0x00000048`

LITTLE-ENDIAN

The Cortex-M3 stores the **lowest byte first**. The bytes `05 00 00 00` are therefore the number 5, and `48 00 00 00` the number `0x00000048` .

The last row is the key point: `greeting` holds `0x48` , which is exactly the flash address where `"hi"` starts. **A pointer is simply a variable whose value is an address.**

Variables in `.data` appear in definition order. In this example the first 32 bytes of `.data` (`0x20000000` – `0x2000001F`) hold a string defined earlier in the file, so `counter` and `greeting` follow at `0x20000020` and `0x20000024` .

3 Vector Table Placement and Section Garbage Collection

The vector table, described in the chapter on the ARM Cortex-M3 architecture, is the first data the CPU reads after reset: word 0 becomes the initial main stack pointer and word 1 the address of `Reset_Handler`. Because `VTOR` resets to `0x0000_0000`, the table must sit at the very start of FLASH when the CPU leaves reset. The startup code therefore puts the table in its own input section, `.isr_vector`, and the linker script places that section first in FLASH, before `.text`. Each handler address is stored with bit 0 set (the Thumb bit), so with a 16-word table the first code starts at `0x40` and word 1 reads `0x41`.

> ⚠ **THE VECTOR TABLE IS IN FLASH, NOT RAM**
>
> At reset the table sits at address `0x0`, the start of the Code/FLASH region. RAM starts at `0x20000000` and holds only `.data`, `.bss`, heap, and stack. The table can be relocated later through `VTOR` (for example into RAM), but this is a deliberate software choice.

3.1 KEEP and Section Garbage Collection

With the option `-Wl,--gc-sections`, the linker performs **garbage collection of sections**:

1. it starts from the `ENTRY` symbol (`Reset_Handler`);
2. it follows every reference from one section to another (calls, pointers, addresses);
3. it **drops every input section that nothing references**.

This is useful to trim unused code, but it is dangerous for data that **only the hardware reads**. No code references the vector table: the CPU reads it by itself at reset. For the linker it is therefore unused, and it would be discarded.

`KEEP(*(.isr_vector))` marks those input sections as **always kept**, whatever the garbage collector decides.

`--gc-sections`	`KEEP`	Result
off	present or absent	nothing is collected: `KEEP` changes nothing, it only acts as insurance
on	present	`.isr_vector` is kept at `0x0`: the image works
on	absent	`.isr_vector` is discarded: the image does not boot

> ⚠ **WHAT HAPPENS WITHOUT `KEEP`**
>
> 1. `.isr_vector` shrinks to size 0; the map file lists it under *Discarded input sections*.
> 2. `.text` becomes the first section in FLASH, so `Reset_Handler` lands at `0x0`.
> 3. At reset the CPU reads the first two words at `0x0`, which are now **instructions**, and loads them as SP and PC.
> 4. With a meaningless SP and PC, execution faults immediately and the CPU ends in **lockup**.

4 The Startup Code: `boot/startup.s`

The **startup code** (`boot/startup.s`) is the first code the CPU executes after reset, before `main()`. It contains two parts:

- the **vector table**, from which the hardware loads the initial SP and PC;
- `Reset_Handler`, the function that prepares the machine to run C code.

```
// THE COMPLETE STARTUP CODE

/* Assembler settings */
    .syntax unified             /* modern ARM syntax */
    .cpu cortex-m3              /* only M3 instructions */
    .thumb                      /* Thumb code only */

/* 1. Vector table */
    .section .isr_vector,"a",%progbits
    .global isr_vector
    .type isr_vector, %object
isr_vector:
    .word _estack               /* 0: initial SP */
    .word Reset_Handler         /* 1: reset */
    .word NMI_Handler           /* 2: NMI */
    .word HardFault_Handler     /* 3: HardFault */
    .word MemManage_Handler     /* 4: MemManage */
    .word BusFault_Handler      /* 5: BusFault */
    .word UsageFault_Handler    /* 6: UsageFault */
    .word 0                     /* 7: reserved */
    .word 0                     /* 8: reserved */
    .word 0                     /* 9: reserved */
    .word 0                     /* 10: reserved */
    .word SVC_Handler           /* 11: SVCall */
    .word DebugMon_Handler      /* 12: debug monitor */
    .word 0                     /* 13: reserved */
    .word PendSV_Handler        /* 14: PendSV */
    .word SysTick_Handler       /* 15: SysTick */
    .size isr_vector, . - isr_vector

/* Default handlers: weak aliases of Default_Handler */
    .weak      NMI_Handler
    .thumb_set NMI_Handler, Default_Handler
    .weak      HardFault_Handler
    .thumb_set HardFault_Handler, Default_Handler
    .weak      MemManage_Handler
```

```
    .thumb_set MemManage_Handler, Default_Handler
    .weak      BusFault_Handler
    .thumb_set BusFault_Handler, Default_Handler
    .weak      UsageFault_Handler
    .thumb_set UsageFault_Handler, Default_Handler
    .weak      SVC_Handler
    .thumb_set SVC_Handler, Default_Handler
    .weak      DebugMon_Handler
    .thumb_set DebugMon_Handler, Default_Handler
    .weak      PendSV_Handler
    .thumb_set PendSV_Handler, Default_Handler
    .weak      SysTick_Handler
    .thumb_set SysTick_Handler, Default_Handler

/* 2. Reset_Handler */
    .section .text,"ax",%progbits
    .global Reset_Handler
    .type Reset_Handler, %function
    .thumb_func
Reset_Handler:

    /* Step 1: mask interrupts */
    cpsid i                     /* PRIMASK = 1 */

    /* Step 2: set SP */
    ldr r0, =_estack
    mov sp, r0

    /* Step 3: copy .data FLASH -> RAM */
    ldr r0, =_sidata            /* src */
    ldr r1, =_sdata             /* dst */
    ldr r2, =_edata             /* end */
copy_data:
    cmp r1, r2                  /* while (dst < end) */
    bhs copy_data_done
    ldr r3, [r0], #4            /* r3 = *src++ */
    str r3, [r1], #4            /* *dst++ = r3 */
    b copy_data
copy_data_done:

    /* Step 4: zero .bss */
    ldr r1, =_sbss              /* dst */
    ldr r2, =_ebss              /* end */
```

```
    movs r3, #0
zero_bss:
    cmp r1, r2                  /* while (dst < end) */
    bhs zero_bss_done
    str r3, [r1], #4            /* *dst++ = 0 */
    b zero_bss
zero_bss_done:

    /* Step 5: VTOR = &isr_vector */
    ldr r0, =0xE000ED08
    ldr r1, =isr_vector
    str r1, [r0]

    /* Step 6: SHCSR |= bits 16-18 */
    ldr r0, =0xE000ED24
    ldr r1, [r0]
    orr r1, r1, #0x00070000
    str r1, [r0]

    /* Step 7: CCR |= DIV_0_TRP */
    ldr r0, =0xE000ED14
    ldr r1, [r0]
    orr r1, r1, #(1 << 4)
    str r1, [r0]

    /* Step 8: priorities (SHPR1-3) */
    ldr r0, =0xE000ED18
    movs r1, #0x00
    strb r1, [r0, #0]           /* MemManage */
    strb r1, [r0, #1]           /* BusFault */
    strb r1, [r0, #2]           /* UsageFault */
    movs r1, #0x80
    strb r1, [r0, #7]           /* SVCall */
    movs r1, #0xE0
    strb r1, [r0, #10]          /* PendSV */
    strb r1, [r0, #11]          /* SysTick */

    /* Step 9: unmask interrupts */
    cpsie i                     /* PRIMASK = 0 */

    /* Step 10: call main, then hang */
    bl main
hang:
```

```
    b hang

    .ltorg                      /* literal pool */
    .size Reset_Handler, . - Reset_Handler

/* 3. Default_Handler */
    .global Default_Handler
    .type Default_Handler, %function
    .thumb_func
Default_Handler:
    b Default_Handler           /* for (;;) {} */
    .size Default_Handler, . - Default_Handler
```

The order of the steps is dictated by dependencies: nothing may interrupt a half-built system, C needs a stack, globals must hold their values before any C code reads them, and the configuration must be complete before interrupts are accepted.

Step	Action	Reason
1	mask interrupts (`cpsid i`)	nothing may interrupt a half-built system
2	set SP	C functions need a stack
3	copy `.data` FLASH → RAM	initialized globals get their values
4	zero `.bss`	C guarantees uninitialized globals start at 0
5–8	configure the CPU	vector table address, fault handlers, divide-by-zero trap, priorities
9	unmask interrupts (`cpsie i`)	setup is complete
10	`bl main` , then loop forever	hand over to C; on bare metal there is nothing to return to

It works in sequence:

1. **Hardware**: at reset the CPU loads SP from word 0 and PC from word 1 of the vector table, so execution starts at `Reset_Handler` .
2. **Stack**: `Reset_Handler` sets SP to `_estack` , the top of RAM.
3. **`.data`** : it copies the initial values of the initialized variables from FLASH (`_sidata`) to RAM (`_sdata` … `_edata`).
4. **`.bss`** : it fills `_sbss` … `_ebss` with zeros.
5. **CPU configuration**: it sets up the vector table address, fault handlers and priorities.
6. **`main()`** : it calls `main` and, if `main` ever returns, loops forever.

All the addresses used in steps 2–4 are symbols defined by the linker script (see the linker script section above). The two work at different times: the linker script is used only at **build time** to place sections and define those symbols, and it is never executed; the startup code runs on the CPU at **run time** and uses them as loop bounds. Each step is explained in the reset handler section below.

WHY ASSEMBLY

When the startup code begins, the stack has not been set up yet and `.data` and `.bss` are not initialized. C code takes all of these for granted, so it cannot be trusted until the startup code has finished. On a desktop this job is done by **crt0**, the C library's startup code; on bare metal it is excluded (`-nostartfiles`) and written by hand.

Writing the startup code needs only a small subset of Thumb instructions: loads and stores, constants and literal pools, labels, compares, and branches. They are summarised in the instruction table of the chapter on the ARM Cortex-M3 architecture. The assembler directives, which steer the assembler rather than the CPU, are described below.

4.1 Assembler Directives

Lines starting with a dot produce no instructions; they steer the assembler.

```
    .section .isr_vector,"a",%progbits   @ following content goes into .isr_vector
    .global isr_vector                   @ name visible to the linker
isr_vector:
    .word _estack                        @ one 32-bit value
    .word Reset_Handler

    .section .text,"ax",%progbits
    .global Reset_Handler
    .thumb_func                          @ next label is Thumb code: bit 0 = 1
Reset_Handler:
```

The equivalent vector table in C is:

```
__attribute__((section(".isr_vector")))
const uint32_t isr_vector[] = { (uint32_t)&_estack, (uint32_t)Reset_Handler };
```

Directive	Effect
`.section name,"flags"`	selects the section; `a` = occupies space in the image, `x` = executable
`.global name`	exports the name to other files and the linker (otherwise it behaves like a `static` C name)
`.thumb_func`	marks the next label as Thumb code, so its address is stored with bit 0 set
`.word X`	stores the 32-bit value X
`.type` , `.size`	tell `nm` and gdb whether a name is code or data, and its size
`.weak name`	declares a weak symbol, overridable by a normal definition
`.thumb_set a, b`	makes `a` an alias of `b` , marked as Thumb code

Directive	Effect
`.ltorg`	emits the literal pool here

5 Reset Handler: From Reset to main()

`Reset_Handler` is the function the CPU executes **first** after every reset. Its address is **stored in slot 1 of the vector table**: at reset the hardware loads that word into PC, so execution starts here, before any C code.

On bare metal there is no operating system and no C library to prepare the machine. `Reset_Handler` takes their place: it brings the CPU and the memory into the state that C code assumes, configures how the CPU reacts to errors, and only then calls `main()`. Its work is organized in two jobs, carried out in order:

Job	Steps	Without it
Make C code safe to run	set the stack, copy `.data`, zero `.bss`	globals hold wrong values, function calls have no valid stack
Configure the CPU	vector table address, separate fault handlers, divide-by-zero trap, priorities	errors pass silently or all end up in the same HardFault

A STARTUP THAT ONLY CALLS `MAIN`

Consider a minimal `Reset_Handler` that executes only `bl main`, and a global `char data_message[] = "hello";`:

- the linker places the bytes `"hello"` in **FLASH** (LMA) and reserves space for `data_message` in **RAM** (VMA);
- nobody copies the bytes from FLASH to RAM;
- `main` reads `data_message` from **RAM**, where the copy was never written.

The result depends on what RAM contains at power-on. QEMU fills RAM with zeros, so the first byte is `'\0'` and the string reads as **empty**. Real hardware leaves random content, so the string reads as **garbage**. The program compiles and runs, but the data is wrong: this is the kind of silent error the copy loop prevents.

5.1 Weak Default Handlers

The vector table has 16 slots, and the CPU jumps to whatever address slot N contains when exception N occurs. Every slot must therefore point to valid code, even for exceptions the program does not handle yet; reserved slots simply hold `0`. Instead of writing nine real handlers, the startup code uses two pieces:

- **`Default_Handler`**: a single catch-all function, an infinite loop (`for (;;) {}`);
- **weak names**: every handler name in the table is declared `.weak` and, by default, is an alias of `Default_Handler` (same address).

A **weak** symbol is a default that gives way: if another file defines a normal (strong) function with the same name, the linker uses that one and drops the weak alias. A handler is installed simply by writing a C function with the right name, without touching the assembly. The C equivalent of each weak name is:

```
void HardFault_Handler(void) __attribute__((weak, alias("Default_Handler")));
```

With only `UsageFault_Handler` defined in `main.c`:

Slot	Name	Defined in C?	CPU jumps to	`nm`
3	`HardFault_Handler`	no	`Default_Handler`	`W`, same address as `Default_Handler`
6	`UsageFault_Handler`	yes	the C function	`T`, its own address
15	`SysTick_Handler`	no	`Default_Handler`	`W`, same address as `Default_Handler`

> **WHY AN INFINITE LOOP**
>
> An unexpected exception is a bug. Freezing at a known place lets a debugger show immediately that PC is in `Default_Handler`, instead of letting the CPU run off into random memory.

5.2 Interrupt Masking and Stack Setup

`cpsid i` sets **PRIMASK**, a 1-bit core register (not memory-mapped): while it is 1, every exception with configurable priority is ignored; only NMI and HardFault get through. Interrupts arriving while masked are not lost: they remain **pending** and run as soon as `cpsie i` clears PRIMASK. PRIMASK is 0 at reset; the boot code sets it first and clears it only after the vector table, handlers and priorities are in place.

Instruction	PRIMASK	C (vendor headers)
`cpsid i`	1: masked	`__disable_irq()`
`cpsie i`	0: accepted	`__enable_irq()`

SP is set explicitly even though the hardware already loaded it from vector word 0, because `Reset_Handler` is not always reached through a real reset: a bootloader or debugger may jump to it with SP holding any value. SP is a special register, so the address is first loaded into `r0` with `ldr` and then moved with `mov sp, r0`.

> **FAILURE MODES OF A WRONG SP**
>
> With SP = `0x30000000` (outside RAM), the first push in `main` writes to a non-existent address and faults; reporting the fault requires stacking registers, which faults again, and the CPU enters lockup. With SP = `0x20000001`, the CPU silently clears the two low bits (SP is always word-aligned), so the stack starts at the bottom of RAM and grows *below* it, into an unmapped range where QEMU ignores writes: every call fails silently and nothing is printed.

5.3 Initializing .data and .bss

The `.data` copy translates `while (dst < &_edata) *dst++ = *src++;` with `r0` = `src` (`_sidata`), `r1` = `dst` (`_sdata`) and `r2` = end (`_edata`). It copies whole words, which is safe because the linker script aligns the start and end of `.data` to 4 bytes. Stepping through the loop in a debugger shows `r1` climbing `0x20000000`, `0x20000004`, … until it equals `&_edata`; only then does the string appear in RAM.

The `.bss` loop has the same shape without a source pointer: `while (dst < &_ebss) *dst++ = 0;`. When `.bss` is empty, `_sbss` equals `_ebss` and the loop exits immediately. Relying on the emulator zeroing RAM is incorrect: real SRAM is random at power-on. After these two loops, `Reset_Handler` provides exactly what a C runtime startup (crt0) provides.

5.4 Configuring the System Control Block

Steps 5–8 of `Reset_Handler` configure the System Control Block. The meaning of each register and field is described in the chapter on the ARM Cortex-M3 architecture; this section shows only what the boot code writes and why. All four registers are memory-mapped, so the startup code uses ordinary loads and stores: a plain store when the whole register is written, read-modify-write when other bits must keep their value, and byte stores for the priority bytes.

Step	Register	Operation	Effect
5	`VTOR` (`0xE000ED08`)	`= isr_vector`	exceptions use this table, wherever the image is placed
6	`SHCSR` (`0xE000ED24`)	`|= 0x00070000`	MemManage, BusFault, and UsageFault get their own handlers instead of escalating to HardFault
7	`CCR` (`0xE000ED14`)	`|= 1 << 4`	integer division by zero raises a UsageFault; `STKALIGN` stays 1, so `CCR` becomes `0x210`
8	`SHPR1` – `SHPR3` (`0xE000ED18` …)	byte stores	faults `0x00` , SVCall `0x80` , PendSV and SysTick `0xE0`

`VTOR` is written as a whole word, because all its bits are the table address. `SHCSR` and `CCR` contain status bits or bits that are already set (`STKALIGN`), so they are updated with read-modify-write and never overwritten. Each priority is a separate byte: viewing `SHPR1` – `SHPR3` as a 12-byte array at `0xE000ED18` , the boot code writes indices 0–2 (faults), 7 (SVCall), and 10–11 (PendSV, SysTick).

The effect of steps 6 and 7 is easy to observe with a division by a `volatile` zero. With both settings in place, a C function named `UsageFault_Handler` (which replaces the weak alias) runs and can report `CFSR = 0x2000000` , the `DIVBYZERO` bit. Without the `SHCSR` bits the fault escalates to HardFault and its kind is lost; without `DIV_0_TRP` the division silently returns 0 and `main` continues. The worked example and the fault status bits are in the fault status section of the Cortex-M3 chapter.

5.5 Additional Startup Work on Real Chips

QEMU's CPU runs at full speed out of reset. On a real microcontroller the startup code usually does more, often in a vendor function `SystemInit()` called from `Reset_Handler` :

- **Clock and PLL**: the chip starts on a slow internal oscillator, and a PLL multiplies the frequency up to full speed.
- **Flash wait states**: flash is slower than a fast CPU, so the flash controller must be told to insert wait cycles *before* the clock is raised, or the CPU reads garbage.
- **Watchdog**: a timer that resets the chip unless software periodically feeds it; on some chips it runs from reset, so boot code must feed or disable it.
- **FPU**: on a Cortex-M4F the floating-point unit is off at reset and must be enabled in **CPACR** (`0xE000ED88`), otherwise the first float instruction raises a UsageFault.
- **C++**: static constructors listed in `.init_array` must be called before `main` .

5.6 Verifying Boot State with gdb

A **debugger** controls a running program: it stops it at a breakpoint or before the first instruction, steps it one machine instruction or one C line at a time, inspects and modifies registers and memory, and resumes it. On a microcontroller, where a crash often produces no message at all, it is frequently the only way to see what the CPU does. The ARM build of gdb is `arm-none-eabi-gdb` (`gdb-multiarch` on Linux).

Debugging is **remote**: the program runs inside QEMU, and gdb connects over TCP. QEMU is started with the normal run command plus `-S` (freeze the CPU before its first instruction) and `-gdb tcp::1234` (start a gdb server on port 1234). gdb reads the ELF only for symbols and debug information; QEMU already holds the code.

```
qemu-system-arm -machine mps2-an385 -monitor null -semihosting \
    --semihosting-config enable=on,target=native \
    -kernel build/scratch-os.axf -serial stdio -nographic \
    -S -gdb tcp::1234
```

Command	Effect
`target remote :1234`	connect to the gdb server
`info registers sp pc`	show registers (`info registers` shows all)
`x/2wx 0`	examine 2 words in hex at address 0
`x/s &data_message`	examine memory as a C string
`p/x $r1`	print a register or C expression in hex
`display/i $pc`	show the next instruction after every step
`stepi` (`si`)	execute one machine instruction
`break main` (`b`)	stop when execution reaches a symbol or label
`continue` (`c`)	run to the next breakpoint

Attached before the first instruction, gdb already shows SP = `0x20400000` and PC = `Reset_Handler`, while `x/2wx 0` shows `0x20400000 0x00000041` (or `0x9` with a two-word table): no instruction has executed, so the hardware itself loaded both registers from the vector table, clearing the Thumb bit for PC. At `break main`, the SCB registers hold the values written in steps 5–8 (`VTOR` = `0x00000000`, `CCR` = `0x00000210`, `SHCSR` = `0x00070000`, `SHPR2` = `0x80000000`, `SHPR3` = `0xE0E00000`) and `info registers primask` reads 0 (it reads 0 at reset and 1 after `cpsid i`).

6 Freestanding C and Semihosting

6.1 Hosted and Freestanding Environments

The C standard defines two environments:

Aspect	Hosted	Freestanding
Example	desktop program	bare-metal Cortex-M3 image
Below the program	a C library (libc) and an OS	nothing
`printf`, `malloc`, `fopen`, `exit`	available	not available
Who starts `main()`	libc startup code, invoked by the OS	the application's own startup code

A freestanding environment still provides the headers that need **no run-time code**, only types, constants and macros supplied by the compiler:

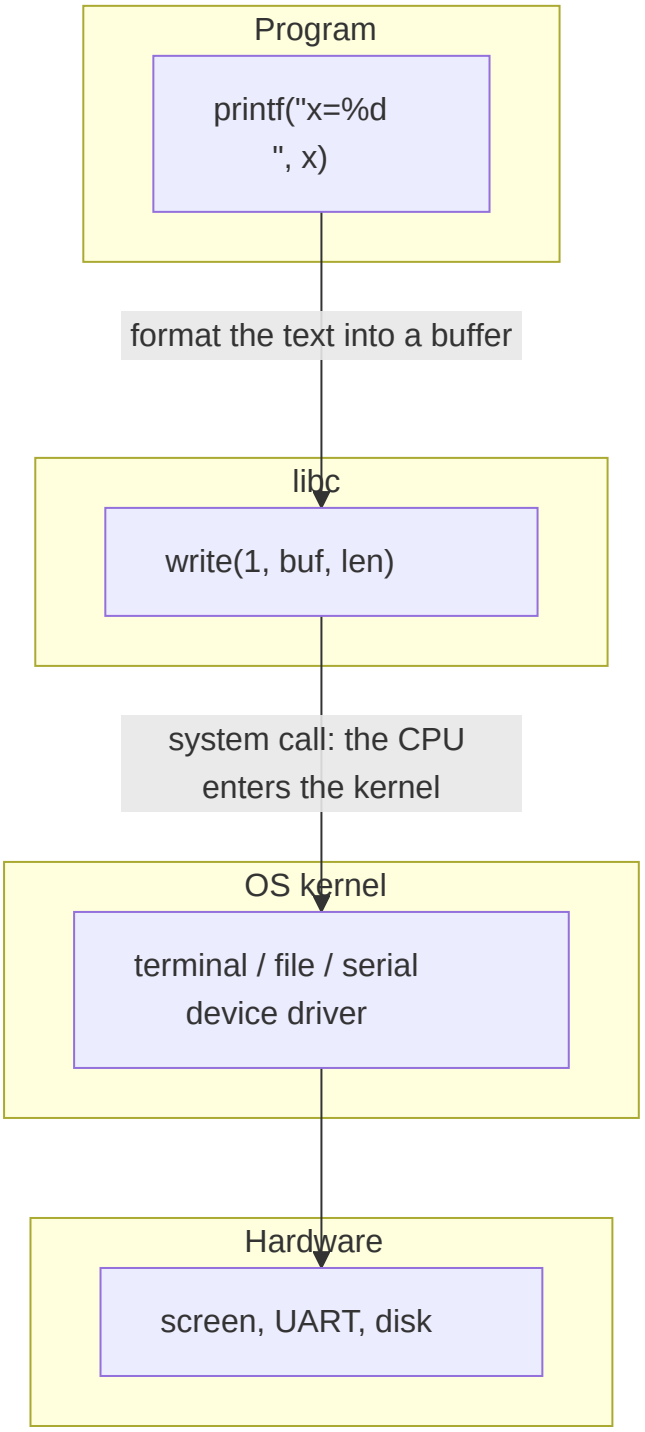
Header	Provides
`stdint.h`	`uint32_t`, `int8_t`, …
`stddef.h`	`size_t`, `NULL`, `offsetof`
`stdbool.h`	`bool`, `true`, `false`
`stdarg.h`	`va_list` for variadic functions
`limits.h`, `float.h`	`INT_MAX`, `FLT_EPSILON`, …

There is no `stdio.h`, `stdlib.h` or `string.h`: no printing, no `malloc`, no `exit`, not even `memcpy`. This is why the boot code copies `.data` with its own loop.

6.2 The Layers Under printf

On a desktop, `printf` looks like a **single function** that writes to the screen. In reality it is the top of a stack of layers, and **most of the work happens in layers that a bare-metal system does not have**:

Figure 3.2 — The layers under printf on a hosted system



`printf` itself only **formats**: it turns `"x=%d"` and `42` into the characters `x=42` in a buffer. **Getting those characters out of the machine** is the **OS's** job, reached through the `write()` system call. Many other libc functions have the same structure: a portable part on top, and a dependency on something underneath.

libc feature	Requires underneath
`printf`, `puts`	`write()`: a way to send bytes to a device

libc feature	Requires underneath
`malloc`, `free`	a heap region, grown with `sbrk()`
`exit`	something to return to
`main()` being called	crt0: sets up stack, `.data`, `.bss`, then calls `main`

6.2.1 libc on Bare Metal

Embedded C libraries such as **newlib** keep the portable part (formatting, string handling, data structures) and leave the bottom functions (`write`, `sbrk`, `exit`, …) as **hooks**: empty stubs that must be implemented for each board.

The firmware described in these notes links **no libc at all**, for three reasons:

Reason	Explanation
Nothing to put under the hooks	there is no kernel, no `write()`, no heap manager yet
crt0 is not needed	`Reset_Handler` already does its work
No hidden code	the image contains only the startup file, the application and a few compiler helpers

> **WHAT REPLACES `PRINTF`**
>
> Without libc, output is produced by the program itself: in this chapter through **semihosting**, and later through a UART driver and the kernel's own `kprintf` / `printf` (see the chapter on devices, interrupts, and system calls).

6.3 Build Flags for a Freestanding Image

```
CFLAGS := -mthumb -mcpu=cortex-m3 -nostartfiles -ffreestanding -std=gnu17
LDFLAGS += -nostdlib -lgcc
```

Flag	Meaning
`-ffreestanding`	GCC must not assume a libc or OS exists (e.g. that a function named `printf` behaves like the standard one)
`-nostartfiles`	do not link the toolchain's startup code (crt0)
`-nostdlib`	do not link any standard library or startup file (no `-lc`)
`-lgcc`	add back libgcc, the compiler's own helper routines

`libgcc` is kept because the compiler sometimes turns a plain C operator into a **call** to a helper when the CPU has no single instruction for it. These helpers need neither OS nor libc, and dropping them would make harmless code fail to link.

C code	CPU	GCC emits
`a / b` (32-bit)	Cortex-M0 (no divide instruction)	`bl __aeabi_idiv`
`a / b` (32-bit)	Cortex-M3	`sdiv` (hardware)
`x / y` (64-bit)	Cortex-M3	`bl __aeabi_uldivmod`

Calling `printf` in such a build always fails: with a toolchain that ships no C library, compilation stops with `stdio.h: No such file or directory`; with a toolchain that ships newlib, the header is found but the link fails with `undefined reference to 'printf'` because of `-nostdlib`.

6.4 Semihosting Output via bkpt 0xab

Without libc and without a UART driver, the program has no way of its own to print anything. All the output of the boot code is produced with **semihosting**: the program places `0x04` (`SYS_WRITE0`) in `r0` and the address of a NUL-terminated string in `r1`, then executes `bkpt 0xab`, and the host (QEMU or a debugger) prints the string on its terminal. The convention, the C wrapper `semihost_write0`, and its limits are described in the toolchain chapter.

> **MULTIPLE INSTRUCTIONS IN ONE `__ASM__`**
>
> C concatenates adjacent string literals, so `"ldr r2, [r0]" "ldr r3, [r1]"` reaches the assembler as the single line `ldr r2, [r0]ldr r3, [r1]` and fails with `garbage following instruction`. Each instruction must end with `\n` (commonly `\n\t`) inside the string.

> **SEMIHOSTING IS A TRAP**
>
> The program stops its own work, control passes to a more powerful entity outside the CPU, which performs the job and then returns control. This is exactly the shape of a **system call**, with the host playing the role of the kernel (see the system calls in the chapter on devices, interrupts, and system calls).

1 Peripherals and Buses of the MPS2-AN385 Platform

Before writing a driver, it is necessary to know the hardware it talks to: which board is emulated, which peripherals it contains, where they sit in the address space, and how the CPU reaches them.

1.1 CMSDK Hardware and CMSIS Software Conventions

Two Arm standards cover the two sides of a peripheral:

- **CMSDK** defines the hardware blocks,
- **CMSIS** defines how software names and accesses them.

Aspect	CMSDK	CMSIS
Full name	Cortex-M System Design Kit	Cortex Microcontroller Software Interface Standard
Nature	**hardware**: ready-made peripheral designs placed next to a Cortex-M core	**software**: a standard for the C headers and helper functions that describe a chip
Examples	APB UART, APB timer and dual timer, watchdog, AHB GPIO	`core_cm3.h`, `NVIC_EnableIRQ()`, `UART0->DATA`, `UART0TX_IRQn`
Key property	registers documented once by Arm, identical on every chip that integrates the block	shipped by chip vendors with their parts
In this context	the peripherals of the MPS2-AN385 board	a register header written by hand **in CMSIS style**, without vendor libraries, so names match real vendor code

1.2 Board, Clock, and Peripheral Address Map

The code runs on an emulated Arm development board. This section identifies the board, the single clock that times everything, and the addresses where its peripherals are located.

Element	Description
MPS2	Arm development board whose main chip is an **FPGA**: a reprogrammable chip whose circuit is loaded at power-on, so the same board can imitate different microcontrollers
AN385	the circuit (FPGA image, described in Arm Application Note 385) used here: a **Cortex-M3** CPU plus CMSDK peripherals
QEMU `mps2-an385`	emulator of exactly this system: the code runs on the PC without the physical board
Clock	one **25 MHz** clock shared by CPU and peripherals; every timing value (UART speed, timer period) is computed from it
Peripheral region	addresses `0x40000000` – `0x5FFFFFFF`, reserved by the Cortex-M memory map for devices; each device occupies a 4 KiB window

Figure 4.1 — MPS2-AN385 peripheral region (0x4000_0000…)

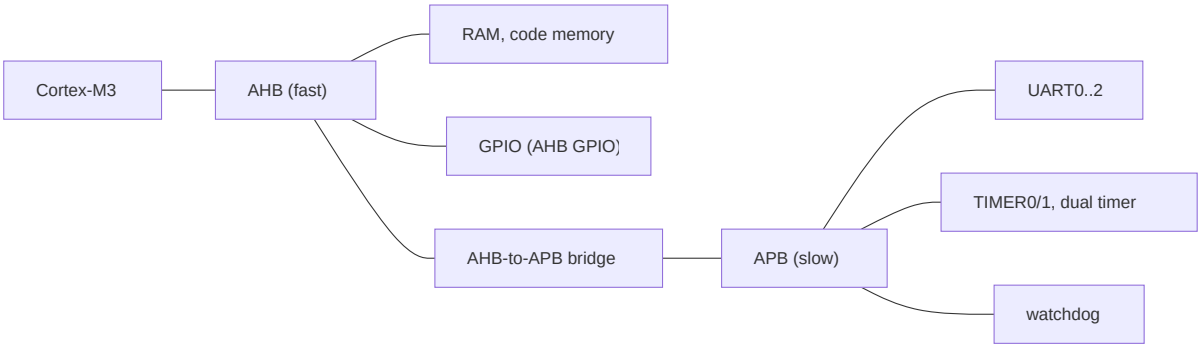


1.3 AHB and APB Buses

The CPU does not talk to every device in the same way: fast and slow devices sit on two different buses, connected by a bridge.

A **bus** carries every load and store from the CPU to a memory or a device.

Figure 4.2 — AHB and APB buses of the MPS2-AN385



Bus	Characteristics
AHB (Advanced High-performance Bus)	pipelined, one transfer per cycle: memories, GPIO
APB (Advanced Peripheral Bus)	simple, slow, low-power: rarely accessed registers (UART, timers, watchdog)
AHB-to-APB bridge	translates each access: a few extra cycles per APB register

For software **the bus is transparent**: only the timing differs. Software does not need to know which bus a device is on: every register access is the same load or store instruction, and the bridge routes it automatically. The only difference is speed: an APB access takes a few extra clock cycles.

1.4 Standard I/O Interfaces and DMA

Microcontrollers exchange data with the outside world through a small set of standard **interfaces**; a DMA controller can additionally move data without using the CPU.

Interface	Wires	Operating principle	Typical use
GPIO	1 per pin	each pin is a digital input (level read) or output (driven to 0 or 1)	buttons, LEDs, chip-selects
UART	2 (TX, RX)	asynchronous: no clock wire, both sides agree on a **baud rate**	debug console, PC link
SPI	clock, data out, data in, 1 select per device	synchronous; the controller drives the clock, one bit out and one in per tick; **chip-select** picks the device	flash, displays (MHz)
I2C	2 (clock, data)	synchronous multi-drop; the controller first sends the 7-bit device **address**	sensors (100–400 kHz)
ADC / DAC	1 per channel	analog voltage to number (ADC) or number to voltage (DAC)	temperature, audio

1.4.1 GPIO

A **GPIO** (General-Purpose Input/Output) pin is the simplest interface: a single wire whose level the software can read (input) or set to 0 or 1 (output). When a pin is used as an output, the electrical circuit that drives it determines

whether the pin can safely share its wire with other devices.

Output type	Circuit	Level 1	Level 0	Shared wire
Push-pull	two transistors: one to the supply, one to ground	driven actively (connected to the supply)	driven actively (connected to ground)	**not allowed**: one device driving 1 and another driving 0 short-circuit supply and ground
Open-drain	one transistor to ground only	not driven: an external **pull-up resistor** brings the line high when nobody pulls it down	driven actively (connected to ground)	**allowed**: nobody ever drives 1, so there is no conflict; the line is 0 if at least one device pulls it low (wired-AND)

Push-pull is the normal choice for LEDs and chip-selects (fast, clean edges). Open-drain is required when several devices share one wire, as on the two I2C lines.

1.4.2 UART

A **UART** (Universal Asynchronous Receiver-Transmitter) sends bytes one bit at a time over a single wire per direction. It is **asynchronous**: there is no clock wire, so transmitter and receiver must agree in advance on the speed, the **baud rate** (bits per second), and each side times the bits with its own clock.

Element	Description
Wires	TX (transmit) and RX (receive), crossed between the two devices: the TX of one goes to the RX of the other; plus a common ground
Idle line	held at 1 when nothing is sent
Start bit	one 0 bit: the falling edge tells the receiver that a byte is starting and synchronizes its timing
Data bits	usually 8, sent **least significant bit first**
Parity bit	optional error check (none in the common **8N1** format: 8 data bits, no parity, 1 stop bit)
Stop bit	one 1 bit: returns the line to idle before the next byte

Transmission of `'A'` (`0x41` = `0100 0001`) in 8N1 format, bit 0 first:

```
idle  start  b0  b1  b2  b3  b4  b5  b6  b7  stop  idle
 1      0     1   0   0   0   0   0   1   0    1     1
```

Each byte therefore takes **10 bits** on the wire (start + 8 data + stop). At 115 200 baud one bit lasts about 8.7 µs, so one byte takes about **87 µs**: a long time for a CPU running at 25 MHz, which is why the way the CPU waits for the UART (polling or interrupts) matters.

1.4.3 DMA

Moving data between a peripheral and memory normally costs CPU time: the CPU must read each byte from the device and store it in memory, or the opposite. A **DMA controller** (Direct Memory Access) is a separate hardware

unit that performs these copies on its own, leaving the CPU free to execute other code while the transfer is in progress.

Aspect	Description
Operation	copies source → destination for a count, using the bus while the CPU runs; usually signals completion with an interrupt
Directions	peripheral → memory (UART RX, ADC); memory → peripheral (SPI TX)
Costs	bus contention; the buffer must not be touched during the transfer
AN385	no DMA: the CPU moves every byte

2 Memory-Mapped I/O

On a Cortex-M, devices have **no special I/O instructions**: each device register is a **memory address**, and the CPU controls the device with ordinary loads and stores.

With **memory-mapped I/O** (MMIO), every peripheral register has a fixed physical address and is accessed with ordinary load and store instructions:

```
#define UART0_DATA (*(volatile uint32_t *)0x40004000u)

UART0_DATA = 'A';      /* a store to 0x40004000: the UART transmits 'A' */
```

The assignment compiles to a single `str` at `0x40004000`: the syntax is a variable access, the meaning is defined by the hardware.

2.1 Device Registers Are Not RAM

Although a device register is accessed like a variable, **it does not behave like memory:** reading or writing it can trigger actions in the hardware.

Property of a device register	Example
A **read** can have a side effect	consuming a received byte, acknowledging an event
A **write** can start an action	a transmission, a flag clear, a pin change
The value can **change without any store**	a status bit set when a byte arrives
The value read back can **differ** from the value written	read-only bits, self-clearing bits, reserved bits that must be written as zero or preserved

2.2 The `volatile` Qualifier

The C compiler assumes that **memory changes only when the program writes it**. For device registers this assumption is false, and `volatile` tells the compiler not to rely on it.

Under optimization the compiler caches values, removes repeated reads, and merges stores: all invalid for device registers.

TRY IT: `VOLATILE` AT `-O2`

Goal: see the compiler delete a hardware read. In a folder **outside** `base/` (e.g. `/tmp/vol`), create `poll.c`:

```c
#include <stdint.h>

#ifndef QUAL
#define QUAL    /* empty: a plain pointer */
#endif

/* UART0 STATE, bit 0 = TXBF */
#define UART0_STATE \
    (*(QUAL uint32_t *)0x40004004u)

void wait_tx_room(void)
{
    while (UART0_STATE & 1u)
    {
        /* wait until TXBF is 0 */
    }
}
```

Compile it twice at `-O2`, once with `-DQUAL=volatile` (defines `QUAL` as `volatile`), and disassemble both:

control the level of optimization

```
arm-none-eabi-gcc -mthumb -mcpu=cortex-m3 \
  -O2 -c poll.c -o plain.o
arm-none-eabi-gcc -mthumb -mcpu=cortex-m3 \
  -O2 -DQUAL=volatile -c poll.c -o vol.o
arm-none-eabi-objdump -d plain.o
arm-none-eabi-objdump -d vol.o
```

Predict: which version jumps back to the `ldr`? (Answers next slide.)

TRY IT: `VOLATILE` AT `-O2` — ANSWERS

`plain.o`: the read happens once; the "loop" is a jump to itself.

```
0: mov.w r3, #0x40004000   /* r3 = 0x40004000                        */
4: ldr   r3, [r3, #4]      /* r3 = STATE   (read ONCE)                */
6: lsls  r3, r3, #31       /* shift bit 0 into the sign: N flag = TXBF */
8: bmi.n c                 /* if (TXBF) goto c                        */
a: bx    lr                /* return                                  */
c: b.n   c                 /* c: goto c  -> for (;;) { }, never reads again */
```

`vol.o`: the loop goes back to the `ldr` and reads `STATE` on every turn.

```
0: mov.w r2, #0x40004000   /* r2 = 0x40004000                */
4: ldr   r3, [r2, #4]      /* r3 = STATE   (read every turn)  */
6: lsls  r3, r3, #31       /* N flag = TXBF                   */
8: bmi.n 4                 /* if (TXBF) goto 4: read again    */
a: bx    lr                /* return                          */
```

Without `volatile`, a UART busy at the first read hangs the program for ever. At `-O0` (our Makefile) the plain version happens to re-read, so the bug hides until you optimize: always use `volatile` for registers.

Build	Loop branch target	Effect
`-O2`, plain	`c` (itself)	`STATE` read once: a UART busy at the first read hangs the program forever
`-O2`, `volatile`	`4` (the `ldr`)	`STATE` re-read on every iteration: correct
`-O0`, plain	—	re-read by chance: the bug stays **latent** until optimization is enabled

> ⚠ **WHAT `VOLATILE` DOES AND DOES NOT DO**
>
> It forces every source access to be performed, in order with respect to other `volatile` accesses. It gives **no atomicity** and **no synchronization** between `main` and a handler.

2.3 Read-Modify-Write Hazards

Changing one bit of a register with `|=` or `&=` looks like a single (atomic) operation in C, but the CPU performs it in several different steps. Since a device register can also change at run time, something can go wrong between them.

```
CMSDK_GPIO0->DATAOUT |= (1u << 0);      /* set bit 0 of the output latch */
```

```
    ldr  r1, [r0]       /* 1. READ   the whole register into r1   */
    orr  r1, r1, #1     /* 2. MODIFY bit 0 inside the CPU         */
    str  r1, [r0]       /* 3. WRITE  the whole value back         */
```

The GPIO (`0x40010000`) offers both ways of changing a pin:

Register	Function	How it is written
`DATA`	read: current pin levels; write: pin drive	plain store
`DATAOUT`	output latch: the levels driven on output pins	**read-modify-write** (OR-assignment or `&=`) to change one bit
`OUTENABLESET` / `OUTENABLECLR`	make pins outputs / inputs	**set/clear register**: only the 1 bits act, 0 bits are ignored

```
static void gpio_init(void)
{
    CMSDK_GPIO0->OUTENABLESET = (1u << 0);   /* one store: pin 0 becomes an output */
}

static void gpio_set(unsigned pin, int high)
{
    if (high) CMSDK_GPIO0->DATAOUT |= (1u << pin);    /* read-modify-write */
    else      CMSDK_GPIO0->DATAOUT &= ~(1u << pin);   /* read-modify-write */
}
```

`gpio_init` is safe: a single store, no read. `gpio_set` rewrites the **whole** register to change one bit, which fails in three cases:

Hazard	What happens	Example
Concurrent modification	another context changes the register between the read and the write; the write puts back the old value and **cancels** that change	`main` sets bit 0 of `DATAOUT`; an interrupt between `ldr` and `str` sets bit 1; the `str` writes the value read before, and bit 1 is lost
Write-1-to-clear (W1C) bits	writing a 1 *clears* a flag; writing back the read value clears **every** flag that was set	UART `INTSTATUS` reads `0b11` (TX and RX pending); OR-ing in TX writes `0b11` back and also clears RX: the RX event is lost
Read differs from write	the value read is not what was written; writing it back changes bits never meant to be touched	GPIO `DATA` returns the pin levels, including input pins; writing it back drives outputs with the levels just observed instead of the intended ones

The safe alternatives avoid the read, or make sure nothing can happen between read and write:

Safe pattern	Code	When
Set/clear register	`CMSDK_GPIO0->OUTENABLESET = (1u << pin);`	whenever the device provides one (GPIO `OUTENABLESET` / `OUTENABLECLR`, NVIC `ISER` / `ICER`)
Plain write of the single bit	`CMSDK_UART0->INTSTATUS = UART_INT_TX;`	W1C registers: only the written 1 acts, the other flags are untouched
Protected read-modify-write	`irq_save()`, read-modify-write, `irq_restore()` (see the section on critical sections), or done before interrupts are enabled	unavoidable cases, e.g. `CCR`, where `STKALIGN` must stay 1

2.4 Register Overlays with C Structures

Instead of one macro per register, a whole register block can be described by a C `struct` placed at the device's base address, so that every register becomes a named field.

```
typedef struct
{
    volatile uint32_t DATA;      /* 0x00 read = received byte, write = byte to send */
    volatile uint32_t STATE;     /* 0x04 status flags */
    volatile uint32_t CTRL;      /* 0x08 control flags */
    volatile uint32_t INTSTATUS; /* 0x0C interrupt status; write 1 to clear a bit */
    volatile uint32_t BAUDDIV;   /* 0x10 baud-rate divider */
} CMSDK_UART_TypeDef;

#define CMSDK_UART0   ( ( CMSDK_UART_TypeDef * ) 0x40004000UL )
```

Element	Meaning
Layout	fields at consecutive 4-byte offsets from the base address

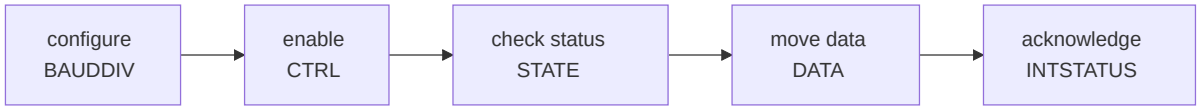
Element	Meaning
`CMSDK_UART0`	a constant pointer, not a variable: `->STATE` is a load from `0x40004004`
Safety	`volatile` fields; bit names next to the `struct` (`UART_STATE_TXBF` is `1UL << 0`); `_Static_assert` + `offsetof` catch layout typos at compile time

The same technique describes SysTick, NVIC, SCB, timers, watchdog, GPIO, and FPGAIO.

2.5 Registers as a Hardware Protocol

Device registers must be used in a precise order, like the steps of a protocol; the **driver is the code that implements this order**.

Figure 4.3 — Register protocol of a device



Rule	Example
Configuration precedes enabling	speed before switching the transmitter on
A status check precedes every transfer	write `DATA` only when there is room, read it only when a byte is present
An event is acknowledged	clearing its flag lets the device report the next one

2.6 Real, Placeholder, and Missing Devices under QEMU

QEMU **does not emulate every device of the board equally well**. Knowing which devices are real models and which are placeholders explains why some drivers cannot be tested in the emulator.

The QEMU monitor lists the object answering at each address range:

```
printf 'info mtree -f\nquit\n' | qemu-system-arm -M mps2-an385 -display none -S -monitor stdio
-serial null | grep ' 00000000400' | sort -u
```

```
0000000040000000-0000000040000fff (prio 0, i/o): cmsdk-apb-timer
0000000040002000-0000000040002fff (prio 0, i/o): cmsdk-apb-dualtimer
0000000040004000-0000000040004fff (prio 0, i/o): uart
0000000040008000-0000000040008fff (prio 0, i/o): cmsdk-apb-watchdog
0000000040010000-0000000040010fff (prio -1000, i/o): cmsdk-ahb-gpio
0000000040020000-0000000040020fff (prio 0, i/o): pl022
0000000040022000-0000000040022fff (prio 0, i/o): arm_sbcon_i2c
0000000040028000-0000000040028fff (prio 0, i/o): mps2-fpgaio
```

Case	Recognized by	Behaviour	Example	`-d unimp` output
Real model	`prio 0` + device name	registers behave like the hardware	UART0 `0x40004000`, SysTick, NVIC	nothing
Placeholder	`prio -1000`	writes ignored, reads return 0	GPIO0 `0x40010000`	line naming the device (`cmsdk-ahb-gpio`)
No device	no entry	—	`0x40080000`	line naming a region (`RESERVED 4`)

None of the cases faults. `-d unimp` logs accesses to placeholders and unmapped regions, `-d guest_errors` misuse of real models (e.g. writing to a disabled UART transmitter): a run with no `-d unimp` output places any malfunction in the code. A GPIO driver cannot be verified in QEMU; the FPGAIO LED register instead keeps the written value.

> **CORE VERSUS BOARD PERIPHERALS**
>
> **Core** peripherals (SysTick, NVIC) have addresses fixed by ARMv7-M and exist on every Cortex-M. **Board** peripherals (UART0, GPIO0, FPGAIO) exist where the board places them, modelled as faithfully as the emulator allows.

3 Device Drivers and Polled UART I/O

The first driver built on these concepts is the UART, the serial port used as console. On top of it, a small formatting library provides `kprintf` for kernel output.

3.1 CMSDK UART Register Interface

The UART (Universal Asynchronous Receiver-Transmitter) sends and receives bytes on a serial line. It is controlled through five registers at `0x40004000`.

Offset	Register	Access	Content
`0x00`	`DATA`	R/W	write: byte to send; read: received byte (clears RXBF)
`0x04`	`STATE`	R; bits 2–3 W1C	TXBF, RXBF, TXOR, RXOR
`0x08`	`CTRL`	R/W	TXEN, RXEN, TXIRQEN, RXIRQEN, overrun IRQ enables
`0x0C`	`INTSTATUS`	R/W1C	TX, RX, TXOR, RXOR interrupt pending
`0x10`	`BAUDDIV`	R/W	clock / baud rate, minimum 16

STATE 8-bit

UART STATE (0x04), low byte of the 32-bit register



Bits	Field	Description
3	RXOR	Receive overrun: a byte was lost (write 1 to clear)
2	TXOR	Transmit overrun: a write was lost (write 1 to clear)
1	RXBF	Receive buffer full: a byte is waiting
0	TXBF	Transmit buffer full: the previous byte is still leaving

CTRL 8-bit = 0x03

UART CTRL (0x08) after uart_init, low byte



Bits	Field	Value	Description
5	RXORIRQEN	0	Receive-overrun interrupt enable
4	TXORIRQEN	0	Transmit-overrun interrupt enable
3	RXIRQEN	0	Receive interrupt enable
2	TXIRQEN	0	Transmit interrupt enable
1	RXEN	1	Receiver enable
0	TXEN	1	Transmitter enable

INTSTATUS 8-bit

UART INTSTATUS (0x0C), write 1 to clear a bit



Bits	Field	Description
3	RXOR	Receive-overrun interrupt pending
2	TXOR	Transmit-overrun interrupt pending
1	RX	Receive interrupt pending
0	TX	Transmit interrupt pending

Behaviour	Consequence
One byte buffered per direction	a write while TXBF = 1 is lost (TXOR); a byte arriving while RXBF = 1 is lost (RXOR)
`CTRL` = 0 after reset	transmitter and receiver off: writes to `DATA` are ignored
`BAUDDIV` on real hardware	25 000 000 / 115 200 ≈ 217 for 115 200 baud
`BAUDDIV` under QEMU	speed ignored; 16 (minimum legal value) is used

3.2 The Device Driver Abstraction

A driver separates *what* the rest of the system wants to do (send a byte) from *how* a particular device does it (which registers to touch, in which order). It is the only code that touches the device's registers; everything else calls its functions.

All character devices (UART, terminal, …) offer the same three operations. They can be collected in a `struct` whose fields are **pointers to functions**: each field holds the address of the function that performs that operation for one specific device.

```
struct char_driver
{
    void ( *init )( void );       /* bring the device up     */
    int  ( *read )( void );       /* one byte, or -1 if none */
    void ( *write )( char c );    /* send one byte           */
};

/* The UART driver fills the struct with its own functions */
static const struct char_driver uart0_driver = {
    uart_init,                    /* init  */
    uart_getc_polled,             /* read  */
    uart_putc_polled              /* write */
};

/* Generic code: works with any driver passed to it */
void say_hi( const struct char_driver *dev )
{
    dev->write( 'h' );            /* calls the write function of that driver */
    dev->write( 'i' );
}
```

`say_hi( &uart0_driver )` prints "hi" on the UART; passing another driver prints it on another device, without changing `say_hi`.

Aspect	Description
Interface	every driver offers the same operations (init, read, write); replacing the UART means replacing one driver file
Generalization	operating systems use this pattern for every class of device: Linux `struct file_operations` (`.open`, `.read`, `.write`, …) is filled in by each driver
This kernel	with a single console the `struct` is not needed: the kernel calls `uart_putc_polled` directly

3.3 Polled UART Driver

The simplest UART driver uses **polling**: the CPU repeatedly reads the status register until the device is ready, **without using interrupts**.

```
#include "drivers/uart.h"
#include "cmsdk.h"

void uart_init( void )
{
    CMSDK_UART0->BAUDDIV = 16;                          /* configure */
    CMSDK_UART0->CTRL = UART_CTRL_TXEN | UART_CTRL_RXEN;    /* enable */
}

void uart_putc_polled( char c )
{
    while ( CMSDK_UART0->STATE & UART_STATE_TXBF )          /* check status: room? */
    {
    }
    CMSDK_UART0->DATA = (uint32_t) (unsigned char) c;       /* move data */
}

int uart_getc_polled( void )
{
    if ( ( CMSDK_UART0->STATE & UART_STATE_RXBF ) == 0 )    /* check status: byte? */
    {
        return -1;
    }
    return (int) ( CMSDK_UART0->DATA & 0xFF );              /* reading DATA takes the byte */
}
```

Function	Protocol steps	Behaviour
`uart_init`	configure (`BAUDDIV`), enable (`CTRL`)	brings the UART to a known state
`uart_putc_polled`	check TXBF in a loop, write `DATA`	blocks until there is room

Function	Protocol steps	Behaviour
`uart_getc_polled`	check RXBF once, read `DATA`	never blocks: returns `-1` if no byte is waiting

Polled: status is checked by the CPU, not signalled by interrupts. The cast through `unsigned char` keeps a byte such as `0xE9` from becoming `0xFFFFFFE9` when `char` is signed.

> ⚠ **ENABLE BEFORE MOVING DATA**
>
> Without `uart_init`, `CTRL` stays 0 and every byte is silently dropped (`-d guest_errors`: `transmit data write with Tx disabled`).

3.4 Variadic Functions and `<stdarg.h>`

A `printf`-like function accepts a variable number of arguments. C supports this with *variadic functions* and the macros of `<stdarg.h>`.

```
void kprintf( const char *fmt, ... )
{
    va_list ap;                     /* a cursor over the extra arguments    */
    va_start( ap, fmt );            /* start right after the last named one */
    int n = va_arg( ap, int );      /* take the next argument, as an int    */
    va_end( ap );                   /* done                                 */
}
```

Rule	Meaning
Argument count and types	unknown to the function: the **format string** supplies them; a mismatch is undefined behaviour
Default promotions	a `char` arrives as an `int`: `%c` uses `va_arg( ap, int )`
Freestanding	`<stdarg.h>` has only types and built-ins, no library code
Convention	a function taking a `va_list` is named `v…` (`vprintf`)

3.5 A Shared Formatting Core: `vformat` and `kprintf`

Turning a format string and its arguments into characters is the same work whatever the destination (UART, buffer, …), so it is written once in `vformat` and reused.

Formatting is separated from output: `vformat` calls `out( c, ctx )` per character, and `ctx` carries the destination's state.

```
static void put_string( void ( *out )( char c, void *ctx ), void *ctx, const char *s )
{
    while ( *s != '\0' )
    {
```

```
        out( *s, ctx );
        s++;
    }
}

void vformat( void ( *out )( char c, void *ctx ), void *ctx, const char *fmt, va_list ap )
{
    char num[12];   /* longest number + '\0' */

    while ( *fmt != '\0' )
    {
        if ( *fmt != '%' )              /* ordinary character: pass it on */
        {
            out( *fmt, ctx );
            fmt++;
            continue;
        }
        fmt++;                          /* a '%': look at the next letter */
        switch ( *fmt )
        {
        case 'c':
            out( (char) va_arg( ap, int ), ctx );   /* a char arrives as an int */
            break;
        case 's':
        {
            const char *s = va_arg( ap, const char * );
            put_string( out, ctx, s != 0 ? s : "(null)" );  /* no crash on null */
            break;
        }
        case 'd':
        {
            int v = va_arg( ap, int );
            uint32_t mag;
            if ( v < 0 ) { out( '-', ctx ); mag = 0u - (uint32_t) v; }
            else         { mag = (uint32_t) v; }
            utoa_dec( mag, num );
            put_string( out, ctx, num );
            break;
        }
        case 'u': utoa_dec( va_arg( ap, uint32_t ), num ); put_string( out, ctx, num ); break;
        case 'x': utoa_hex( va_arg( ap, uint32_t ), num ); put_string( out, ctx, num ); break;
        case '%': out( '%', ctx ); break;
        case '\0': out( '%', ctx ); return;          /* string ended right after '%' */
```

```
        default:  out( '%', ctx ); out( *fmt, ctx ); break;  /* unknown: as written */
        }
        fmt++;                          /* past the conversion letter */
    }
}
```

Aspect	Description
Conversions	`%c` , `%s` , `%d` , `%u` , `%x` (no `0x`), `%%` ; no width; unknown ones printed literally
`%d` magnitude	`0u - (uint32_t) v` , not `-v` : `-INT_MIN` overflows (UB), unsigned subtraction is always defined

```
static void kprintf_out( char c, void *ctx )
{
    (void) ctx;                         /* not used */
    uart_putc_polled( c );
}

void kprintf( const char *fmt, ... )
{
    va_list ap;
    va_start( ap, fmt );
    vformat( kprintf_out, 0, fmt, ap );
    va_end( ap );
}
```

`kprintf( "d=%d\n", -42 )` makes six `kprintf_out` calls. Polled, unbuffered, and interrupt-free, `kprintf` works in **any context**, fault handlers included.

3.6 Fault Handlers That Report CFSR and HFSR

With a working `kprintf` , fault handlers can print *why* a fault happened instead of hanging silently, by **reading the fault status registers of the core**.

Each fault handler prints its status register with `kprintf` , then halts.

Register	Address	Content
CFSR (Configurable Fault Status)	`0xE000ED28`	one bit per cause of MemManage, BusFault, UsageFault
HFSR (HardFault Status)	`0xE000ED2C`	why a HardFault occurred

DIVISION BY ZERO

With `CCR.DIV_0_TRP` set, an integer division by a `volatile` zero (`volatile` prevents compile-time evaluation) prints `UsageFault: CFSR=0x2000000` : bit 25, `DIVBYZERO` .

TRY IT: FAULT HANDLERS THAT PRINT (1/3)

Goal: the base's fault handlers are silent loops; make them print through the UART. In `kernel/faults.c`, replace everything below the header comment with the code of the two columns, left then right (the same four handlers, now printing, plus a `halt` helper):

```c
#include "cmsdk.h"
#include "kernel/kprintf.h"
/* Stop here for ever. */
static void halt( void )
{
    for ( ;; )
    {
    }
}
/* HFSR tells why it came here. */
void HardFault_Handler( void )
{
    kprintf( "HardFault: HFSR=0x%x\n", SCB->HFSR );
    halt();
}
```

```c
void MemManage_Handler( void )
{
    kprintf( "MemManage: CFSR=0x%x\n", SCB->CFSR );
    halt();
}
void BusFault_Handler( void )
{
    kprintf( "BusFault: CFSR=0x%x\n", SCB->CFSR );
    halt();
}
void UsageFault_Handler( void )
{
    kprintf( "UsageFault: CFSR=0x%x\n", SCB->CFSR );
    halt();
}
```

4 Polling and Interrupts

Polling wastes CPU time; interrupts let a device call the CPU only when needed. The hardware mechanism that enters and leaves a handler is described in the exception model of the chapter on the ARM Cortex-M3 architecture; this section compares the two approaches and shows what the mechanism means for driver code.

4.1 Polling versus Interrupts

There are two ways to find out when a device is ready: the CPU keeps asking (**polling**), or the device signals the CPU (**interrupt**). Each has its uses.

Aspect	Polling	Interrupts
CPU time	spent in the waiting loop even when nothing happens	spent only per event (entry, handler, exit)
Latency	up to one trip around the loop; grows with the devices checked	about 12 cycles of entry on Cortex-M3, nearly constant
Complexity	one loop	handler, shared data, priorities
CPU between events	busy	free, or asleep (`wfi`)
Suited to	certain, imminent events; contexts without interrupts (fault handlers)	rare or unpredictable events, long transfers

One byte at 115 200 baud lasts ~87 µs, about **2 170 cycles** at 25 MHz wasted by polling.

4.2 Interrupt Handlers Are Ordinary C Functions

On exception entry the Cortex-M3 pushes `r0` – `r3`, `r12`, `lr`, `PC`, and `xPSR` on the current stack and loads `EXC_RETURN` into `lr`. These are exactly the registers that the AAPCS allows a C function to clobber, and any compiled C function already preserves `r4` – `r11`. A device handler is therefore written as a plain C function whose name matches the vector table entry, and its ordinary return becomes an exception return. The register roles of the AAPCS, the stacked frame, `EXC_RETURN`, and tail-chaining are described in the Cortex-M3 chapter; the frame can be observed with gdb, as shown in the SysTick section below.

5 The SysTick Timer and Wraparound-Safe Time Keeping

An operating system needs a notion of time. SysTick, a **timer** built into every Cortex-M, generates a **periodic interrupt** (the *tick*) from which the kernel counts **milliseconds**.

5.1 SysTick Configuration

SysTick is the 24-bit down-counter built into every Cortex-M core. Its four registers (`CTRL` , `LOAD` , `VAL` , `CALIB` at `0xE000E010` – `0xE000E01C`), the choice of clock source, and the differences between SysTick and a device interrupt are described in the SysTick section of the chapter on the ARM Cortex-M3 architecture. The driver needs only three facts: one period lasts `LOAD + 1` cycles of the processor clock (25 MHz on `mps2-an385`); writing `CTRL = 7` starts the counter on the processor clock with the exception enabled; and SysTick is a core exception (number 15), so its priority is set in `SHPR3` and its handler needs no acknowledgement.

5.2 Reload Value and Tick Rate

The tick period is chosen by writing a reload value; it is computed from the clock frequency and the desired number of ticks per second.

From period = (`LOAD` + 1) / f: **`LOAD` = f / rate − 1**. At 25 MHz and 100 ticks/s, `LOAD` = 25 000 000 / 100 − 1 = **249 999** (`0x3D08F`), which fits in 24 bits; the longest period is 2^24 cycles ≈ 0.67 s.

Tick	Rate	Resolution	Exceptions/s	Note
1 ms	1 000 Hz	1 ms	1 000	in QEMU runs about 26% slow in wall-clock time
10 ms	100 Hz	10 ms	100	classic OS rate; exact wall-clock time in QEMU

A faster tick gives finer resolution at the cost of more exceptions.

5.3 SysTick Driver and Uptime Counter

The driver starts SysTick and counts elapsed milliseconds in a variable updated by the interrupt handler.

```
#define CPU_CLOCK_HZ 25000000UL     /* processor clock: 25 MHz */

static volatile uint32_t uptime_ms; /* changed by the handler */

void systick_init( void )
{
    uptime_ms = 0;
    SysTick->LOAD = CPU_CLOCK_HZ / ( 1000 / TICK_MS ) - 1;   /* 249 999 for TICK_MS = 10 */
    SysTick->VAL = 0;               /* any write: counter = 0 */
    SysTick->CTRL = SysTick_CTRL_ENABLE | SysTick_CTRL_TICKINT | SysTick_CTRL_CLKSOURCE;
}

void SysTick_Handler( void )
```

```
{
    uptime_ms += TICK_MS;           /* no acknowledge needed */
}

uint32_t systick_uptime_ms( void )
{
    return uptime_ms;               /* one 32-bit read: never torn */
}
```

`SysTick_Handler` overrides the weak default in slot 15; `uptime_ms` is `volatile` because the handler changes it, and its single aligned 32-bit read can never be **torn**.

5.4 Wraparound-Safe Elapsed Time

The kernel measures time with a `uint32_t` counter of milliseconds (`uptime_ms`). A 32-bit variable can count only up to $2^{32}-1$ (`0xFFFFFFFF`); one millisecond later it **wraps around** to 0. This happens after 2^{32} ms ≈ **49.7 days**, a realistic uptime for an embedded device, so code that measures elapsed time must stay correct across the wrap.

> **ANALOGY: A 12-HOUR CLOCK**
>
> From 11 o'clock to 2 o'clock, 3 hours pass, even though 2 is smaller than 11. Counting on the clock face, $(2-11) \bmod 12 = 3$. Unsigned arithmetic in C works the same way, on a "clock" of 2^{32} positions: subtraction is computed **modulo** 2^{32}, so `now - start` is always the true distance from `start` to `now` , even if `now` has wrapped past 0.

Two ways to test whether `delay` ms have passed since `start` :

Test	Across the wrap	Why
`now - start >= delay`	**correct**	the subtraction gives the real elapsed time, modulo 2^32
`now >= start + delay`	**wrong**	`start + delay` can itself wrap to a small number, so the comparison becomes true too early

WORKED EXAMPLE: `START = 0XFFFFFF00`, `DELAY = 300` MS

`start` is 256 ms before the wrap (`0xFFFFFFFF` + 1 = 0).

Moment	`now`	`now - start` (correct test)	`start + delay` (wrong test)
16 ms after start	`0xFFFFFF10`	16 → 16 < 300: **not yet** ✔	wraps to 44; `0xFFFFFF10` ≥ 44 → **elapsed ✘** (284 ms too early)
356 ms after start (after the wrap)	`0x00000064` (100)	256 + 100 = 356 → 356 ≥ 300: **elapsed ✔**	—

The subtraction always measures the real distance; the addition breaks as soon as `start + delay` passes `0xFFFFFFFF`.

5.5 Idle Loop with `wfi`

When there is nothing to do, the CPU should sleep instead of spinning. The `wfi` instruction puts it to **sleep until the next interrupt.**

```
uint32_t last = systick_uptime_ms();
for ( ;; )
{
    __asm volatile ( "wfi" );           /* sleep until an interrupt */
    uint32_t now = systick_uptime_ms();
    if ( now - last >= 1000 )           /* safe across wraparound */
    {
        last += 1000;
        kprintf( "uptime: %u ms\n", now );
    }
}
```

Element	Effect
`wfi`	sleeps until an exception is pending; the loop runs once per interrupt, at least every 10 ms
`last += 1000`	schedules each print 1 s after the previous one: no drift (unlike `last = now`)

5.6 Inspecting the Exception Frame in gdb

The stacked frame described in the exception model of the Cortex-M3 chapter can be observed directly with gdb, by stopping at the first instruction of `SysTick_Handler`.

```
(gdb) break *SysTick_Handler        # stop at the very first instruction
(gdb) continue
(gdb) x/8wx $sp                     # r0 r1 r2 r3 / r12 lr pc xPSR
```

```
0x203fffd0:  0x00000000  0x00000000  0x00000007  0x00000000
0x203fffe0:  0x00000000  0x0000050d  0x00000510  0x01000000
(gdb) p/x $lr
$1 = 0xfffffff9
(gdb) info symbol 0x510
main + 28 in section .text
```

Observation	Meaning
`break *SysTick_Handler`	stops before the prologue, while `sp` points at the frame
Stacked `PC` = `0x510`	instruction after `wfi` in `main`
Stacked `r2` = 7	value just written to `CTRL`
`lr` = `0xFFFFFFF9`	return to Thread mode, MSP

6 The NVIC and Interrupt-Driven UART Transmission

Device interrupts are managed by the **NVIC** (Nested Vectored Interrupt Controller). Using it, the UART can transmit in the background: the program puts bytes in a buffer, and an interrupt handler sends them one by one.

6.1 IRQ Lines and Handlers on the MPS2-AN385

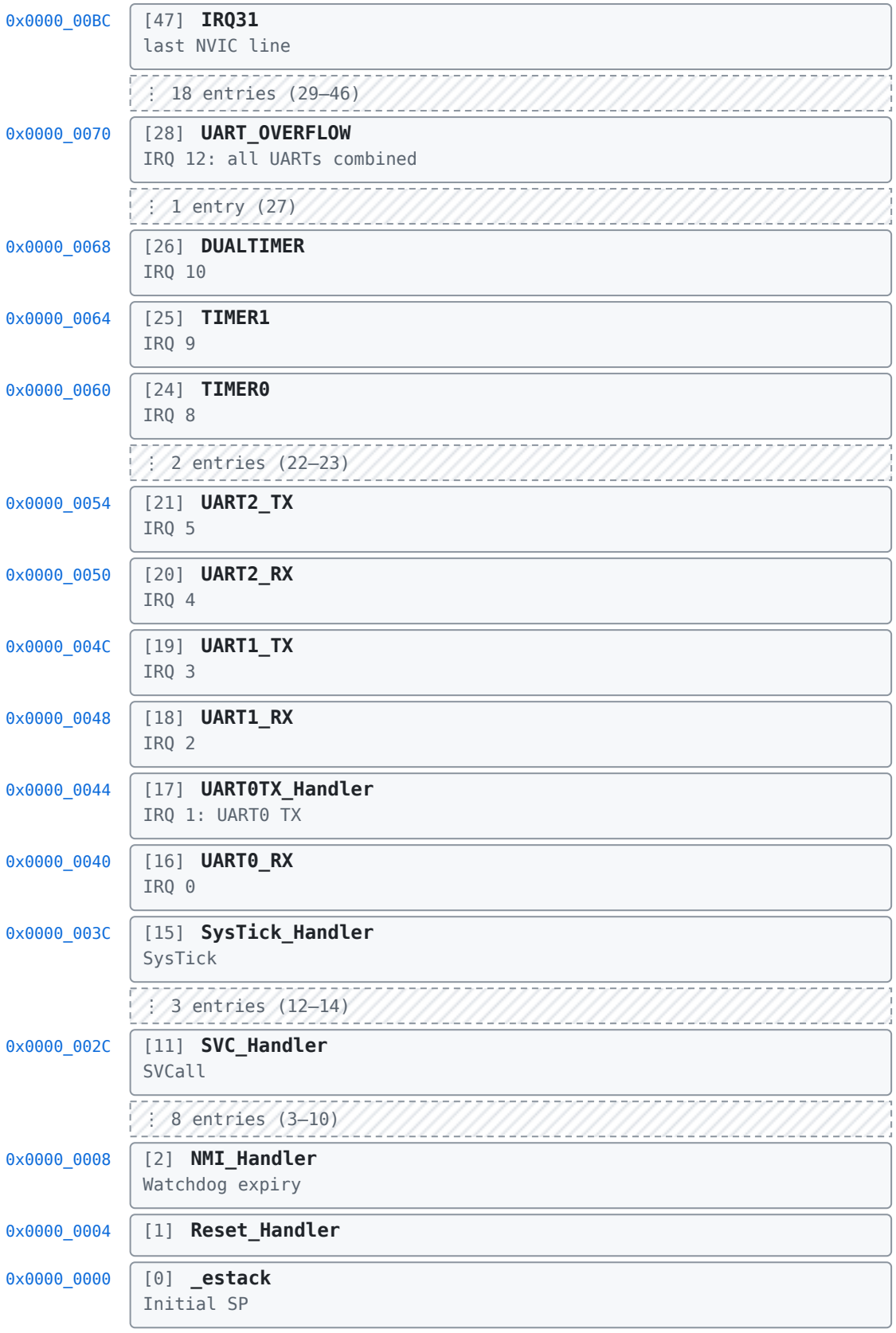
Device interrupts reach the CPU through the NVIC, whose registers are described in the Cortex-M3 chapter. The `mps2-an385` board connects 32 interrupt request lines, **IRQ 0–31**, to it. Every IRQ is also an exception with its own vector table slot: IRQ n is exception 16 + n, and its handler address is stored at offset 4 × (16 + n).

UART0 TX

IRQ 1 → exception 16 + 1 = 17 → slot address 4 × 17 = 68 = `0x44`, which holds the address of `UART0TX_Handler`.

IRQ	Source	IRQ	Source
0	UART0 RX	8	TIMER0
1	UART0 TX	9	TIMER1
2 / 3	UART1 RX / TX	10	dual timer
4 / 5	UART2 RX / TX	12	UART overflow (all UARTs; never fires in QEMU)

Figure 4.4 — Vector table with device interrupts (48 words, 0xC0 bytes)



The vector table grows from 16 to 48 words. As for the core exceptions, every device handler name is a `.weak` alias of `Default_Handler`, and a C function with the same name (for example `UART0TX_Handler`) replaces it at link time without editing the table.

The board's watchdog is connected to the **NMI** (exception 2) instead of an ordinary IRQ line. A watchdog is a timer that the software must reload periodically; if the program hangs and stops reloading it, the watchdog fires so that the system can recover. It uses the NMI because a hung program may have masked all ordinary interrupts: `PRIMASK` does not block the NMI, and its fixed priority is above every configurable one.

6.2 Enabling, Acknowledging, and Prioritising the UART Interrupt

```
NVIC->IPR[UART0TX_IRQn] = 0xC0;                              /* priority of IRQ 1 */
NVIC->ISER[UART0TX_IRQn / 32] = 1UL << ( UART0TX_IRQn % 32 ); /* enable IRQ 1 */
```

The first line writes the priority byte of IRQ 1; the second sets its bit in the enable register. Set and clear registers ignore 0 bits, so a plain assignment is enough and no `|=` is needed. The UART TX handler then runs only if three conditions hold at the same time:

1. the **device** may raise the interrupt (UART TX: `CTRL.TXIRQEN`, bit 2);
2. the **NVIC** line is enabled in `ISER`;
3. its priority is more urgent than that of the running code, and `PRIMASK` = 0.

NVIC lines are **level-sensitive**: a handler that does not clear the device flag is re-entered forever. The UART handler therefore starts by **acknowledging at the device**, with the write-1-to-clear store `CMSDK_UART0->INTSTATUS = UART_INT_TX;`.

Priorities decide which exception runs first and which can interrupt another. A lower value means more urgent, and only a **strictly more urgent** exception preempts the running one; the others stay **pending**. The kernel uses the following policy:

Exception	Priority
Faults	`0x00` or more urgent
SVCall	`0x80`
UART0 TX (IRQ 1)	`0xC0`
SysTick	`0xE0`

6.3 Races on Shared Data and Critical Sections

When `main` and a handler share data, an interrupt arriving in the middle of an update can corrupt it. A critical section prevents this by temporarily masking interrupts.

`volatile` forces real memory accesses but does not make an update indivisible:

```
/* count++ */
    ldr  r1, [r0]       /* r1 = count            (say 5)                    */
    adds r1, r1, #1     /* r1 = 6   <- the handler runs here, sets count = 6 */
    str  r1, [r0]       /* count = 6: the handler's update is lost          */
```

Operation on shared data	Safe?
Single aligned 32-bit read or write	yes
Read-modify-write (`++`, `+=`, `&=`, OR-assignment)	no: **lost update** (a **race**)
Update of several related variables	no

A **critical section** masks interrupts through `PRIMASK`, which C cannot name; two assembly functions provide nestable masking:

```
    .syntax unified
    .cpu cortex-m3
    .thumb
    .section .text,"ax",%progbits

/* uint32_t irq_save(void) */
    .global irq_save
    .type irq_save, %function
    .thumb_func
irq_save:
    mrs r0, primask             /* old = PRIMASK; r0 = return value */
    cpsid i                     /* PRIMASK = 1: interrupts masked */
    bx lr                       /* return old (in r0) */
    .size irq_save, . - irq_save

/* void irq_restore(uint32_t old) */
    .global irq_restore
    .type irq_restore, %function
    .thumb_func
irq_restore:
    msr primask, r0             /* PRIMASK = old (first argument, r0) */
    bx lr                       /* return */
    .size irq_restore, . - irq_restore
```

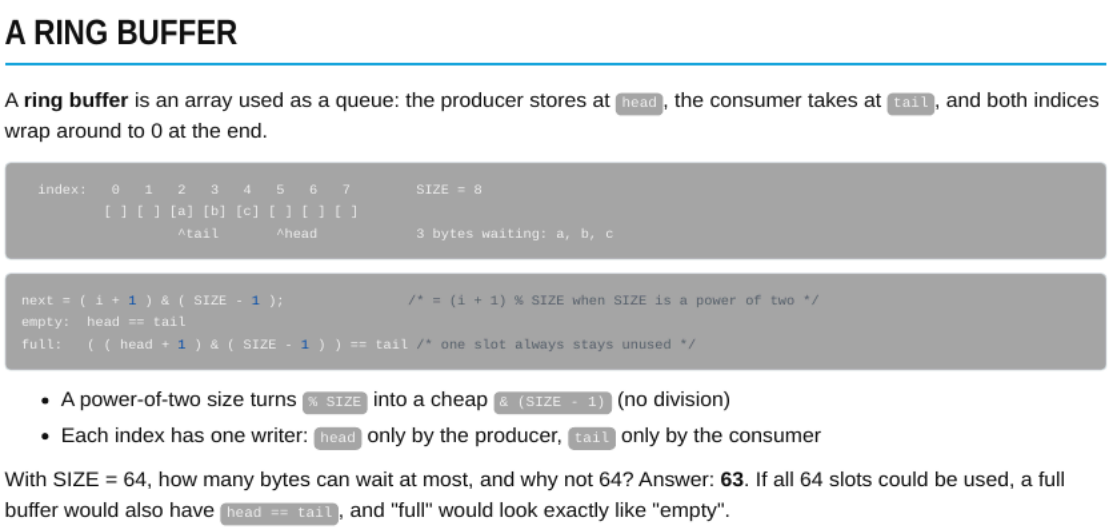
```
uint32_t a = irq_save();     /* PRIMASK 0 -> 1, a = 0 */
uint32_t b = irq_save();     /* PRIMASK already 1, b = 1 */
irq_restore( b );            /* PRIMASK stays 1: a plain cpsie here would unmask too early */
irq_restore( a );            /* PRIMASK back to 0 */
```

Rule	Reason
Restore the saved value, never `cpsie i`	sections **nest** correctly
Only the main code needs it	a handler cannot be interrupted by the main code
Short, never waiting	interrupts stay pending until `irq_restore`

6.4 Ring Buffer

A ring buffer is the data structure that connects the program (which produces bytes) and the interrupt handler (which consumes them).

A **ring buffer** is an array used as a FIFO: producer at `head`, consumer at `tail`, both wrapping.



A RING BUFFER

A **ring buffer** is an array used as a queue: the producer stores at `head`, the consumer takes at `tail`, and both indices wrap around to 0 at the end.

```
index:   0   1   2   3   4   5   6   7        SIZE = 8
       [ ] [ ] [a] [b] [c] [ ] [ ] [ ]
                ^tail       ^head            3 bytes waiting: a, b, c
```

```
next = ( i + 1 ) & ( SIZE - 1 );              /* = (i + 1) % SIZE when SIZE is a power of two */
empty:  head == tail
full:   ( ( head + 1 ) & ( SIZE - 1 ) ) == tail /* one slot always stays unused */
```

- A power-of-two size turns `% SIZE` into a cheap `& (SIZE - 1)` (no division)
- Each index has one writer: `head` only by the producer, `tail` only by the consumer

With SIZE = 64, how many bytes can wait at most, and why not 64? Answer: **63**. If all 64 slots could be used, a full buffer would also have `head == tail`, and "full" would look exactly like "empty".

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Operation	Expression
Next index	`( i + 1 ) & ( SIZE - 1 )`, equal to `% SIZE` for a power of two, with no division
Empty	`head == tail`
Full	`( ( head + 1 ) & ( SIZE - 1 ) ) == tail`

Each index has one writer. One slot stays unused, so 64 entries hold **63** bytes: otherwise full and empty would both satisfy `head == tail`.

6.5 Interrupt-Driven Transmitter

The interrupt-driven UART driver combines the previous pieces: the ring buffer, the critical section, and the TX interrupt handler.

```
#define TX_BUF_SIZE 64                  /* a power of two */

static char tx_buf[TX_BUF_SIZE];        /* bytes waiting to be sent */
static volatile unsigned tx_head;       /* next free slot: written by uart_write */
static volatile unsigned tx_tail;       /* oldest byte: written by the handler (and priming) */
static volatile int tx_busy;            /* 1 while the UART sends and its IRQ will come */
```

```c
static int tx_empty( void ) { return tx_head == tx_tail; }
static int tx_full( void )  { return ( ( tx_head + 1 ) & ( TX_BUF_SIZE - 1 ) ) == tx_tail; }

static char tx_pop( void )              /* take the oldest byte; buffer not empty */
{
    char c = tx_buf[tx_tail];
    tx_tail = ( tx_tail + 1 ) & ( TX_BUF_SIZE - 1 );
    return c;
}

void uart_init( void )
{
    CMSDK_UART0->BAUDDIV = 16;
    CMSDK_UART0->CTRL = UART_CTRL_TXEN | UART_CTRL_RXEN;
    tx_head = 0;
    tx_tail = 0;
    tx_busy = 0;
    NVIC->IPR[UART0TX_IRQn] = 0xC0;                              /* below SVCall, above
SysTick */
    NVIC->ISER[UART0TX_IRQn / 32] = 1UL << ( UART0TX_IRQn % 32 ); /* enable IRQ 1 */
}

unsigned uart_write( const char *buf, unsigned len )
{
    unsigned accepted = 0;
    uint32_t saved = irq_save();               /* the handler must not run during the updates
*/

    while ( accepted < len && !tx_full() )      /* copy what fits */
    {
        tx_buf[tx_head] = buf[accepted];
        tx_head = ( tx_head + 1 ) & ( TX_BUF_SIZE - 1 );
        accepted++;
    }

    if ( !tx_busy && !tx_empty() )              /* idle: no IRQ will come, so prime it */
    {
        CMSDK_UART0->CTRL |= UART_CTRL_TXIRQEN; /* FIRST enable the TX interrupt ... */
        while ( CMSDK_UART0->STATE & UART_STATE_TXBF )
        {
        }                                       /* (a polled byte may still be leaving) */
        CMSDK_UART0->DATA = (uint32_t) (unsigned char) tx_pop(); /* ... THEN write */
        tx_busy = 1;
```

```
    }

    irq_restore( saved );
    return accepted;
}

void UART0TX_Handler( void )
{
    CMSDK_UART0->INTSTATUS = UART_INT_TX;       /* acknowledge at the device (W1C) */

    if ( !tx_empty() )
    {
        CMSDK_UART0->DATA = (uint32_t) (unsigned char) tx_pop(); /* send the next byte */
    }
    else
    {
        CMSDK_UART0->CTRL &= ~UART_CTRL_TXIRQEN;  /* nothing left: interrupt off */
        tx_busy = 0;                              /* transmitter idle */
    }
}
```

Component	Role
`uart_write` (**producer**)	critical section; copies what fits and **returns the count accepted**, never waits; **primes** an idle transmitter with the first byte
`UART0TX_Handler` (**consumer**)	acknowledges, sends the next byte or disables `TXIRQEN`; no critical section needed

PRIMING ORDER

The TX interrupt fires when a byte has been sent **and** `TXIRQEN` was set when that byte was written. Enabling it while idle raises nothing; enabling it after the write misses that byte. Correct order: first `TXIRQEN`, then the first byte.

160 BYTES THROUGH THE 64-BYTE BUFFER

`uart_write` is called 3 times (63, 63, 34 accepted); `UART0TX_Handler` runs **160 times**, the last one disabling `TXIRQEN`.

7 System Calls and the Kernel Boundary

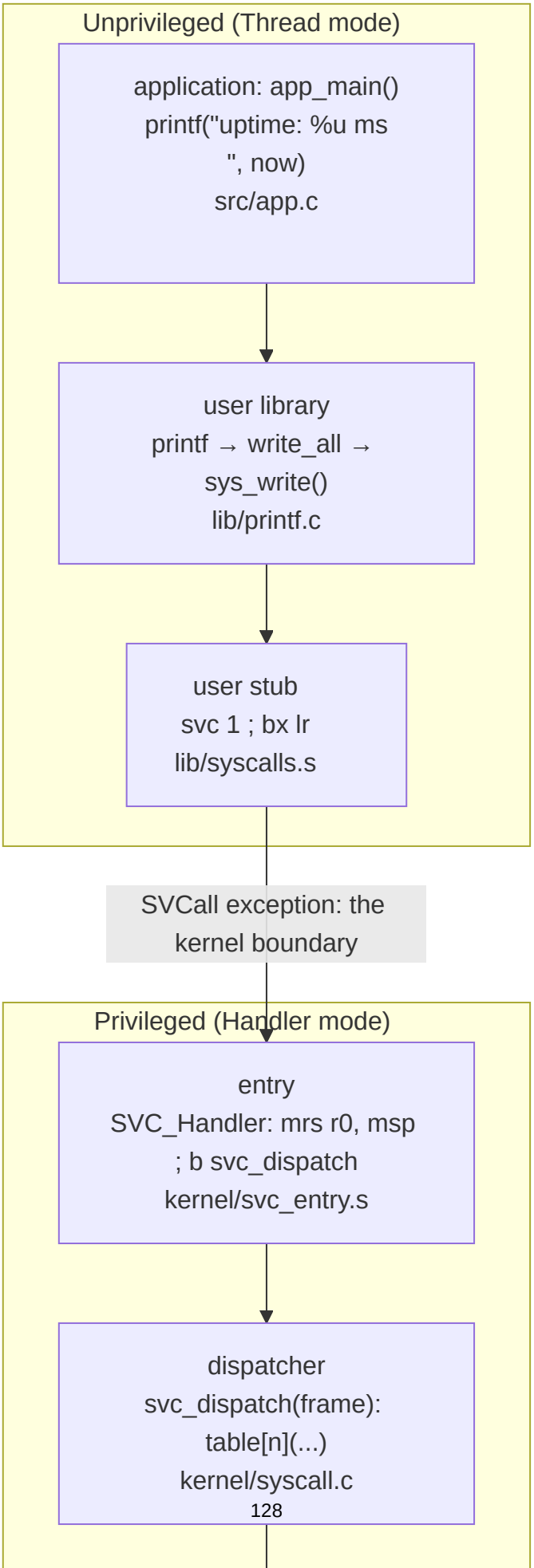
Application code can be made unprivileged, so that it cannot reconfigure the machine. It then needs a controlled way to ask the kernel for services: the system call, implemented with the `svc` instruction.

7.1 Privilege Model and Layered Structure

The Cortex-M distinguishes **privileged** and **unprivileged** execution. The system is organized in layers, with the application on the unprivileged side and the kernel and drivers on the privileged side.

Mechanism	Behaviour
`CONTROL.nPRIV` = 1 in Thread mode	execution becomes unprivileged; one-way (unprivileged code cannot clear the bit)
Unprivileged access to the System Control Space (SysTick, NVIC, SCB)	**BusFault**
`svc #n`	allowed; raises **SVCall**, whose handler runs in Handler mode, always privileged
Return from SVCall	resumes after `svc`, still unprivileged

Figure 4.5 — Layers on the two sides of the kernel boundary



Without an MPU the UART stays reachable from unprivileged code, so "all I/O through system calls" is a **design choice**, with one hard reason: `cpsid i` **is silently ignored unprivileged**, so `uart_write` is correct only when privileged.

The mechanism is the same as in a desktop operating system:

Aspect	Linux on a desktop	Bare-metal Cortex-M3
Restricted code	user-mode process	application in unprivileged Thread mode
Trap instruction	`syscall` (x86-64), `svc` (ARM)	`svc #n`
Privileged side	the kernel	`SVC_Handler` and the dispatcher
Service	`write()` puts bytes on the terminal	`sys_write()` sends bytes to the UART driver

The restricted side cannot do the job itself, so it traps into code that can, and that code decides what to do. This is the core of every operating system's protection model.

7.2 The System-Call ABI

Caller and kernel must agree on how a request is expressed at the machine level: which service is requested, where the arguments are, and where the result goes.

The **ABI** (Application Binary Interface): service number in the immediate of `svc #n`, arguments in `r0`–`r2`, result in `r0`.

Number	Service	Arguments	Result
1	`sys_write`	`buf`, `len`	bytes accepted, 0 to `len` (`uart_write`)
2	`sys_read`	none	one received byte, or `-1` (`uart_getc_polled`)
3	`sys_uptime`	none	milliseconds since start (`systick_uptime_ms`)
0, ≥ 4	none	none	`-1`

No service ever waits: the caller handles partial results.

7.3 Encoding of `svc #n` and Decoding from the Stacked Frame

The service number is not passed in a register but encoded inside the `svc` instruction itself; the kernel reads it, together with the arguments, from the stacked frame.

```
$ arm-none-eabi-objdump -d build/scratch-os.axf          one instruction per line
000008e0 <sys_write>:
 8e0:   df01    svc  1
 8e2:   4770    bx   lr

$ arm-none-eabi-objdump -s -j .text build/scratch-os.axf  raw bytes, memory order
 08e0 01df7047 02df7047 03df7047
```

svc_1 16-bit **= 0xDF01**

Thumb encoding of svc #1 (one halfword)



Bits	Field	Value	Description
15:8	`OPCODE`	0xDF (223)	0xDF identifies svc
7:0	`IMM8`	0x1 (1)	Service number n

Memory is **little-endian**: `objdump -d` shows the halfword `df01`, `objdump -s` the bytes `01 df`. With `uint32_t *frame` pointing at the stacked frame (see the exception model in the Cortex-M3 chapter; `frame[6]` = `pc`):

Item	Location	Reason
Service number `n`	`( ( uint8_t * ) frame[6] )[-2]`	the stacked `pc` points **after** the 2-byte `svc`
Arguments	`frame[0]` – `frame[2]`	stacked by the hardware: no copy needed
Result	**`frame[0]`**	the exception return pops it into the caller's `r0`

7.4 Assembly Entry Point `SVC_Handler`

To read the stacked frame, the kernel must know where it is at the very first instruction of the handler; this requires a short entry point in assembly.

The kernel needs **MSP** at entry to find the frame, but a C prologue moves `sp` first:

```
0000027a <svc_dispatch>:
 27a:  b580   push  {r7, lr}     @ sp = sp - 8
 27c:  b084   sub   sp, #16      @ sp = sp - 16
 27e:  af00   add   r7, sp, #0
```

`sp` has moved by a compiler-dependent 24 bytes. A handler that must find the frame needs an assembly entry:

```
    .global SVC_Handler         /* replaces the weak alias in the vector table */
    .type SVC_Handler, %function
    .thumb_func
SVC_Handler:
    mrs r0, msp                 /* r0 = MSP: frame = address of the 8 saved registers */
    b svc_dispatch              /* svc_dispatch(frame); lr still = EXC_RETURN */
    .size SVC_Handler, . - SVC_Handler
```

Instruction	Purpose
`mrs r0, msp`	frame address in `r0`, the first AAPCS argument of `svc_dispatch(uint32_t *frame)`

Instruction	Purpose
`b` (not `bl`)	**tail branch**: `bl` would overwrite `lr` and lose `EXC_RETURN`; with `b`, the normal return of `svc_dispatch` through `lr` performs the exception return directly

7.5 Dispatch Table and User-Side Stubs

On the kernel side, a table maps each service number to its implementation; on the application side, tiny assembly stubs turn a C call into an `svc`.

```
/* A service: up to 3 arguments (caller's r0-r2), one result (caller's r0). */
typedef uint32_t ( *syscall_fn )( uint32_t a0, uint32_t a1, uint32_t a2 );

static uint32_t sys_write_impl( uint32_t a0, uint32_t a1, uint32_t a2 )
{
    (void) a2;
    return uart_write( ( const char * ) a0, a1 );   /* bytes accepted, 0..len */
}

static uint32_t sys_read_impl( uint32_t a0, uint32_t a1, uint32_t a2 )
{
    (void) a0; (void) a1; (void) a2;
    return ( uint32_t ) uart_getc_polled();         /* byte, or -1 */
}

static uint32_t sys_uptime_impl( uint32_t a0, uint32_t a1, uint32_t a2 )
{
    (void) a0; (void) a1; (void) a2;
    return systick_uptime_ms();
}

static const syscall_fn table[] = {             /* entry 0 stays empty (0) */
    [SYS_WRITE]  = sys_write_impl,
    [SYS_READ]   = sys_read_impl,
    [SYS_UPTIME] = sys_uptime_impl,
};

#define TABLE_SIZE ( sizeof( table ) / sizeof( table[0] ) )

void svc_dispatch( uint32_t *frame )
{
    uint8_t n = ( ( uint8_t * ) frame[6] )[-2];  /* low byte of svc #n before the stacked pc
*/
```

```
    if ( n >= TABLE_SIZE || table[n] == 0 )
    {
        frame[0] = ( uint32_t ) -1;             /* unknown service */
        return;
    }
    frame[0] = table[n]( frame[0], frame[1], frame[2] );  /* result into the stacked r0 */
}
```

Element	Meaning
`syscall_fn`	one signature for all services, so they fit one array
Designated initializers	each entry at its number; entry 0 stays empty; `TABLE_SIZE` follows automatically
Bounds and null check	unknown service answers `-1`

```
/* int sys_write(const char *buf, unsigned len): buf in r0, len in r1 */
    .global sys_write
    .type sys_write, %function
    .thumb_func
sys_write:
    svc #1                      /* svc(SYS_WRITE, buf, len) */
    bx lr                       /* return r0 (set by the kernel) */
    .size sys_write, . - sys_write
```

`sys_read` (`svc #2`) and `sys_uptime` (`svc #3`) are identical. The number is part of the encoding, so it is a literal kept in sync by hand with the C header. In gdb, `x/2bx ((unsigned *)$sp)[6] - 2` at `SVC_Handler` shows `0x03 0xdf` (`svc #3`), and `finish` from `svc_dispatch` lands on the stub's `bx lr` : the return was the exception return.

7.6 User-Space `printf` , `write_all` , and `sleep_ms`

Unprivileged code cannot use `kprintf` , so the application gets its own `printf` , built only on system calls.

Aspect	`kprintf` (kernel)	`printf` (user)
Each character goes to	`uart_putc_polled`	a 64-byte buffer on the stack
When the buffer is full, or at the end	—	`write_all(buf, used)`
Path to the UART	direct register access (privileged)	`sys_write` → `svc #1`

```
#define PRINTF_BUF_SIZE 64      /* characters per sys_write */

void write_all( const char *buf, unsigned len )
{
    while ( len > 0 )
```

```
    {
        int n = sys_write( buf, len );  /* the kernel takes what fits */
        buf += n;
        len -= n;
        if ( n == 0 )
        {
            __asm volatile ( "wfi" );   /* full: sleep until an interrupt */
        }
    }
}

struct printf_ctx
{
    char buf[PRINTF_BUF_SIZE];  /* characters not sent yet */
    unsigned used;              /* how many of buf are in use */
    int total;                  /* characters produced so far */
};

static void printf_out( char c, void *ctx )    /* store one char, flush when full */
{
    struct printf_ctx *p = ctx;
    p->buf[p->used] = c;
    p->used++;
    p->total++;
    if ( p->used == PRINTF_BUF_SIZE )
    {
        write_all( p->buf, p->used );
        p->used = 0;
    }
}

int printf( const char *fmt, ... )
{
    struct printf_ctx p;                    /* on the stack, about 72 bytes */
    p.used = 0;
    p.total = 0;
    va_list ap;
    va_start( ap, fmt );
    vformat( printf_out, &p, fmt, ap );
    va_end( ap );
    write_all( p.buf, p.used );             /* send what is left */
    return p.total;
}
```

```c
void sleep_ms( uint32_t ms )
{
    uint32_t start = sys_uptime();
    while ( sys_uptime() - start < ms )     /* safe across wraparound */
    {
        __asm volatile ( "wfi" );
    }
}
```

Element	Design point
64-byte buffer	one system call per 64 characters
`write_all`	handles **partial writes**; on 0 accepted, `wfi` (allowed unprivileged) until the TX interrupt frees room
`sleep_ms`	the **waiting happens in Thread mode**, where interrupts run

> ⚠ **HIDDEN `MEMSET` IN A FREESTANDING BUILD**
>
> `struct printf_ctx p = { .used = 0, .total = 0 };` fails to link (`undefined reference to 'memset'`): GCC zero-fills the array by calling `memset` , absent without a C library.

7.7 Kernel Start and Unprivileged Application

`main` initializes the system while still privileged, then drops privilege and hands control to the application, which from then on uses only system calls.

```c
int main( void )
{
    uart_init();                                /* 1. console first */
    kprintf( "scratch-os: kernel started\n" );  /* 2. polled print */
    systick_init();                             /* 3. 10 ms tick */
    kprintf( "dropping to unprivileged mode\n" );
    __asm volatile (            /* 4. CONTROL = CONTROL | 1; (nPRIV = 1) */
        "mrs r0, control    \n" /* r0 = CONTROL */
        "orr r0, r0, #1     \n" /* r0 |= 1: set nPRIV */
        "msr control, r0    \n" /* CONTROL = r0: now unprivileged */
        "isb                \n" /* refetch under the new rules */
        : : : "r0", "memory" );
    app_main();                                 /* 5. never returns */
    for ( ;; ) { }                              /* not reached */
}

void app_main( void )
```

```
{
    printf( "app: hello from unprivileged code\n" );
    uint32_t last = 0;                          /* when the uptime was last printed */

    for ( ;; )
    {
        uint32_t now = sys_uptime();
        if ( now - last >= 1000 )               /* one second passed? */
        {
            printf( "uptime: %u ms\n", now );
            last += 1000;
        }
        int c = sys_read();                     /* never waits: -1 = no key */
        if ( c != -1 )
        {
            printf( "key: %c\n", c );
        }
        sleep_ms( 10 );
    }
}
```

Element	Reason
Order: console, tick, drop	printing first; the tick serves `sys_uptime` and `sleep_ms`
`isb`	discards instructions fetched under privileged rules
Clock comparison	counting iterations would drift

```
scratch-os: kernel started
dropping to unprivileged mode
app: hello from unprivileged code
uptime: 1000 ms
key: a
key: b
uptime: 2000 ms
```

The first two lines come from polled `kprintf`, the rest through `printf` → `sys_write` → `svc #1` → `uart_write` → `UART0TX_Handler`. In gdb, `$control` is `0x1` even inside `sys_write_impl` (privileged only because in Handler mode), and `$xpsr & 0x1ff` = 11 (SVCall).

7.8 Kernel Rules: No `svc` Inside the Kernel, Never Wait

Two rules keep the kernel correct; breaking either one stops the system, as the following failures show.

No system calls in kernel code. An `svc` is **synchronous** and cannot stay pending: if not more urgent than the

running code, it **escalates** to HardFault (HFSR bit 30, **FORCED**, e.g. `HFSR=0x40000000`).

Where `svc` executes	Current priority	Result
`app_main`, `main` (Thread mode)	none (lowest)	taken
`SysTick_Handler` / `UART0TX_Handler`	`0xE0` / `0xC0`	taken: SVCall is more urgent and nests
`SVC_Handler` and anything it calls	`0x80`	HardFault
A fault handler	`0x00` or more urgent	HardFault
Between `irq_save` and `irq_restore`	masked (`PRIMASK` = 1)	HardFault

The kernel never waits. If `sys_write_impl` loops until all bytes are accepted, a 130-byte write prints one byte and freezes: only `UART0TX_Handler` (`0xC0`) can drain the buffer, but the CPU is in SVCall (`0x80`), more urgent, so TX and SysTick (`0xE0`) stay pending forever. Hence `sys_write` returns the accepted count and `write_all` waits in **Thread mode**.

> **TWO KERNEL INVARIANTS**
>
> Never block inside a system call (partial results, waiting in user space). Never issue a system call from the kernel (output via polled `kprintf`).

1 Why an Operating System Manages Memory

Memory is a shared resource: the kernel and every task or process it runs all need it at the same time. With respect to memory, an operating system has four jobs.

- **Placement**: decide where the code, data, and stack of each program go, so that they do not overlap. Two programs that both use address `0x20000004` for their own data would destroy each other's values.
- **Sharing**: let programs use the same memory when they should, for example one copy of library code for every program, or a buffer handed to a device.
- **Protection**: stop a program from reading or writing memory that is not its own, whether by mistake (a bad pointer, a stack that grows too far) or on purpose.
- **More programs than memory**: when the programs together need more memory than there is, keep in RAM only the parts in use and store the rest elsewhere.

A flat firmware image, like the kernel built in the previous chapters, does only the first job, and only partly. The linker places every variable, but it places them file after file, with no border between the kernel's data and the data of each task.

```
20000004 B uptime_ms      kernel: millisecond counter
20000008 b tx_buf         kernel: UART transmit buffer
20000054 b a_lines        task A: printed lines
20000058 b b_seconds      task B: reported seconds
```

The output of `arm-none-eabi-nm -n` shows four variables packed together in `.bss`, just above `0x20000000`, a few bytes apart. Nothing marks `a_lines` as "task A only": if task B computed the address `0x20000054` and wrote there, it would change A's variable, and nobody would notice.

1.1 Static Versus Dynamic Allocation

Placement can be decided at two different times. With **static allocation**, every address and every size is fixed at link time by the linker script and the variable definitions; the map file shows the full layout of memory before the program runs, and no holes can appear because nothing is ever freed. The price is flexibility: a size cannot change at run time, and objects whose size is known only at run time cannot be created.

With **dynamic allocation**, memory is handed out at run time from a **heap**, through calls such as `malloc( n )` and `free( p )`. The layout then depends on the order of the calls, which is usually unpredictable. After many allocations and frees, the free memory is split into small holes between blocks still in use.

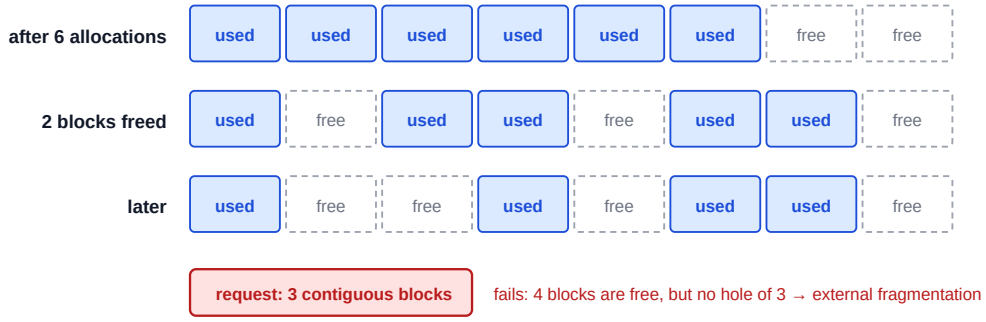


Figure 5.1: *External fragmentation. Four blocks are free, but no three of them are contiguous, so a request for three blocks fails.*

This is **external fragmentation**: enough free space exists, but in the wrong shape. Dynamic allocation has two more problems in an embedded system. It can fail at run time, when the heap is exhausted or too fragmented, and a device in the field usually has nobody to read the error. Its execution time is also not constant, because `malloc` may have to search many blocks, which is a problem for code with deadlines. For these reasons the kernel described here allocates everything statically.

1.2 The Memory-Management Spectrum

Memory-management schemes range from very simple to very capable. Two questions classify each of them: is the address used by the program **translated** into another address before it reaches memory, and does the hardware **protect** memory by stopping forbidden accesses?

Scheme	Translation	Protection	Where
Flat	No	No	Simple firmware: one address space for everybody
Static partitions	No	No	A fixed slice of RAM per task, decided at link time
MPU	No	Yes	Microcontrollers: hardware checks every access against a few regions
Paging (MMU)	Yes	Yes	Linux, Windows, macOS: each process has its own address space
Virtual memory	Yes	Yes	Paging plus a disk: programs can use more memory than the RAM

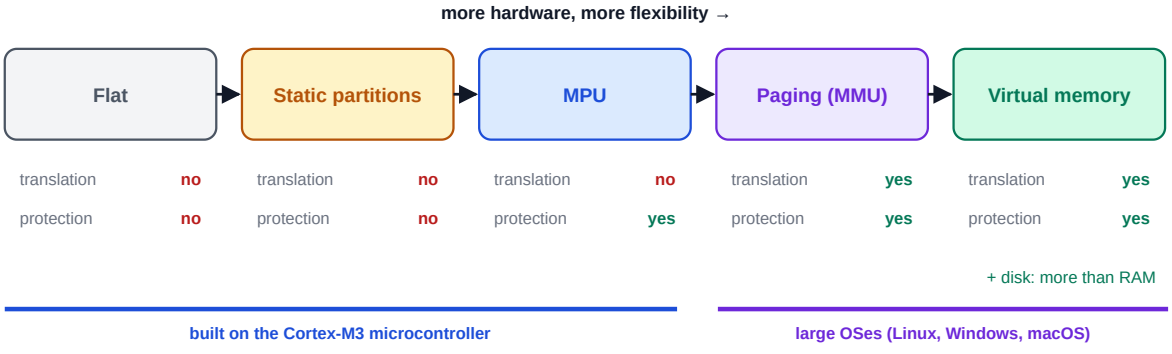


Figure 5.2: *The memory-management spectrum. Each step to the right needs more hardware and gives more flexibility.*

The first three steps can be built on a Cortex-M3 microcontroller; paging and virtual memory need an MMU and are described here as theory, because they explain what a microcontroller does differently.

1.3 Unprotected Memory: A Rogue Task

```
extern volatile uint32_t uptime_ms;     /* the kernel's counter */


printf( "B: writing to the kernel's uptime counter\n" );
uptime_ms = 0x12345678;                 /* a store into kernel memory */
```

Task B declares the kernel's counter with `extern`, so the linker gives it the real address, and then stores a value into it. The store succeeds: one second later B prints an uptime of 305 420 896 ms, because `0x12345678` is 305 419 896 and the kernel keeps counting from there. Task B has changed the kernel's clock for everyone.

Nothing stopped the write even though task B runs unprivileged. Unprivileged mode blocks only some instructions (such as `msr` to `CONTROL`) and access to the System Control Space; it does not check ordinary loads and stores to RAM. On the `mps2-an385` board the memories themselves have no notion of owner either: the bus answers every load and store from any code. A bug in one task can therefore silently break the kernel or another task, and the damage shows up far from the code that caused it. Stopping it requires hardware that checks every access, which is the job of an MMU or an MPU.

2 Paging and Virtual Memory

Large operating systems isolate processes with **paging**. A program uses **virtual addresses** (VA), the addresses in its pointers and instructions; the memory chips see **physical addresses** (PA), the addresses on the bus. Paging maps one to the other.

2.1 Pages, Frames, and the MMU

The virtual address space is divided into equal blocks called **pages**, often 4 KiB, and physical memory into **frames** of the same size. Any page can be placed in any frame. A **page table**, one per **process**, records which frame holds each page. Each entry also has a **valid** bit (is the page in a frame at all?) and permission bits: may the page be read, written, or executed, and may user code access it or only the kernel?

The **MMU** (Memory Management Unit) is the hardware that translates every address and checks its permissions on every load, store, and instruction fetch. This must be done in hardware, because doing it in software for every access would be far too slow. Only the **page number** is translated; the **offset** inside the page is copied unchanged, because a page and its frame have the same size. With 4 KiB pages the offset is the low 12 bits of the address ($2^{12} = 4096$).

2.2 Two-Level Page Tables

With 32-bit addresses and 4 KiB pages, the page number has 20 bits. A single flat table would need 2^{20} entries of 4 bytes, that is 4 MiB per process, even for a tiny program. Real systems therefore split the page number again and use two levels. A register called **PTBR** (page-table base register) holds the address of the current process's **page directory**; each directory entry points to a second-level page table.

```
0x00403007 = 0000 0000 0100 0000 0011 0000 0000 0111
           = 0000000001 | 0000000011 | 000000000111
             dir = 0x001  tbl = 0x003  offset = 0x007
```

The top 10 bits select the directory entry, the next 10 bits the table entry, and the low 12 bits are the offset. To translate `0x00403007`, the MMU reads directory entry 1 at `PTBR + 1 × 4`, which gives the table address, say `0x00021000`. It then reads entry 3 of that table at `0x00021000 + 3 × 4 = 0x0002100C`, which gives the frame, say `0x0009A000`, with the valid bit set. The physical address is the frame plus the offset: `0x0009A007`.

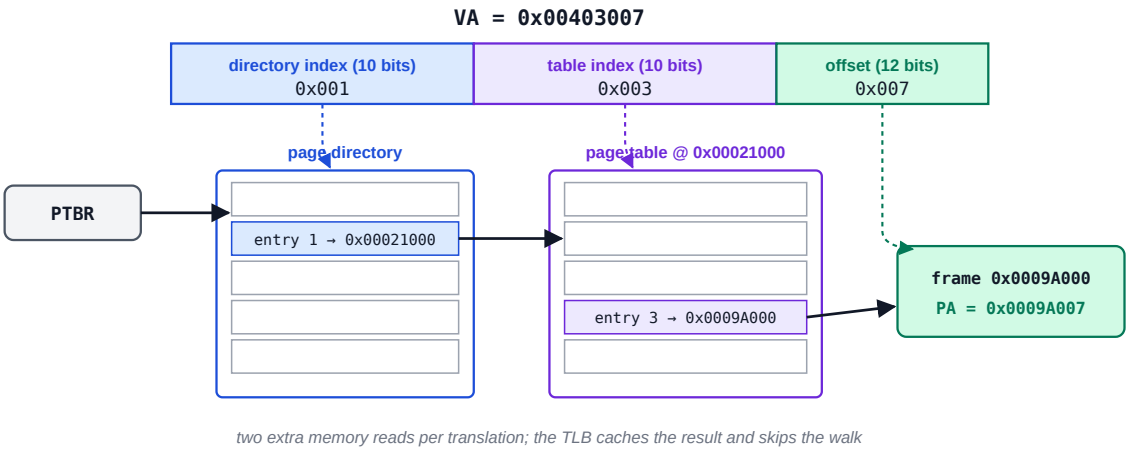


Figure 5.3: *Translation of 0x00403007 with a two-level page table. Each level costs one extra memory read.*

Two levels pay off because a second-level table exists only where memory is used. A small process needs one directory and a few tables instead of a flat 4 MiB table made almost entirely of invalid entries.

2.3 The TLB and the Effective Access Time

The walk costs two extra memory reads for every access the program makes, which would make memory three times slower. The **TLB** (Translation Lookaside Buffer) is a small, fast cache inside the MMU that keeps recent translations (page number → frame, with permissions). On a **TLB hit** the frame comes straight from the TLB; on a **miss** the MMU walks the tables and stores the result. When the OS changes a page table or switches to another process, it must **flush** the stale TLB entries, otherwise a process could reach the frames of the previous one.

The cost of paging is measured by the **effective access time** (EAT), the average time of one memory access including translation. With memory access time m, hit ratio h, and a two-level table, a hit costs m and a miss costs $3m$:

$$EAT = h \cdot m + (1 - h) \cdot 3m = m\,(3 - 2h)$$

The slowdown over plain memory is $2(1-h)$: every 1% of misses makes memory 2% slower. With $m = 10$ ns, a hit ratio of 0.80 gives 14 ns (+40%), while 0.99 gives 10.2 ns (+2%). Processors with 64-bit addresses use four table levels, so a miss costs $5m$ and the slowdown doubles to $4(1-h)$.

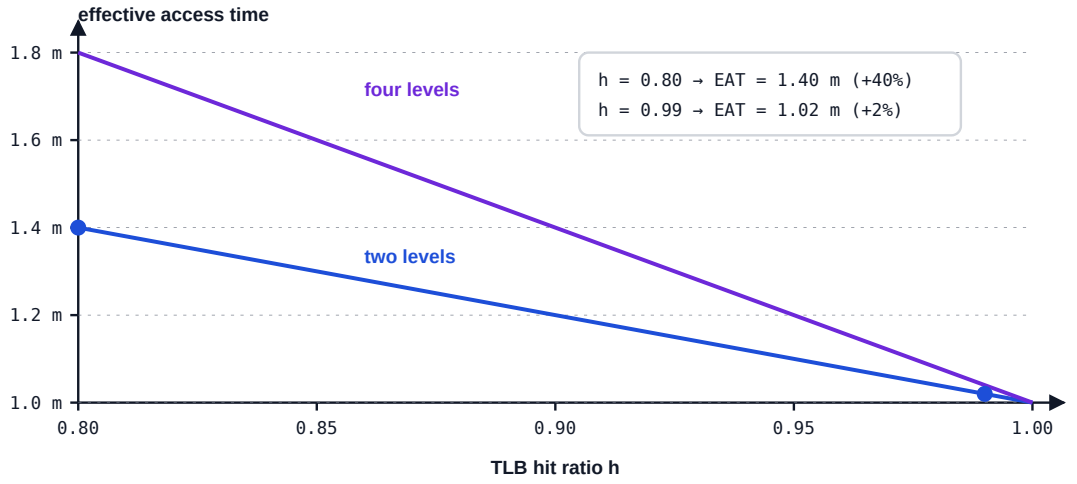


Figure 5.4: *Effective access time as a function of the TLB hit ratio, for two-level and four-level page tables.*

The hit ratio is high in practice because of **locality**: a loop that reads an array misses once on the first word of each 4 KiB page and then hits on the other 1023 words. The **TLB reach** (entries × page size, for example 64 × 4 KiB = 256 KiB) tells how much memory can be accessed without misses. After a flush the TLB is empty, so the same code runs slower right after a context switch. For a real-time task this variation is **jitter**: the time of an access depends on what ran before.

2.4 Page Faults

When the walk finds an entry whose valid bit is clear, or the access breaks the entry's permissions, the MMU raises a **page fault**:

1. the MMU stops the access and raises an exception, saving the faulting address;
2. the OS checks its records of the process's memory: if the address is not part of the program, or the access is not allowed, the program has a bug and the OS terminates it;
3. if the address is legal but the page is not in RAM, the OS finds a free frame, reads the page from disk, fills in the page-table entry, and sets the valid bit;
4. the handler returns and the hardware **restarts** the faulting instruction, which now succeeds.

The instruction is restarted, not skipped, because its load or store never happened. A page fault that reads from disk costs milliseconds, while a memory access costs nanoseconds. With page-fault rate p:

$$EAT = (1 - p) \cdot m + p \cdot t_{fault}$$

With $m = 200$ ns and $t_{fault} = 8$ ms, one fault every thousand accesses makes the machine about forty times slower, and keeping the slowdown under 10% requires fewer than one fault every 400 000 accesses. A single fault also stops the program for milliseconds at an unpredictable moment, which a real-time system cannot accept.

2.5 Virtual Memory

Paging combined with the disk is **virtual memory**. It gives **isolation**: each process has its own page table, so the same virtual address lands in different frames for different processes, and a process cannot even name another process's memory. It also gives **more memory than RAM**: pages not in use wait on disk and are brought back by page faults. Virtual memory therefore handles both protection and the fourth job of the OS, but it needs an MMU, page tables in RAM, and a disk.

A microcontroller has none of these, and it has good reasons not to: an MMU costs silicon area and energy, TLB misses make timing unpredictable, and there is no disk to page to. The Cortex-M3 offers instead an optional **MPU**, which checks addresses against a few regions without translating them. Its regions, permissions, and registers are described in the MPU section of the chapter on the ARM Cortex-M3 architecture. The rest of this chapter builds protection with it, in two steps: first static partitions, which give each task a block of memory with the shape the MPU needs, then the MPU itself.

3 Static Task Partitions

A **partition** is a slice of RAM that belongs to a single task and holds only that task's stack and variables.

3.1 Partition Rules

The partitions follow five rules.

- **They are fixed**: the linker chooses them at link time (static allocation), and no task is created, grown, or moved at run time.
- **Each one is 4 KB and aligned to 4 KB**: the size is a power of two and the start address a multiple of it, such as `0x20000000` or `0x20001000`. This is exactly the shape of an MPU region.
- **They cover RAM only**: code, constants, and string literals stay in FLASH, shared by the kernel and all tasks. Both tasks call the same `printf`, and one copy of its code is enough.
- **The stack is at the bottom**: the stack takes the lowest 1 KB, and the task's variables come right above it.
- **The kernel keeps the rest**: the kernel's `.data` and `.bss` come after the partitions, and the kernel stack stays at the top of RAM.

The position of the stack matters. The stack grows down, so a stack that grows too far leaves the partition below its start instead of overwriting the task's own variables. With the MPU enabled, that first out-of-partition store causes a fault; with the stack at the top, an overflow would silently overwrite the task's variables, and no protection hardware could tell that write from a legitimate one.

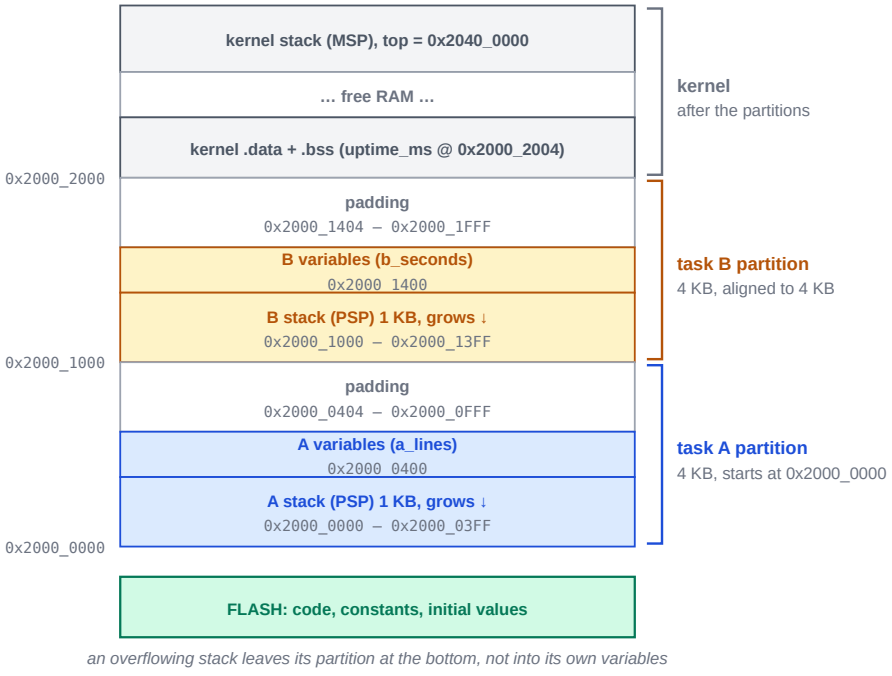


Figure 5.5: *RAM layout with two task partitions. Each 4 KB partition holds a 1 KB stack at the bottom, the task's variables, and padding.*

Power-of-two sizes have a cost: a task that needs 1.1 KB still gets 4 KB. On a microcontroller with a few hundred KiB of RAM and a few tasks, this waste is usually acceptable.

3.2 Linker Script Constructs for Partitions

```
.task_a_data : { ... } > RAM AT > FLASH       /* runs in RAM, initial bytes stored in FLASH */
_task_a_data_load = LOADADDR(.task_a_data);  /* the FLASH address of those bytes           */
.task_a_stack ALIGN(ORIGIN(RAM), 4096) (NOLOAD) : { ... } > RAM
*task_a.o(.data .data.* .bss .bss.* COMMON)  /* these input sections, from task_a.o only */
```

The partitions reuse the linker-script constructs of the boot chapter and add placement by file.

Construct	Meaning
`> RAM AT > FLASH`	The section runs in RAM (VMA) but its initial bytes are stored in FLASH (LMA), as for `.data`
`LOADADDR(section)`	The load address of a section, here the FLASH address of the task's initial values
`(NOLOAD)`	Reserves addresses but stores nothing in the image: right for stacks and padding
`ALIGN(x, 4096)`	`x` rounded up to a multiple of 4096; written before the colon, it sets the section start
`. = start + 4096`	Moves the location counter to the end of the partition
`*task_a.o(...)`	Takes the listed input sections from the object file `task_a.o` only
`ASSERT(cond, "msg")`	Makes the link fail if `cond` is false

A file-name pattern in front of the parentheses selects input sections from one object file only, so every variable written in `src/task_a.c` goes to A's partition without any special marking in the source. Three details make the rules work. First, **the first matching rule wins**: the generic `*(.data*)` and `*(.bss*)` rules of the kernel would also match `task_a.o`, so the partition rules must come before them in the script. Second, the task's `.bss` is placed inside the loaded section together with `.data`: its zeros are then stored in FLASH (a few bytes), and a single copy loop initialises every task variable. Third, the first partition must use `ALIGN(ORIGIN(RAM), 4096)`, because right after `.text` the location counter still holds a FLASH address.

3.3 The Partition Block

```
    /* Task A partition, 4 KB: [ stack 1 KB | A's .data + .bss | padding ] */
    .task_a_stack ALIGN(ORIGIN(RAM), 4096) (NOLOAD) : {
        _task_a_part_start = .;            /* partition start = stack bottom */
        . = . + TASK_STACK_SIZE;           /* reserve the 1 KB stack */
        _task_a_stack_top = .;             /* the stack grows down from here */
    } > RAM
    .task_a_data : {
        . = ALIGN(4);
        _task_a_data_start = .;            /* run address (RAM) */
        *task_a.o(.data .data.* .bss .bss.* COMMON)   /* all of task_a.o's variables */
```

```
        . = ALIGN(4);
        _task_a_data_end = .;
    } > RAM AT > FLASH                      /* runs in RAM, image stored in FLASH */
    _task_a_data_load = LOADADDR(.task_a_data);   /* FLASH address of the image */
    .task_a_pad (NOLOAD) : {
        . = _task_a_part_start + PART_SIZE;   /* jump to the partition end */
        _task_a_part_end = .;
    } > RAM

    /* Task B partition: the same three sections, in the next 4 KB. */
    .task_b_stack ALIGN(4096) (NOLOAD) : { ... } > RAM
    .task_b_data : { ... } > RAM AT > FLASH
    .task_b_pad (NOLOAD) : { ... } > RAM

    /* Link-time guards: each task's variables must fit in its 4 KB. */
    ASSERT(_task_a_data_end <= _task_a_part_end, "task A data does not fit in its partition")
    ASSERT(_task_b_data_end <= _task_b_part_end, "task B data does not fit in its partition")
```

Each partition is made of three output sections, placed before the kernel's `.data` and `.bss`, with `PART_SIZE = 0x1000` and `TASK_STACK_SIZE = 0x400`. `.task_a_stack` starts at the first 4 KB boundary at or above `0x20000000`, marks the start of the partition, reserves 1 KB, and marks the stack top at `0x20000400`; it is `NOLOAD` because a stack has no initial content. `.task_a_data` follows immediately and collects every variable of `task_a.o`; the two `ALIGN(4)` keep both ends on a word boundary, because the copy loop copies whole words. `.task_a_pad` stores nothing and only moves the location counter to the end of the partition, so the next partition starts after A's full 4 KB. Task B repeats the three sections, with `ALIGN(4096)` alone because the location counter is already in RAM. The two `ASSERT` lines catch a task that grows too big at build time rather than at run time.

3.4 Checking the Layout

```
00000dd0 A _task_a_data_load
20000000 B _task_a_part_start
20000400 B _task_a_stack_top
20000400 d a_lines
20001000 B _task_a_part_end
20001000 B _task_b_part_start
20001400 B _task_b_stack_top
20001400 d b_seconds
20002000 B _task_b_part_end
20002004 B uptime_ms
```

The `nm -n` output confirms the layout: task A owns `0x20000000` – `0x20001000` and task B `0x20001000` – `0x20002000`, both 4 KB and 4 KB-aligned, and the kernel's `uptime_ms` has moved after the partitions, to `0x20002004`. `a_lines` and `_task_a_stack_top` have the same address, `0x20000400`, but they do not overlap. The stack top is an exclusive bound: the Cortex-M stack is full descending, so with `sp = 0x20000400` the first

push writes at `0x200003FC`, and the word at `0x20000400` is free for the first variable. The map file shows the same layout from the linker's point of view, with a FLASH load address for each `.task_X_data` section and none for the `NOLOAD` stacks.

3.5 Initialising Partition Variables

```
void partition_init( const struct task *t )
{
    const uint32_t *src = t->data_load;     /* initial values, in FLASH */
    uint32_t *dst = t->data_start;          /* the variables, in RAM */
    while ( dst < t->data_end )
        *dst++ = *src++;                    /* copy one word, move both on */
}
```

The variables of a task run in RAM but start in FLASH, so the kernel must copy them before the task runs for the first time. `partition_init` is the same loop that `Reset_Handler` runs for the kernel's `.data`, executed once per task with the addresses stored in its `struct task`, which the kernel fills from the linker symbols. No separate zeroing loop is needed, because the task's `.bss` is part of the loaded section.

3.6 Partitions Arrange but Do Not Enforce

Running the rogue task again after the change gives exactly the same result as before: task B still corrupts `uptime_ms`, now at `0x20002004`. The linker decides only *where* things are; at run time a store to `0x20002004` is an ordinary store, and nothing compares it with B's partition. What has changed is the shape of memory: each task's memory is now a single aligned 4 KB block, so one hardware rule per task is enough to describe what that task may touch.

4 Starting and Ending Tasks

A task runs in unprivileged Thread mode on its own stack. Starting and ending such a task requires the two stack pointers of the Cortex-M3 and the exception return mechanism, both described in the chapter on the ARM Cortex-M3 architecture.

4.1 Kernel Stack and Task Stacks

Each task's stack is a **PSP** stack inside its own partition, while the kernel and every exception handler use the **MSP** stack at the top of RAM. A running task has `CONTROL = 3`: `nPRIV = 1` (unprivileged) and `SPSEL = 1` (PSP). The stack must lie inside the partition because it holds the task's local variables, return addresses, and the exception frame that the hardware pushes on every interrupt; with the stack inside the partition, the MPU can restrict the task to its own 4 KB. Because Handler mode always uses MSP, the kernel's own work never runs on a task's stack.

4.2 Entering a Task with a Fake Exception Frame

The kernel cannot start a task with a function call. When it starts a task it is running inside the SVC handler, in Handler mode, privileged, and on MSP; a call would keep that mode, privilege, and stack, and the `svc` would never end. The only hardware mechanism that changes mode, privilege, and stack in a single step is the **exception return**. The kernel therefore **fakes an interruption**: it writes on the task's stack the frame that the hardware would have pushed if the task had been interrupted just before its first instruction, points PSP at it, and returns from the `svc` with `EXC_RETURN = 0xFFFFFFFD` (Thread mode, PSP).

Word	Address (task A)	Register	Value written
`frame[0..4]`	`0x200003E0` – `0x200003F3`	`r0` – `r3`, `r12`	0
`frame[5]`	`0x200003F4`	`lr`	`task_exit`
`frame[6]`	`0x200003F8`	`pc`	`t->entry & ~1`, the address of `task_a`
`frame[7]`	`0x200003FC`	`xPSR`	`0x01000000`, Thumb bit only

```
__asm volatile (
    "msr psp, %0        \n" /* PSP = frame */
    "mrs r1, control    \n" /* r1 = CONTROL */
    "orr r1, r1, #1     \n" /* r1 |= 1: set nPRIV */
    "msr control, r1    \n" /* CONTROL = r1 */
    "isb                \n" /* make the new CONTROL take effect now */
    : : "r" ( frame ) : "r1", "memory" );
return EXC_RETURN_THREAD_PSP;              /* 0xFFFFFFFD */
```

`task_launch` first records the current task, sets the MPU region for its partition, and copies its variables with `partition_init`. It then writes the 8-word frame at `t->stack_top - 8` and runs the assembly block, which is needed because C cannot name PSP or `CONTROL`. The returned value travels back to `SVC_Handler`, which ends the exception with it. The hardware pops the 8 words from PSP and continues at the popped `pc`, `task_a`, in

Thread mode, unprivileged, on PSP.

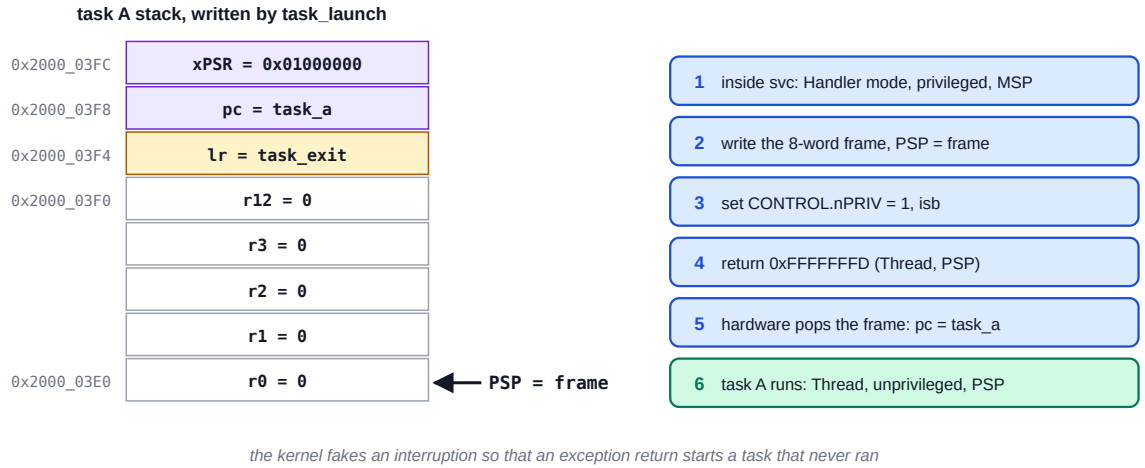


Figure 5.6: *Starting a task. The kernel writes a fake exception frame on the task's stack, and the exception return "resumes" a task that has never run.*

Several details of the frame are essential. Setting `nPRIV` inside the handler has no effect until the return, because Handler mode is always privileged; after the return `CONTROL` is 3, since the exception return with `0xFFFFFFFD` sets `SPSEL`. The `xPSR` word must have bit 24 (the Thumb bit) set, otherwise the first instruction raises a UsageFault (`INVSTATE`). The `pc` word has bit 0 cleared, because it must be a real instruction address rather than a code pointer. Finally, `lr` holds `task_exit` , so a task that simply returns from its function lands in the exit path.

4.3 Choosing the Stack in SVC_Handler

```
    tst lr, #4                  /* flags = lr & 4: is bit 2 set? */
    ite eq                      /* if ((lr & 4) == 0) ... else ... */
    mrseq r0, msp               /*     frame = MSP;  // came from main() */
    mrsne r0, psp               /* else frame = PSP;  // came from a task */
    mov r1, lr                  /* exc_return = lr: second argument */
    bl svc_dispatch             /* r0 = svc_dispatch(frame, exc_return) */
    bx r0                       /* return_from_exception(r0) */
```

With tasks, `svc` can arrive from two places: from a task, on PSP, and once from `main` , on MSP. Bit 2 of `EXC_RETURN` tells which stack holds the stacked frame. `tst lr, #4` sets the Z flag when the bit is 0, and `ite eq` (if-then-else) makes exactly one of the two following `mrs` instructions execute. The entry then calls `svc_dispatch` with the frame and the `EXC_RETURN` value, copying `lr` first because `bl` overwrites it, and ends the exception with the value the dispatcher returns. In pseudo-C: `frame = (lr & 4) ? PSP : MSP; lr = svc_dispatch(frame, lr); return_from_exception(lr);` .

Returning a value is what lets a system call return *somewhere else*. Ordinary services (`SYS_WRITE` , `SYS_READ` , `SYS_UPTIME`) write their result into `frame[0]` and return `exc_return` unchanged, so the exception goes back to the caller. `SYS_START_TASKS` , issued once by `main` with `svc #5` , returns into the first task; `SYS_EXIT` returns into the next task or back to `main` . Each `svc` still ends at once: the kernel never waits inside a handler.

4.4 Ending a Task

```
sys_exit:
    svc #4                      /* svc(SYS_EXIT) */
    b sys_exit                  /* never reached; if it were, ask again */

task_exit:
    bl sys_exit                 /* sys_exit(); it does not come back */
    b task_exit                 /* never reached; if it were, try again */
```

A task ends either by calling `sys_exit()` or by returning from its function, in which case it lands in `task_exit`, the address placed in `frame[5]`. On the kernel side, `SYS_EXIT` from a task calls `task_exit_current`:

```
uint32_t task_exit_current( void )
{
    kprintf( "task %s exited\n", tasks[current].name );
    if ( current + 1 < ( int ) NUM_TASKS )
        return task_launch( current + 1 );      /* start the next task */
    current = -1;                               /* no task runs any more */
    /* asm block: CONTROL = CONTROL & ~1;  clear nPRIV, then isb */
    return EXC_RETURN_THREAD_MSP;               /* 0xFFFFFFF9: back to main() */
}
```

When task A ends, the function launches task B: it moves the MPU region to B's partition and returns B's fake frame with `0xFFFFFFFD`, so the exception returns straight into B. When the last task ends, the kernel clears `nPRIV` and returns `0xFFFFFFF9` (Thread mode, MSP), so `main` continues after its `svc #5`. Clearing `nPRIV` is essential: `main` runs in Thread mode, and with `nPRIV` still at 1 it would run unprivileged and fault on its first access to the UART. It could not fix this by itself, because unprivileged code cannot write `CONTROL`.

5 Protecting Tasks with the MPU

With the partitions in place, two MPU regions are enough to describe what the running task may touch. The region encoding (`RBAR` , `RASR` , `SIZE` , `AP` , `XN`) is described in the MPU section of the Cortex-M3 chapter.

5.1 Two Regions per Task

```
void mpu_init( void )
{
    /* Region 0 = FLASH: base 0, 4 MB = 2^22 B, read-only, code may run. */
    MPU->RBAR = 0x00000000 | MPU_RBAR_VALID | 0;          /* = 0x00000010 */
    MPU->RASR = MPU_RASR_AP( MPU_AP_RO ) | MPU_RASR_C
              | MPU_RASR_SIZE( 22 ) | MPU_RASR_ENABLE;    /* = 0x0602002B */
    /* MPU on. PRIVDEFENA: the kernel keeps the default memory map. */
    MPU->CTRL = MPU_CTRL_ENABLE | MPU_CTRL_PRIVDEFENA;     /* = 5 */
    __asm volatile ( "dsb" ::: "memory" );
    __asm volatile ( "isb" ::: "memory" );
}

void mpu_set_task_region( uint32_t base, uint32_t size )
{
    uint32_t log2_size = __builtin_ctz( size );           /* 4096 -> 12 */
    /* Region 1 = the partition: read-write, never executable (XN). */
    MPU->RBAR = base | MPU_RBAR_VALID | 1;                 /* B: 0x20001011 */
    MPU->RASR = MPU_RASR_XN | MPU_RASR_AP( MPU_AP_FULL_RW )
              | MPU_RASR_S | MPU_RASR_C
              | MPU_RASR_SIZE( log2_size ) | MPU_RASR_ENABLE; /* 0x13060017 */
    __asm volatile ( "dsb" ::: "memory" );
    __asm volatile ( "isb" ::: "memory" );
}
```

`mpu_init` runs once, before the first task starts. It makes **region 0** cover the 4 MB of FLASH as read-only and executable for everyone, and enables the MPU with `PRIVDEFENA` , so that privileged code (the kernel, `main` , and every handler) keeps the default memory map. `mpu_set_task_region` is called by `task_launch` for every task. It points **region 1** at the partition of the task about to run, as read/write and execute-never. `__builtin_ctz` (count trailing zeros) computes $\log_2$ of the power-of-two size, and the `SIZE` macro applies the encoding. The `dsb` and `isb` barriers make sure that no later access is checked against the old regions.

The "MPU state" of a task is therefore a single value, the base of region 1. Everything else (the other task's partition, kernel data, kernel stack, and peripherals) has no region and is forbidden to unprivileged code. A correct program prints exactly the same lines as before: its code and constants are in FLASH, its variables, stack, and the `printf` buffer (a local variable) are in its partition, and every access to the UART happens inside the privileged kernel through system calls.

5.2 MemManage Reports

```
uint32_t cfsr = SCB->CFSR;
kprintf( "MemManage: CFSR=0x%x\n", cfsr );
if ( cfsr & SCB_CFSR_MMARVALID )                /* MMFAR is valid only then */
    kprintf( "  address 0x%x\n", SCB->MMFAR );
if ( cfsr & SCB_CFSR_DACCVIOL )
    kprintf( "  cause: data access\n" );
if ( cfsr & SCB_CFSR_IACCVIOL )
    kprintf( "  cause: instruction fetch\n" );
if ( cfsr & SCB_CFSR_MSTKERR )
    kprintf( "  cause: stacking\n" );
```

`MemManage_Handler` runs privileged and on MSP, so it can always print. It reads `CFSR` once, so that every test sees the same value, prints `MMFAR` only when `MMARVALID` is set, and tests each cause separately, because several bits can be set at the same time. With the MPU enabled, the rogue store never happens: the report reads `CFSR = 0x82` (`MMARVALID` + `DACCVIOL`) with address `0x20002004`, which `arm-none-eabi-nm` identifies as `uptime_ms`. The fault points at the exact instruction and variable involved, instead of letting the damage show up later and elsewhere.

A **stack overflow** is caught in the same way. A recursion that needs about 4 KB of stack in task B, which has only 1 KB, produces `CFSR = 0x92` with address `0x20000FDC`: `0x80 + 0x10 + 0x02`, that is `MMARVALID` + `MSTKERR` + `DACCVIOL`. The address is 36 bytes below B's partition, inside A's partition, which has no region while B runs. The stacking cause appears because the CPU also tried to push the exception frame on the overflowing PSP; the frame is lost, but the handler runs on MSP and its report is still correct. Without the MPU, the same program keeps corrupting memory and ends much later with a misleading `UsageFault` (`INVSTATE`), far from the real cause.

5.3 Why the Kernel Must Check Pointers

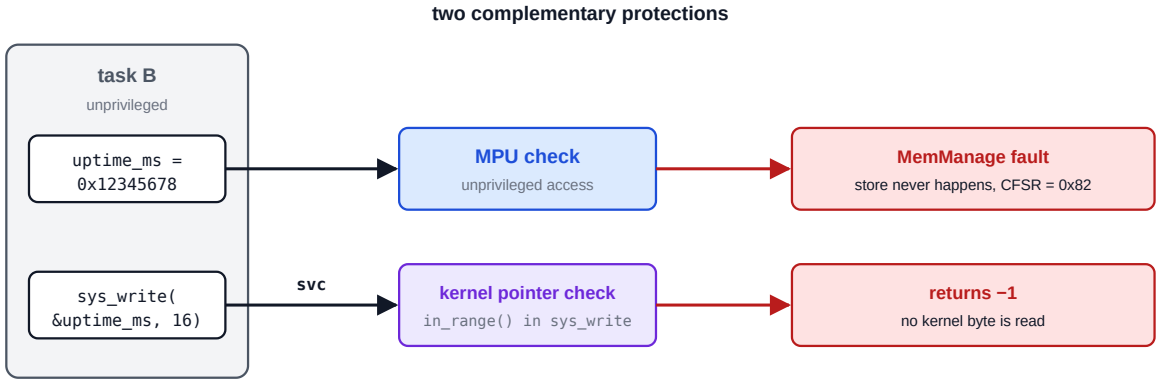
```
int r = sys_write( (const char *) &uptime_ms, 16 );
```

The MPU stops what a task does by itself, but not what a task asks the kernel to do. A task that passes a kernel address to `sys_write` makes the kernel read that memory on its behalf: the handler runs privileged, `PRIVDEFENA` gives it the whole map, and the call prints 16 bytes of kernel data (the counter and the start of the UART buffer). The kernel must therefore check every pointer it receives against what *that task* could access by itself.

```
static int in_range( uint32_t p, uint32_t len, uint32_t start, uint32_t end )
{
    return p >= start && p <= end && len <= end - p;
}
```

```c
/* in sys_write_impl: accept the buffer only inside the caller's
 * partition or inside FLASH; the kernel itself (no task) is trusted. */
const struct task *t = task_current();
if ( t != 0
     && !in_range( a0, len, t->part_start, t->part_end )
     && !in_range( a0, len, 0x00000000, 0x00400000 ) )
    return ( uint32_t ) -1;
```

`in_range` checks that `[p, p + len)` lies entirely inside `[start, end)`. The obvious test `p + len <= end` is wrong, because `p + len` can wrap around 2^{32}: with `p = 0x20001F00` and `len = 0xFFFFFF00`, the sum wraps to `0x20001E00` and the check would pass, letting the kernel read almost all of memory. Once `p <= end` is known, `end - p` cannot wrap, so `len <= end - p` is always correct. `sys_write_impl` accepts a buffer only if it lies entirely in the caller's partition or entirely in FLASH, where string constants live; otherwise it returns −1 before reading anything. The task receives an error it can handle, not a fault, and the task's own `printf` still works because it formats its text in a buffer on the task's stack.



the MPU stops what a task does itself; the kernel stops what a task asks the privileged kernel to do

Figure 5.7: *Two complementary protections. The MPU stops direct accesses by unprivileged code; the kernel's pointer checks stop indirect accesses made through system calls.*